

Government to upgrade 125 school libraries with digital tools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government will upgrade 125 school libraries with 20 digital devices, headphones, a kiosk and a charging cart, according to the Economic Survey of Delhi 2025-26. Besides, it has identified 7.5 lakh students in classes 1 to 8 with learning gaps.

The survey said a baseline assessment conducted in September 2025 identified gaps in foundational literacy and numeracy, forming the basis for academic interventions.

According to the survey, students were classified into four categories — Beginner, Emerging,

Progressive, and Proficient — and interventions using readiness modules developed by SCERT are being implemented for classes 2 to 8 after mid-term exams. The efforts are being carried out under the NIPUN Sankalp programme.

The survey said 125 school libraries will be upgraded in the current academic session, with each to be equipped with 20 digital devices, 20 headphones, one library kiosk, one charging cart and one printer.

It said that the Directorate of Education is continuing its focus on inclusive education, with 879 children with severe or profound disabilities enrolled in home-

based education programmes in 2025. Under the measure, 286 out-of-school children were mainstreamed into schools, while a functional curriculum for children with intellectual disabilities was developed and implemented in 100 schools from pre-primary to class 8.

To streamline admissions of out-of-school children, 2,333 special admission cells have been established, the survey said, adding that 4,258 children with disabilities participated in 12 para-sports disciplines. It noted that 46 per cent of children with special needs have obtained Unique Disability ID (UDID) cards, and more such cards are being

issued. The survey said the Government will set up 8,777 smart classrooms by the end of March this year. According to the

survey, under the Mahamana Pandit Madan Mohan Malviya Vidya Shakti Mission, structured competitive examination coach-

ing will be provided to 2,200 students annually, with 350 seats reserved for girls.

Under the Lal Bahadur Shastri Scholarship Scheme, ₹2,500 per student was disbursed to 34,880 meritorious students. The revised uniform subsidy provides ₹1,250 for Nursery to class 5, ₹1,500 for classes 6 to 8, and ₹1,700 for classes 4 to 12 to ease financial burden on families, it said.

Under the Mukhya mantri Khel Protsahan Yojana, cash awards for Olympic and Paralympic medal winners were increased from ₹3 crore, ₹2 crore and ₹1 crore to ₹7 crore, ₹5 crore and ₹3 crore for gold, silver and bronze.

Incentives for Asian and Para-

Asian Games medal winners have been raised from ₹1 crore, ₹75 lakh and ₹50 lakh to ₹3 crore, ₹2 crore and ₹1 crore.

For Commonwealth and Para-Commonwealth Games, these have been increased from ₹50 lakh, ₹40 lakh and ₹30 lakh to ₹2 crore, ₹1.5 crore and ₹1 crore, the survey reported.

The survey said that the Dr APJ Abdul Kalam language labs launched on a pilot basis in 100 schools in the current academic year are expected to benefit nearly 60,000 students of classes 6, 9, and 11 with teaching of German, French, Spanish, besides English, Hindi, and Sanskrit.

DU mandates 72-hour prior notice for campus protests

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University has mandated that details of any proposed protest or gathering on campus be submitted at least 72 hours in advance to the university authorities and local police, an official notice issued on Monday said.

The directive comes days after a one-month ban on protests imposed by the university on February 17 following a student march that turned violent on the north campus during which a female journalist was allegedly assaulted.

The notice, issued by the Office of the Proctor, is addressed to students, teachers, staff, and other stakeholders. It said organisers must submit a signed hard copy of their application to the university proctor's office and the concerned local police authorities, including the deputy commissioner of police and station house

officer of the respective area.

Delhi University (DU) Proctor Manoj Kumar Singh said the application must include details such as organiser's name, college or department, contact details, nature and duration of the event, logistical requirements, list of speakers, and expected number of participants.

According to the notice, these details must be submitted 72 hours before any assembly, gathering, protest, sit-in, march, procession, or similar activity on campus.

The notice also clarified that electronic communication, including posters, pam-

phlets, social media posts, or WhatsApp messages, will not be treated as official notice or permission.

"Organisers and participants are strictly prohibited from inviting, bringing, or permitting external individuals (ie, persons not enrolled as students at Delhi University) to participate in or join any such activity within the campus," it added.

The notice warned that any violation would invite disciplinary action against organisers, participants, and collaborators, including rustication, expulsion, or police action.

Delhi airport saw India's highest foreign arrivals in 2024

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi airport handled around 32 lakh foreign tourist arrivals in 2024, the highest in the country, according to the Economic Survey of Delhi 2025-26 presented on Monday.

The national Capital recorded 32,24,675 foreign visitors at the Indira Gandhi International Airport in 2024, the survey's data showed.

However, in terms of total foreign tourist arrival — which includes people visiting the city after landing at other places — Delhi stood sixth across India with 1.999 million such visitors in 2024.

Delhi generates nearly 11,862 tonnes of municipal solid waste every day, while the processing capacity is 7,641 tonnes per day, leaving a significant waste-processing gap of around 4,200 tonnes, according to the Delhi Economic Survey 2025-26 was presented on Monday.

The total waste generated daily, around 11,500 tonnes, comes from areas under the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), while 300 tonnes are generated in NDMC areas and 62 tonnes in the Delhi Cantonment Board. A bulk of it continues to strain the city's processing capacity and landfill infrastructure, it said further.

The survey stated that waste collection has reached 100 per cent across all three civic bodies, indicating that almost all garbage generated in the city is being lifted on a daily basis. On the processing front, Delhi currently has a total installed capacity of 7,641 tonnes per day (TPD), which is about 64.4 per cent of the waste generated. Actual pro-

Delhi faces 4,200 tonne daily waste-processing gap

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
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cessing stands slightly lower at 7,460.3 tonnes per day, or 62.9 per cent, the survey said. However, segregation at the source remains uneven. While NDMC areas have achieved about 92 per cent segregation and cantonment areas report up to 90 per cent in civil pockets, MCD areas average only about 59 per cent, with targets set to reach full segregation by January 2027.

The survey highlighted a significant gap: a waste-processing capacity shortfall of over 4,200 tonnes per day and an actual processing gap of around 4,401 tonnes per day.

Highlighting the proposed waste disposal and processing facilities, the

PAC flags major gaps in Delhi's anti-pollution fight

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's Public Accounts Committee (PAC) has flagged "several systemic deficiencies" in the national Capital's fight against vehicular air pollution, saying there were gaps and weaknesses in air quality monitoring, public transport, enforcement of vehicular emission norms, and cleaner mobility policies.

In its third report of the Assembly presented on Monday, the commit-

tee examined the Comptroller and Auditor General's performance audit of "Prevention and Mitigation of Vehicular Air Pollution in Delhi for the year ended 31 March, 2021" and called for urgent, time-bound corrective action by the Transport and Environment departments.

The committee said several Continuous Ambient Air Quality Monitoring Stations (CAAQMS) did not fully comply with prescribed siting norms as prescribed by the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) regarding proximity to roads, trees, and other obstacles, raising concerns over the reliability of pol-

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice

Invitation of Tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Systems)

NIT No.	336500
Name of Work and its location	Tender for "Complete Mechanical and Electrical Furnishing work for LWFCZAC LHB Coaches."
Approx. Cost of Work	Tender Cost Rs. 33,54,082.72/- including GST (Rs. Thirty Three Lakh Fifty Four Thousand Eighty Two & Paise Seventy Two only).
Earnest Money	Rs. 67,100/-
Completion Period of Work	06 months from date of LOA
Cost of Tender document on cash/by post	NIL
Date and Time for submission of tender and opening of tender	Upto 15:00 hrs. on 13.04.2026
Website particulars, notice board location, complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in
Tender No. : 336500 Dated: 23.03.2026	982/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is for general information that **I, AALIMA JAVED W/O MOHD WASEEM R/O D-53/3-A, First Floor, Left Side, Street No.-19, Chauhan Banger, Seelampur, Dist: North East Delhi, Delhi-110053**, declare that name of my father and my mother have been wrongly written as **JAVED and MUSARRAT ZAHAN** in my all educational documents. The actual name of my father and my mother are **MOHD JAVED and MUSARRAT JAHAN** respectively which may be amended accordingly. It is certified that I have complied with other legal requirements in this connection.

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that **Mr. Neeraj Kumar & Mrs. Indu** are the owners of Entire third floor with terrace rights, Property no. 630-A, Gali no. 6, land area measuring 136.3 sq. Mtrs., out of Khassa no. 81, situated at Govind puri, Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019 through Sale Deed dated 15.07.2019 in favour of **Mr. Tilak Bhardwaj** in doc. no. 3912 executed by **Mr. Tilak Bhardwaj** as doc. of **Mr. Neeraj Kumar (2) Mrs. Indu** in respect of said floor.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
1st CORRIGENDUM

Tender No.- 48-R1-SRDEE-G-DLI-2025-26. Name of work: "Comprehensive AMC of Omega Make Lifts installed over Delhi Division for three years." The amendments in above said tender are as under:

Tender No. 48-R1-SRDEE-G-DLI-2025-26	
Earlier Published	Amended
Name of Work 48-R1-SRDEE-G-DLI-2025-26 Comprehensive AMC of Omega Make Lifts installed over Delhi Division for three years.	48-R1-SRDEE-G-DLI-2025-26 Comprehensive AMC of Omega Make Lifts installed over Delhi Division for three years.
Approx cost of the works in	₹8679060/-
Address of the office	Sr. Div. Elect. Engineer/ General, New Delhi
Bid Security	₹173600/-
Date & time submission of tender	23.03.2026, 16.00 Hrs.
opening of tender	23.03.2026, 16.00 Hrs.

The tender document of above-mentioned tender has been modified kindly go through the amended documents available on www.ireps.gov.in and submit your offer accordingly.

SERVING CUSTOMER WITH A SMILE 981/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of **Mr. NAGENDER** who is purchasing Plot area measuring 115 Sq. Yards, comprised in Khassa No. 972, situated at Village, Khatola, District North West, Delhi-110081 from **Mr. Devender Singh** who is recorded owner of the subject property as per revenue records vide Khataoni records for the years of 2014 to 2015. **Mr. NAGENDER** is intend to purchase and mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from **Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd.** To comply the requirements of **BANK/NBFC**, we give this public notice that if any person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saina Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049** Contact :- 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform general public that **Mrs. Renu** has acquired Second Floor without roof rights, Part of Property bearing No. 546-B, area measuring 63 Sq. Mtrs., out of Khassa No. 600/92, Situated at Govindpuri, Gali No. 6, Kalkaji, New Delhi, vide by way of Sale Deed dated 08.12.2025 registered as Document No. 2025/10/19710. Documents related to the above said property has been misplaced i.e. Original Sale Deed in favour of **Mr. Kartar Singh Kalsi** in respect of the said property. If anyone who find the above said documents shall handover the same to the Manager of **Truhome Finance Limited** (earlier known as **Shriram Housing Finance Ltd.**) Now, **Mrs. Renu** intends to sell above said floor to **Mr. Brijesh Kumar** on Sale Deed basis and availing a loan on above said property from **Truhome Finance Limited** (earlier known as **Shriram Housing Finance Ltd.**) in case anyone has any objection, the same may be raised within 7 days of this publication to **Mr. Ajit Sharma (Advocate)**, Partner of **Accolaw Source LLP**, Unit No. S-2-U, 2nd Floor, built on Plot no. 4 and 5, Ansal Utility Commercial Centre, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063 or contact :- 91.9560309905 (M).

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Anuj Srivastava S/o Ram Chander Srivastava R/o Flat No.-1206, Tower-F3, Panchsheel Greens-1, Sector-16B, Greater Noida West, Gautam Buddha Nagar (U.P) 201306 have changed my minor daughter's name from **Aanya Srivastava** to **Daveeja Srivastava** for all future purposes.

PD(577)C I, Komal Sain, D/o Sh. Rajesh Kumar, R/o 662/8, Jagriti Vihar, Meerut, UP 250004, do hereby solemnly declare that **Komal Sain Bharti** (after marriage name) and **Komal Sain** (after divorce name) are one and the same women. Henceforth, I have changed my name from **Komal Sain Bharti** to **Komal Sain** for all purposes.

PD(578)A I, Jag Roshani W/o Chetan Dev Residing at House No-GF-1, Plot No.-271, Moti Apartment-5, Sector -1 Vaishali Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201010 do hereby solemnly affirm that I have changed my name from **Jag Roshani** to **Roshni Devi** for all future puposes.

PD(579)C I, Vikas Singh, Brother of No.16032924K Rfn Neeraj Singh, R/o- Vill- Goinece, PO-Sultanpur Perajor, Dist- Kanpur Dehat, U.P, declare that in my Brother's service record my name is wrongly recorded as **Vikash Singh** whereas my correct name is **Vikas Singh**, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(580)C I, Pinky Devi, W/o- No.4293397K Nk Abhishek Kumar, R/o- Vill- Daulatpur, PO- Dahabigha, PS- Hilsa, Dist- Nalanda, Bihar- 801302, have changed my name from **Pinky Devi** to **Pinki Devi**, vide affidavit dated 23/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(581)C

I, Vishaka, D/o- JC-472612F Sub Hony LT Jugesb Kumar, R/o- RZ B-60, D Block, Nangli Vihar Ext, Part-1, Najafgarh, South West Delhi, Delhi-110043, have changed my name from **Vishaka** to **Vishaka Kumari**, vide affidavit dated 23/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(582)C I, Beena Devi, Mother of No.16019908N Hav Anil Kumar, R/o- Vill- Alampur Hathla Urf Lodona, PO- Lodona, Dist- Gautam Buddha Nagar, U.P- 203141 have changed my name from **Beena Devi** to **Bina Devi**, vide affidavit dated 23/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(583)C I, JC-858709P Sub(OPR) Amarjeet Singh, R/o- 38 Sikhera Road Shapuram, Meerut, have changed my Son's name from **Abhishek to **Abhishek**, vide affidavit dated 23/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.**

PD(584)C I, No.14857477L Hav/MT Prabhu Mohan Mishra, R/o- Vill- Banmunda, Po & PS- Birmitrapur, Dist- Sundergarh, Odisha - 770033, have changed my Father's name in my service record from **Devendra Nath Mishra** to **Devendranath Maninath Mishra**, vide affidavit dated 23/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(585)C I, Suchita Mahajan W/o Harish Mahajan R/o J-85, IVth Floor, RBI Enclave, DAV Jhabban Lal School, Paschim Vihar, West Delhi-110063 have changed my name to **Sucheta Mahajan**.

PD(586)C I, Amit Dubey S/o Shyam Bahadur Dubey R/o H no.A133 durga vihar New delhi 110062, Have change my Name from **Amit Kumar Dubey** to **Amit dubey** for all future purpose.

PD(587)C

Office of Superintending Engineer
6th circle, P.W.D. Uttarkashi
E-Mail : sepwduki@rediffmail.com Tel./Fax No-01374-222127

Letter No.- 1258/56 M-06/2025-26

Date 20.03.2026

National Competitive Bid (E-Tendering)

On behalf of the Hon'ble Governor, Uttarakhand, Superintending Engineer 6th circle. PWD Uttarkashi invites item rate tender in (Two bid system) for the following work. All the information regarding tender shall be available on website <http://www.uktenders.gov.in> from 3.00 pm on dated 25.03.2026

S. N.	Name of work	Earnest money (In Lacs)	Tender Cost (in Rupees)	Validity of tender (days)	Completion period (Month)	Contractor's Category of registration
1	Improvement & Reconstruction work of Dharkot-Musadgaon-Kuleth-Bhatwari Motor Road in District Uttarkashi Block Dunda Under State Sector.	2.95	4000+ 18% GST	90 days	09 Months	Registration in 'C' Class or above for Road Works in P.W.D Uttarkhand
2	Under state sector in District Uttarkashi Block Chinyalisaur Bangaon-Chapda Kaslana motor road phase -2 stage-1 work.	4.15	5000+ 18% GST	90 days	12 Months	Registration in 'C' Class or above for Road Works in P.W.D Uttarkhand
3	Protection work at km 01 in Harsil Mukhwa motor Road in District Uttarkashi Block Bhatwari Under SDMF.	9.00	5000+ 18% GST	90 days	09 Months	Registration in 'B' Class or above for Road Works in P.W.D Uttarkhand

NOTE- The work mentioned at S.no 3 has been invited in anticipation of approval, in case financial approval is not obtained, the Tender for the said work shall be cancelled.

COURT OF THE PRINCIPLE JUDGE, FAMILY COURT, UJJAIN
PRESIDING OFFICER SHRI SANJEEV KUMAR GUPTA
Attach notice for Paper Publication under order 5 rule 20 CPC 1908

Process ID- 182/09-03-26
Next Hearing date 30/04/2026

RCS HM/28/2024
Bhavna Verma
VS Gopal Verma

To,

Gopal Verma S/o Kishan Verma,
Ram Gopal Street, Godown road,
Behind Nizamabad machinery store,
Opposite to Malkani building NJAMABAD, TELANGANA PIN 503001

This is to inform you that an application has been filed against you by the petitioner Bhavna Verma W/o Gopal Verma, 182/6 Jawahar Marg, Gali no-2, Ujjain M.P. under section 13 of Hindu Marriage act, seeking dissolution of marriage. You are hereby summoned to appear before this court, in person, or by a pleader duly instructed, and able to answer all material questions relating to the suit, on 30-04-2026 at 11-00 O'clock to answer the claim. You are also directed to file your written statement of defense on that day and to produce all documents in your possession or power, upon which you base your defense or claim or counter claim. If you rely on any other document whether in your possession or power or not, as evidence in support of your defense or claim or counter claim, you shall enter all such documents in a list to be annexed to the written statement. You are hereby informed that if you fail to appear before this court on the day mentioned above, the suit will be heard and determined in your absence. You are also informed that if you wish to settle the matter through mediation please inform the Presiding Officer.

Given under my hand and the seal of the court on 09/03/2026.

Sanjeev Kumar Gupta
chief justice family

Principal Judge of family court Wahmad Court, Ujjain

Please Note - If for any reason the court remains closed on the said date or the Presiding Officer remains on leave, the case will be taken up for hearing on the next working day.

कार्यालय, नगर पालिक निगम, कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)

ई-प्रोक्युमेंट निविदा सूचना

क्र. 502/2026/
एकीकृत पंजीयन प्रणाली अंतर्गत सक्षम श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से निम्नलिखित निर्माण कार्य हेतु (Online) आनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है:-

क्र.	कार्य का विवरण	अनुमानित लागत (रु.लाख में)	निविदा डालने की अंतिम तिथि
1	वाई क. 03 अंतर्गत न्यू टी.पी. नगर जोन ऑफिस का निर्माण कार्य (निगम मद) (प्रथम निविदा)	99.78	08.04.2026 (T.No. 187353)

उपरोक्त कार्यों की निविदा की जानकारी ई-प्रोक्युमेंट वेब पोर्टल <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> से डाउनलोड की जा सकती है, साथ ही निगम के वेब साईट www.korbamunicipal.in एवं www.korba.urbanecg.gov.in पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

।। स्वच्छ भारत निर्माण में योगदान दें ।।

हस्ता
अधीक्षक अभियंता
नगर पालिक निगम
कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)

Pak-linked terror module busted, 18-year-old operative held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police Special Cell has arrested an 18-year-old man and busted a Pakistan-linked terror module that was recruiting and grooming Indian youths through social media for activities ranging from propaganda to planned attacks, officials said on Monday.

The accused, identified as Harmandeep Singh alias Harman, a resident of Rampur in Uttar Pradesh, was apprehended following sustained surveillance on Pakistan-based gangster-turned-terrorist Shahzad Bhatti and his network. Deputy Commissioner of Police (Special Cell) Narra Chaitanya said the arrest has exposed a structured terror syndicate being operated remotely from Pakistan. "Handlers were targeting vulnerable youth in

India and luring them with promises of money, recognition, and a lavish lifestyle," he said.

Police said the operation was carried out by a team of the Special Cell's Eastern Range. The team had been tracking Bhatti's activities and contacts for some time. During surveillance, Harman emerged as a key operative who was in regular contact with foreign-based handlers through multiple social media platforms.

Investigators said Harman's mobile phone contained incriminating chats with Bhatti and his associates, along with photos and videos of activities carried out on their instructions. A black spray paint bottle used for graffiti was also recovered from his possession.

According to police, the module followed a clear and layered strategy. Recruits were first identified

based on their social media profiles. They were then gradually inducted and assigned tasks in phases. Initial assignments were low-risk, such as arranging logistics, transferring money, conducting reconnaissance, and spreading propaganda through graffiti.

"As part of his assigned tasks, Harman was instructed to paint graffiti at public places to spread fear and attract attention," an officer said. Acting on these directions, he allegedly painted "TTH" graffiti at three locations in Talwara in Punjab's Hoshiarpur district and shared images and videos with his handlers as proof.

Police said Harman had also attempted to recruit others. He allegedly tried to motivate a friend from Rampur to join the network and carry out similar activities.

During interrogation, it emerged that the accused had



Harmandeep Singh alias Harman

discontinued his education early and later became active on social media. Influenced by posts showcasing the lifestyle of gangsters, he developed an inclination towards such networks. His background revealed a troubled

upbringing. Harman was born in Rampur and had a difficult family environment. In 2023, after an altercation at home, he left and travelled to Amritsar, where he came into contact with individuals linked to criminal gangs. This

eventually led him to establish links with Bhatti's network through intermediaries.

Police said Harman came in contact with one Dheeraj alias Dhiru, who had earlier been arrested in a grenade attack case in Haryana's Sirsa. Through such connections, Harman was introduced to Bhatti and other Pakistan-based handlers.

The accused was promised financial rewards and assistance in relocating abroad, including to Dubai, if he successfully completed assigned tasks. Investigators said handlers also assured him that arms and explosives would be supplied through cross-border networks, including drone routes from Punjab.

Police further revealed that Harman and his handlers had discussed plans to carry out a grenade attack at a police chowki

in Rampur. The plan included the supply of explosives through conduits operating from Punjab.

The probe also linked the module to a firing incident in the Kashmiri Gate area of Delhi. Harman claimed that his associates were involved in the incident, and a Pakistan-based associate had publicly claimed responsibility for planning it on social media.

Officials said the timely arrest of the accused has thwarted potential terror attacks and disrupted a larger network operating across regions.

"This was a structured, foreign-controlled module using social media, money, and remote instructions to carry out activities in India," a senior officer said. Further investigation is underway to identify and apprehend other members of the network, police added.

Developed Delhi, Green Delhi our Budget vision: CM Rekha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday said her Government's commitment to the vision of a 'Developed Delhi, Green Delhi,' stating that the upcoming budget would be a significant step towards fulfilling the aspirations of nearly 30 million residents of the Capital.

Making this assertion at the commencement of the Delhi Assembly's Budget session with the traditional 'Kheer Ceremony,' marking the formal start of proceedings, she also said the ceremony is not just a customary start to the Budget process, but also a symbol of prosperity, good fortune, and a commitment to public welfare, values that will be reflected in the forthcoming Budget.

Speaking at the event, Rekha Gupta said the Government's second Budget would further accelerate Delhi's development. She noted that it would not only strengthen infrastructure but also improve the overall quality of life for residents.



The Budget aims to move Delhi towards becoming a city where citizens have access to better healthcare, quality education, robust infrastructure, and a clean and green environment.

She added that priority would be given to improving facilities for students, strengthening healthcare infrastructure, ensuring cleanliness,

controlling pollution, and promoting a greener ecosystem.

Emphasising that 'Developed Delhi, Green Delhi' is not merely a slogan but a clear vision of the Government, the Chief Minister said the goal is to create a positive, safe, and prosperous environment where people can live with comfort and dignity. She added that while the

Government worked over the past year to change the city's direction, the upcoming Budget would focus on taking concrete steps to improve its overall condition.

Expressing gratitude to the people of Delhi, the Chief Minister said the Government continues to function with their trust and support. She reaffirmed that the administration remains committed to serving citizens round the clock and will continue working every day to make Delhi a better place.

The ceremony saw participation from a wide cross-section of society, including farmers, school students, teachers, doctors, members of the transgender community, women drivers, and media personnel.

On the occasion, farmers honoured the Chief Minister by presenting her with a traditional turban. Several prominent leaders were also present, including Cabinet Ministers Parvesh Sahib Singh, Ashish Sood, Manjinder Singh Sirsa, Ravindra Indraj Singh, and Kapil Mishra, along with MLAs and other dignitaries.

Assembly hails PM Modi for record 8,931 days in office

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Assembly on Monday congratulated Prime Minister Narendra Modi for setting a milestone of 8,931 days in public life, first as the Gujarat chief minister and now as the prime minister. On Sunday, Modi surpassed the 8,930-day record of former Sikkim chief minister Pawan Kumar Chamling to become the longest-serving head of a Government in India.

Speaker Vijender Gupta said that starting as Gujarat chief minister, Prime Minister Modi has now completed 8,931 days in public service.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "The prime minister has served the country like a saint, and lived a spotless life dedicated to the development and service of the nation."



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

"The prime minister worked with a vision. I congratulate him on behalf of every citizen of Delhi. He changed many definitions. He has worked 24x7, 365 days, in the service of the nation, and enhanced the pride and honour of the country through governance and foreign policy," she added. The Chief Minister further said that the Prime

Minister's efforts have significantly enhanced India's global standing, prestige, and self-confidence.

She also emphasised that through the use of technology, teamwork, and a forward-looking approach, the Prime Minister has made governance more efficient and transparent, and has steered India onto a new path of progress.

Delhi lost ₹1,034 crore due to 2021-22 excise policy: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A report of the Delhi Assembly's Public Accounts Committee (PAC) tabled in the House on Monday said losses to the tune of ₹890 crore were incurred due to the failure of re-tendering of liquor shops, while another ₹144 crore was lost in the wake of licence fee waiver under the excise policy 2021-22.

Tabling the report related to the excise policy framed and implemented during the previous AAP regime, PAC chairman and BJP MLA Ajay Mahawar said that the report was solely based on findings of CAG Audit and action taken notes of the excise department, so as not to affect any ongoing probes and legal cases.

The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) report on "Regulation and Supply of Liquor in Delhi" was laid before the Delhi Assembly on February 25, 2022. The CAG report was referred by the House to the PAC for further examination. The CAG Audit observed several discrepancies in the way the excise department monitored and regulated the supply of liquor in Delhi. The total financial implication of the audit findings is approximately ₹2,026.91 crore.

According to the PAC report, the CAG found that retendering of surrendered licences was not done, leading to a loss of ₹890.15 crore. It was observed that 19 zonal licences were surrendered before the policy (2021-22) expired in August 2022. However, no retendering process was initiated by the excise department to operationalise the



retail vends in these zones. The excise department, in its action taken note, said that it had sought directions for retendering the retail licenses for the year 2022-23, through communications dated February 4, 2022, March 16, 2022 and April 12, 2022, but did not receive any directions from the then Delhi Government or the competent Authority.

Manish Sisodia, who was the deputy chief minister in the AAP Government during the time, held the finance portfolio, which includes the excise department.

Further, the PAC report mentioned a loss of ₹144 crore as flagged by the CAG audit due to "irregular" grant of waiver in licence fee during the COVID pandemic.

The CAG report mentioned that both the excise and finance departments proposed to the Government that the waiver should not be granted to the licensees due to the COVID-related lockdown period from 28 December 2021 to 27 January 2022.

AAP boycotts Budget session over MLA suspensions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Opposition AAP MLAs boycotted the first day of the Delhi Assembly's Budget session on Monday, staging a protest with a *Loktantra Ki Arthi Yatra* (funeral procession of democracy), alleging "murder" of democracy by the ruling BJP. They demanded the revocation of the suspension of its four MLAs. The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) MLAs tried to enter the Assembly premises, but the police stopped them at a barricade. Later, they took out a march outside the Assembly carrying the *arthi*.

The Leader of Opposition Atishi pointed out that whenever the BJP-led Government does not have answers, it tries to crush the voice of the opposition in the arrogance of power, calling it not just a demonstration but an expression of public anger against dictatorship, and asserting that those who undermine democracy will be held accountable by history and the people.

"We have been elected by the people of Delhi, and we raise their troubles and issues, but the BJP wants us



Leader of Opposition Atishi

not to raise our voice," Atishi said, adding that the police prevented them from entering the Assembly premises.

Four AAP MLAs — Sanjeev Jha, Jarnail Singh, Som Dutt and Kuldeep Kumar — were suspended in January this year by Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta for disrupting Lt Governor's address to the House. Their suspension has continued as the sitting was not prorogued.

Meanwhile, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta condemned the boycott of House proceedings by the Opposition Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) members on the first day of the budget

session. "I strongly condemn the protest being carried out outside the House by the members of the Opposition and the Leader of the Opposition, Atishi," the Assembly Speaker said in a statement.

"Boycotting the House and failing to participate in its proceedings is completely against the dignity of the House and Parliamentary decorum," Speaker Gupta said, after the AAP members stayed away from the proceedings, allegedly to demand the revocation of the suspension of their party's four MLAs during the last sitting of the House.

The Assembly Speaker said, "In a democratic system, the House is the very place where discussion and dialogue should occur; however, the Opposition's decision to distance itself from the Budget Session is deeply unfortunate."

He added that at a time when the Delhi Budget is being presented, the participation and presence of the Opposition are of utmost importance.

"Protesting outside instead of engaging in discussion is contrary to established parliamentary traditions," he said. Delhi Cabinet Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh also criticised the Opposition for boycotting the first day of the Assembly's budget session. The Minister called the move "unfortunate" and an attempt to avoid accountability.

Addressing the media inside the assembly premises, Singh said the Opposition walked out after learning that key reports, including those of the Public Accounts Committee (PAC) and the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG), were to be presented in the House.

SIM cards were procured through forged documents,

phishing, and pre-activated connections. Money transactions were routed through small shops and Jan Seva Kendras to avoid detection.

On March 20, nine more people, including five minors, were detained. The network's footprint spans Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Maharashtra and Nepal. On March 22, another key accused, Naushad Ali alias Lalul, was arrested in Faridabad. A woman identified as Meera, an e-rickshaw driver from Mathura, and a minor were also detained. Meera had earlier been arrested in a weapons supply case and is suspected of having assisted in recruitment and logistics.

Officials said Sarfaraz alias Sardar was among the handlers coordinating activities from across the border. Another accused, Sameer alias Shooter, remains absconding.

Multiple agencies, including the NIA, ATS, and police teams from Uttar Pradesh, Delhi, and Haryana, are now working together to trace the remaining operatives and reconstruct the full extent of the network.

Delhi's vehicle count hits 87.6 lakh; 8% rise in 2025-26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The total number of motor vehicles on roads in Delhi till 2025-26 is 87.61 lakh, showing an increase by 7.93 per cent compared to 2024-25, according to the Economic Survey of Delhi 2025-26 report released on Monday. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday tabled the report on the first day of the Delhi Assembly's Budget session.

As per the report, the total number of motor vehicles on the road in NCT of Delhi as on March 19, 2026, is 87.61 lakh, showing an increase by 7.93 per cent compared to 2024-25. GNCTD has banned Diesel Vehicles more than 10 years old, and Petrol Vehicles of more than 15 years old, hence deregistered 66,20,160 vehicles up to 2025-26 (March 19, 2026). Also, the number of vehicles per thousand population was 522 in 2025-26 (as on March 19,



2026). "The highest number of increase was registered in the two-wheeler category, including motorcycles and scooters. Till March 19, 5,927,775 two-wheelers were registered, making up for 67.65 per cent of the total number of vehicles," the report States.

DTC is the largest public transport entity in the City-NCR, transporting about 24.29 lakh passengers and covering 5.01 lakh km per day, a reduction from the previous year of 2024-25 when the average daily ridership was registered at 25.58 lakh per day. As

of March 2026, DTC, DoT has a fleet size of 6100 buses, comprising 1002 Non AC low floor (CNG) buses, 760 AC low floor (CNG) buses, 2750 AC low floor (Electric-12 Mt.) and 1588 AC low floor (Electric-9 Mt.) buses. DTC is also operating an International Bus Service on Delhi-Kathmandu route.

"In the transport sector, there are 86 buses on 27 routes for night bus service. Under its gender sensitisation program for bus crew undertaken by DTC, 30 ladies special buses are also being

plied during peak hours on 30 routes. DTC is also operating an International Bus Service on the Delhi-Kathmandu route," the report States.

The number of bus breakdowns has also increased; in the current financial year, 929 bus breakdowns were registered, an increase from 897 in 2024-25. This year, a total of 1503 electric buses broke down in 12-metre and 9-metre categories; the breakdowns are per 10,000 buses, the report added.

Under the electric vehicle push, till March 19, a total of 47,01,04 electric vehicles have been registered in Delhi, the report added. Presently, the Delhi Metro network consists of about 352 Km, including 58.497 km of NCR, 22.909 km of Airport Line, and 2.008 km extension of Airport Line to Yashobhoomi.

After completion of Phase IV, the total length of metro lines, including NCR lines, will be about 463 km.

Government to hike power tariff to pay ₹38,552 crore discom dues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Residents in Delhi may soon face higher electricity bills, with tariffs expected to rise from April 2026 as the Delhi Government moves to clear outstanding dues exceeding ₹38,000 crore owed to the city's three power distribution companies (discoms).

The Government is, however, planning to subsidise the hike in power tariff to cushion the impact on the consumers.

"This is a regulatory business. The Government is committed to ensuring that no burden falls on the people of Delhi," Delhi Power Minister Ashish Sood assured on the first day of the Budget Session of Delhi Assembly on Monday.

"The previous Government has left a debt



of more than ₹38000 crores of regulatory assets with the discoms through DERC. To recover this, the companies are authorised to increase the electricity rates. During the tenure of the previous Government, on the orders of the high court, DERC was ordered to bring tariff orders," he said.

The Delhi Power Minister also slammed the former

AAP-led administration for neglecting the public interest and allowing the debt to grow unchecked. "The successive failures of various past Governments, combined with the connivance and corrupt underhand dealings of the AAP Government and DISCOMs, have resulted in this massive accumulation of debt. Despite DISCOMs receiving continuous subsi-

dies from the Government, their Regulatory Assets simultaneously increased. This points to clear collusion and financial mismanagement by the AAP Government," the minister stated.

In August last year, the Supreme Court directed that regulatory assets, including carrying costs of ₹27,200 crore, be paid to Delhi's private discoms — BSES Rajdhani Power Limited (BRPL), BSES Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL), and Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) — within seven years.

Regulatory assets refer to costs approved for future recovery. These have risen sharply due to the absence of tariff hikes in Delhi over the past decade under the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) Government.

IN FOCUS



Students dressed as Lord Hanuman taking part in a fancy dress competition ahead of the Ram Navami festival in Patna

PTI

Student stabbed over Instagram row; 2 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A student of Anglo Arabic School was stabbed outside an examination centre near Ajmeri Gate in central Delhi on March 18.

According to police, the attack stemmed from a social media dispute. Two accused, including a juvenile, were apprehended within hours while trying to flee the city.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Central) Rohit Rajbir said the arrests were made the same evening. "The accused were apprehended at around 8.30 PM, soon after the FIR was registered at about 6.50 PM.

Acting on technical surveillance and ground intelligence, the team tracked and intercepted them near Old Delhi

Railway Station while they were attempting to escape," he said. The victim had gone to appear for an examination at the Andhra Education Society. Shortly after stepping out of the centre, he was attacked with a sharp-edged weapon. He sustained serious injuries and was rushed to Lok Nayak Jai Prakash Hospital. Police said he is now stable and has been discharged.

A case under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita was registered at the IP Estate police station, and an investigation was launched immediately. Police identified the accused as Sufiyan (19), a resident of Sadar Bazar, and a 17-year-old juvenile.

Both were traced through CCTV footage and technical inputs within a short span of time.

PM: Iran war a concern for India's energy needs

He said endangering any life in this war runs counter to the interests of humanity and "India's effort is to encourage all parties to arrive at a peaceful resolution as soon as possible".

On India's diplomatic response to the West Asia conflict, the Prime Minister said India's stand has been clear from the very beginning, when the US and Israel attacked Iran and the latter retaliated by targeting its Gulf neighbours and Israel, "one of expressing deep concern, advocating de-escalation, and opposing attacks on civilians and on energy and transport infrastructure". "India, through diplomacy, is making continuous efforts for the safe passage of Indian ships even amidst the war environment. Due to such efforts, several of our ships that were stuck in the Strait of Hormuz have also arrived in India in recent days," he said.

The prime minister also drew the attention of the House to the internal security dimension of the crisis, warning that certain elements attempt to exploit such situations. He said all security agencies have been placed on alert and that security across all domains, coastal, border, cyber, and strategic installations, is being further strengthened. "Whether it is coastal security, border security, cyber security, or strategic installations, the security of all is being reinforced," he said.

Urging patience, restraint, and vigilance, and cautioning against those who may seek to exploit the situation by spreading falsehoods, engaging in black-marketing, or hoarding, Modi appealed to all state governments to ensure strict monitoring and swift action against such elements. Expressing his abiding faith in the collective resolve of the nation, the Prime Minister said that when every government and every citizen of this country walk together, "we can challenge every challenge, this is our identity, and this is our strength". The prime minister said the crisis has been going on now for more than three weeks, and it is having a very adverse impact on the global economy and on people's lives. The entire world is urging all parties for the earliest resolution of this crisis, he said. This region is important to India for yet another reason, as nearly one crore Indians live and work in the Gulf countries and among the commercial ships that sail in these seas, the number of Indian crew members is also very high, he said. "India's concerns are naturally greater, and therefore it is essential that a united and unanimous voice goes out to the world from India's Parliament on this crisis," he said. Modi underscored how the energy diversification strategy pursued over the past decade has proven its worth in the current crisis. He informed the House that India has expanded its energy import sources from 27 countries to 41 countries over the past 11 years, thereby reducing dependence on any single region.

Modi said India has more than 5.3 million metric tonnes of strategic petroleum reserves, and the country is also working on arrangements for more than 6.5 million metric tonnes of storage. Apart from this, he said, there are reserves held by the domestic oil companies.

"In the last 11 years, our refining capacity has increased significantly, and the government is in constant touch with suppliers from different countries. The effort is to ensure that oil and gas supplies continue from wherever possible," he said. Highlighting the scale of the evacuation effort, the Prime Minister said more than 3,75,000 Indians

IndiGo appoints Alope Singh as Chief Strategy Officer

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The board of InterGlobe Aviation, which operates IndiGo, has approved the appointment of Alope Singh as the airline's new Chief Strategy Officer.

In his new role, Singh will oversee long-term strategic planning and lead company-wide transformation initiatives aimed at boosting growth, improving efficiency, and strengthening IndiGo's competitive position in the global aviation market.

He is also expected to work closely with senior leadership on cross-functional priorities, including enhancing customer experience and ensuring sustainable value creation.



Singh brings more than 30 years of experience in the aviation sector, with expertise across strategy, operations, planning, and commercial functions.

He is widely recognized for managing large-scale transformations and driving rapid expansion. Prior to

this appointment, Singh served as Managing Director and CEO of Air India Express, where he played a key role in improving operational performance and accelerating growth. His earlier career includes senior leadership roles in strategy at Air India and Oman Air.

Welcoming the appointment, IndiGo Managing Director Rahul Bhatia said Singh's combination of strategic insight and operational expertise would support the airline's next phase of expansion. He added that Singh will initially report directly to him and later transition to reporting to the incoming Chief Executive Officer.

Speaking on his new role, Singh said he was pleased to join IndiGo at a crucial time for both the airline and the broader Indian aviation sector. He noted that as IndiGo expands its global ambitions, he looks forward to strengthening its strategy, enhancing operational excellence, and expanding its market reach.

Maldives: Search continues for 2 Indians, Gautam Singhania recovering

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Felidhoo/ Maldives/New Delhi

In the early hours of March 20, 2026, a high-speed speedboat capsized in the waters of Vaavu Atoll, Maldives, near Felidhoo (also referred to as Fulidhoo or Keyodhoo area, approximately two nautical miles southwest of Keyodhoo. The incident has left the Indian business and motorsport communities in shock, with two prominent Indians still missing days later.

Two fellow Indian passengers, five-time national rally champion Hari Singh and decorated sailor Commander Mahesh Ramachandran, remain missing after the vessel overturned near Felidhoo island in the Vaavu Atoll.

At the centre of the story is Gautam Hari Singhania, Chairman and Managing

Director of the Raymond Group, who was on board, sustained minor injuries and has since flown back to Mumbai. Local Maldivian authorities and media have confirmed that seven people were aboard the vessel, including Singhania, one British woman, and one Russian woman. Five passengers were thrown into the sea. Search and rescue operations by the Maldives National Defence Force (MNDF) and Coast Guard continue, involving boats, drones, and underwater searches across thousands of square nautical miles. As of March 23, 2026, no trace of the missing has been officially confirmed recovered, though some unverified reports in niche circles have circulated fears that one or both may not have survived. As per the available infor-



mation, the vessel was a Cigarette racing boat, a high-performance speedboat designed for extreme velocities, serving as a tender to Singhania's luxury superyacht, TT Ashena (a 46-metre vessel).

Reliable sources told the prominent Maldivian news portal Adhaddhu that Singhania himself was driving the boat at the time

of the capsizing around 1:15 am local time. The President of the Vaavu Atoll Council, Shujau Ali, corroborated this based on information gathered from survivors and authorities: records reviewed showed the vessel had reached speeds of up to 72 miles per hour (approximately 116 km/h). The boat was reportedly being used to ferry passengers, possibly

back to the yacht after a late-night outing.

According to sailing experts, the high speed of a Cigarette boat in potentially choppy night waters is widely seen as a contributing factor. Rumours of alcohol or recklessness have circulated on social media but remain entirely unverified and unmentioned in any official or mainstream reporting.

Two Legends of Indian Motorsport and Sailing. The two individuals still unaccounted for are: Hari Singh (59), India's "Gypsy King" and one of the most decorated rally drivers in the country. A five-time Indian National Rally Champion and the first Indian to win the Asia Zone Rally Championship, Singh was a mentor at JK Tyre Motorsport. He was known for his humility, smooth

driving style, and decades of contributions to Indian motorsport.

Commander Mahesh Ramachandran is an Arjuna Award-winning sailor, former naval aviator, Asian Games medallist, and legendary figure in Indian sailing. He served as the captain (skipper) of Singhania's yacht TT Ashena. His expertise in both naval aviation and competitive sailing made him a respected leader in India's maritime and sailing community.

Police have confirmed that both missing persons are Indian nationals. The sailing and motorsport fraternities in India have expressed profound shock and are holding out hope, with figures like sailor Abhilash Tomy publicly urging continued rescue efforts.

FROM PAGE - 1

Two US tourists booked for flying drone near...

This area falls within a designated red zone that encompasses INS Dronacharya, the Indian Navy's premier gunnery and missile training school. It also houses the headquarters of the Indian Coast Guard. Under India's Drone Rules, 2021, red zones are strictly no-fly areas. Drone operations are strictly prohibited around defence establishments, airports and other strategic areas without explicit prior permission from authorities.

Kerala Tourism Police noticed the activity and promptly intervened. A First Information Report (FIR) was registered at the Fort Kochi police station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), the Aircraft Act, and the Drone Rules. The duo's drone and laptop were seized as evidence. Kerala Police have clarified that the two foreigners were not formally arrested. They were questioned at the station and released on notice, requiring them to appear before investigators as and when required. Officials have not alleged any security breach yet.

It may be noted that Fort Kochi, with its historic naval presence, remains a high-security zone. INS Dronacharya trains Indian Navy personnel in gunnery, missiles, and advanced weaponry systems, while the Coast Guard headquarters oversees maritime security operations along India's western seaboard. Unauthorised aerial surveillance in such areas is taken seriously to prevent potential intelligence gathering or safety risks. India's drone policy, enforced by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), divides airspace into green (permitted with basic rules), yellow (requires permission), and red (no-fly) zones.

As per the law of the land, flying in red zones can attract heavy penalties, including fines, confiscation of equipment, and legal proceedings. Foreign nationals, in particular, are expected to familiarise themselves with these rules before using recreational or professional drones.

This incident highlights the growing popularity of drone photography among international visitors to Kerala's scenic backwaters and coastline and the legal pitfalls that can arise when rules are overlooked. Similar cases have occurred in other sensitive locations across India, where even well-meaning tourists have faced scrutiny.

As the investigation continues, Phelps and Harvey remain in Kochi and are cooperating with authorities. Meanwhile, the Karamal Police have urged all visitors to check the DGCA's Digital Sky platform or consult local tourism offices before operating drones anywhere in the country. This particular case serves as a timely warning to all. India's skies may be beautiful, but in protected zones, one should not try any adventure or explore with a drone. Any misadventure around red zones will have consequences.

Delhi's per capita income surges, becomes one...

The per capita income of Delhi at current prices reached at the level of ₹49,2592 in 2024-25 as compared to ₹45,7708 in 2023-24. The Advance Estimate of per capita income of Delhi at current prices during 2025-26 is estimated at ₹53,1610, registering a growth of 7.92 per cent over the previous year. "The per capita income of Delhi at constant prices was estimated at ₹28,5207 in 2024-25 as com-

pared to per cent 27,2950 in 2023-24. The Advance Estimate of per capita income of Delhi at constant prices during 2025-26 is estimated to reach at ₹30,5433, registering a growth of 7.09 per cent over the previous year", the report said.

According to the report, Delhi's economy has a predominant Service Sector with its share of contribution to Gross State Value Added (at current prices) at 86.32 per cent during 2025-26, followed by the contribution of Secondary Sector (12.88 per cent) and Primary Sector (0.80 per cent). The tertiary sector plays a pivotal role in the State economy, both in terms of employment generation and contribution to State Income.

"The Advance Estimate of GSDP of Delhi at current prices during 2025-26 is likely to attain a level of ₹13,27,055 crore, which is at a growth of 9.42 per cent over 2024-25. The Advance Estimate of GSDP of Delhi at constant prices during 2025-26 is recorded at ₹7,76,479 crore, showing a growth of 8.53 per cent over 2024-25. With the economy's return to normalcy brought closer by the successful mega vaccination drive in Delhi, hopes of a robust recovery in the services sector, consumption and investment have been rekindled. In the years 2021-22, 2022-23, 2023-24 & 2024-25, a recovery of real GSDP of Delhi with growth of 7.20 per cent, 7.40 per cent, 9.63 per cent & 6.23 per cent respectively is based on a low base effect and inherent strengths of the economy," the report said.

The report highlighted that Delhi's outstanding debt at the end of March, 2025 was ₹30,556.54 crore, including the non-plan loan received during 2013-14 from the Government of India for meeting the outstanding liabilities of DVB/DESU amount of ₹3,326.39 crore and Chandrawal Water Treatment Plant (Delhi Water Supply Improvement Project Aided by JICA) amount of ₹447 crore. Thus, the outstanding debt of the Delhi Government constitutes 2.30 per cent of GSDP during 2025-26.

As a result of the outstanding debt, the Delhi Government has paid an amount of ₹2,666.08 crore as interest and a total of ₹4,914.32 crore as repayment of principal to the Government of India during 2024-25.

The Delhi Government recorded a Fiscal Deficit of ₹3,934.15 crore in FY2023-24 as compared to a Fiscal Surplus of ₹5,724.12 crore in 2024-25. Chart 4.9 indicates the fiscal deficit/surplus as a percentage of GSDP during 2014-15 to 2025-26 (BE). However, the Government has projected the fiscal deficit of ₹13,702.95 crore during 2025-26 (BE), which is 1.03 per cent of GSDP. The fiscal deficit in 2025-26 (BE) is mainly on account of an increase of more than double (145 per cent) in capital expenditure over 2024-25. The capital expenditure which was only ₹11,485 crore in 2024-25 (Prov) has been increased to ₹28,115 crore in 2025-26 (BE). The Capital Expenditure is developmental, and it has been appropriately attuned to the needs of the capital city of India.

The report said the fiscal deficit is within the accepted limits of 3 per cent of GSDP. It may be seen that Delhi is budget to have a Fiscal Deficit of ₹13,703 crore in BE 2025-26, which is mainly on the account of increase of more than double in capital expenditure over 2024-25. The capital expenditure which was only ₹11,485 crore in 2024-25 (Prov) has been increased to ₹28,115 crore in 2025-26 (BE).

The total Revenue Collection of Delhi Government was ₹81,545.83 crore (6.14 per cent of GSDP) in 2025-26 (BE) as against ₹62,232.85 crore (5.13 per cent of GSDP) during 2024-25 (Prov).

CAG slams ₹33.66 crore renovation of Kejriwal...

Audit noted that in respect of the award of the consultancy work, PWD did not make available to Audit the basis for selecting three consultancy firms for restricted bidding. Besides, while working out the justification cost, PWD adopted one-year-old rates of consultancy work and enhanced it by 50 per cent.

During the execution of work, PWD again resorted to restricted tendering and selected five contractors for bidding on the basis of their financial status, resourcefulness and experience in executing similar works in VIP areas. Audit, however, observed that only one contractor, to whom the work was awarded, had the requisite experience, indicating that the selection of bidders for restricted tendering was arbitrary.

Audit observed that during execution, PWD increased the built-up area from 1,397 sqm to 1,905 sqm (36 per cent) and also altered the applicable specifications of the work by executing several items of superior specifications, artistic and antique items, ornamental works (both Civil and Electrical/Services). To cover the cost, PWD had to revise the PEs four times.

Besides, PWD also did not explore the possibility of tendering for additional AA&ES and works amounting to ₹25.80 crore (2nd to 5th PE) were executed by the existing contractor. Audit noted that ₹18.88 crore was incurred by PWD in the execution of items of superior specification, artistic, antique and ornamental items which were executed by PWD as extra items. Moreover, AA&ES for the 5th PE amounting to ₹9.34 crore was issued more than two months after completion of the work, thus creating a liability without any approval.

According to CAG, the second work of additions/alterations in the Staff Block/Camp Office was awarded at ₹16.54 crore against the estimated cost of ₹18.37 crore. The said work was also awarded through restricted tendering. The reasons for resorting to restricted tendering could not be ascertained, as the related records were not made available to Audit. Audit noted that, out of ₹19.87 crore sanctioned for the construction of the Staff Block and Camp Office, funds were diverted for other works.

Besides, the Staff Block was not constructed out of the funds; seven servant quarters were constructed at another location, not related to the original work. Besides, the nature of the Camp Office was altered from Permanent to Semi-Permanent Structure (SPS), rendering the AA&ES and the estimates totally unrelated to the actual work executed. Ultimately, only the raw structure of the Camp Office was completed as the funds for the same were exhausted, and foreclosure of the work was initiated by PWD in June 2023.

Audit of the "renovation", which started in 2020, also lists the appliances and amenities acquired for the CM's residence — an 88-inch OLED TV (8K LG) purchased for ₹28.9 lakh, 10 other OLED TVs (4K Sony) for the household at ₹43.9 lakh, a Samsung 'flex family hub French multi-door' refrigerator for ₹3.2 lakh, a microwave oven for ₹1.8 lakh, two steam ovens for ₹6.5 lakh, a front-loading automatic washing machine for ₹1.9 lakh, and 10 beds and sofas for ₹13 lakh, among others. The Public Works Department (PWD) also installed a jacuzzi, sauna and spa for ₹19.5 lakh. An additional amount of ₹19.8 crore was spent on the construction of seven servant quarters.

NIA raids 9 J&K locations over Red Fort blast case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Monday conducted extensive raids at nine locations across Jammu and Kashmir in connection with the November 10, 2025, Red Fort car bomb blast case.

According to the official spokesman of the NIA, "the counter-terror agency, which is pursuing various leads in the case RC — 21/2025/NIA/DLI, searched nine locations in the districts of Srinagar, Baramulla, Jammu, Kulgam, Ganderbal and Handwara".

Several digital devices were seized during the searches and the same have been sent for forensic analysis.

The spokesman said a total of 11 accused have been arrested till date for their roles in the deadly blast that shook the national capital on 10th November 2025, killing several persons and injuring



many others. The prime accused, Umer Un Nabi, was also killed in the lethal explosion.

NIA found during the investigation that Umer had mas-

terminded the blast conspiracy in coordination with arrested co-accused and others.

The agency is continuing with its efforts to unravel

the larger conspiracy behind the terror attack and to identify others involved in the plot to spread mayhem and destabilise the country, the spokesman added.

BLAST ROCKS SAMBA DISTRICT

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Panic gripped one of the border villages of Samba district in Jammu after a powerful blast ripped apart the main gate of the residence of a former sarpanch at village Gawala Talab of Ghagwal tehsil past midnight. Several houses in the close vicinity also bore the brunt of the blast, which took place around 1.07 am.

The local police authorities immediately rushed to the spot after the residents raised an alarm and dialled the police control room for immediate help. According to preliminary reports, the blast took place near the main gate of the residence of former sarpanch Jai Ram Sharma at Gawala Talab, some 10 km from the

International Border in the Ghagwal sector of Samba district. At daybreak, senior police officials from Jammu and members of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) also visited the spot as part of the ongoing probe to ascertain the nature of the blast and the motive behind the same.

Briefing media persons, a senior police officer said the police teams rushed to the spot after the mysterious blast was reported in the border village. The police officer said the blast uprooted the gate and a portion of the boundary wall but caused no casualties. A team of forensic experts visited the site and took samples from the scene to ascertain the cause of the explosion.

EC letter with BJP Kerala seal triggers row; poll panel calls it clerical error

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

A political row erupted on Monday after a letter from the Election Commission of India was found carrying the seal of the BJP Kerala unit, prompting sharp reactions from the CPI(M) and the Congress.

The controversy surfaced after CPI(M) flagged the issue on social media platform X, sharing an affidavit attached to a March 19, 2019 letter sent to political parties in the country that bore the BJP Kerala seal instead of the Election Commission's official seal.

Reacting to the development, the ECI said it was "purely a clerical error" and had been "rectified immediately."

In a strongly worded post, the CPI(M) said, "Have all pre-ferences been dropped by the BJP?" It added, "It is no secret that the same power centre seems to control both the Election Commission of India and the BJP. Even then, at least maintain the courtesy of two separate desks."

The party further alleged, "Seals are being casually swapped. A BJP seal on an Election Commission letter!" and remarked, "Just like the



old allegation — that no matter which button you press, the lotus appears — here comes another 'coincidence.'"

The CPI(M) claimed the document had been "received by multiple parties" and "cross-verified with at least two of the recipients," adding that the email had originated from an official Election Commission source.

Responding to the controversy, the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Kerala, issued an official clarification, stating: "It has come to our notice that a letter from the Election Commission, bearing the seal of the BJP, is being circulated across various Malayalam news channels. The Office of the Chief

Electoral Officer (CEO) hereby clarifies that this was purely a clerical error, which was identified and rectified immediately."

Explaining the sequence of events, the CEO's office said, "The BJP Kerala Unit had recently approached the CEO's office seeking clarification on the 2019 guidelines regarding the publication of criminal antecedents of candidates. Along with their request, the party submitted a photocopy of the original 2019 directive. The party's seal was present on that specific copy provided by them."

It added, "Due to an oversight, the office failed to notice the party symbol on the submitted document and inadvertently redistributed it to other political parties as part of the requested clarification."

The CEO's office said corrective action was taken promptly. "The Office of the Chief Electoral Officer acknowledged the lapse as soon as it was detected. Consequently, on March 21, the Deputy Chief Electoral Officer issued a formal letter withdrawing the erroneous document," it said.

IAF to train UK Royal Air Force pilots: British Air Chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Britain's Air Chief Marshal Sir Harv Smyth on Monday hailed a new move that will facilitate the Indian Air Force (IAF) train pilots of the UK's Royal Air Force as the two sides are looking at boosting overall defence ties in the face of emerging security challenges.

The Chief of the Air Staff, presently on a three-day visit to India, held wide-ranging talks with his Indian counterpart Air Chief Marshal AP Singh.

Air Chief Marshal Smyth met his Indian counterpart to discuss evolving security threats and ways to further strengthen the partnership between the two air forces, according to a British readout. Smyth is in India to boost military ties in the face of "emerging security challenges," it said.

In February this year, the UK and India signed an agreement under which the Indian Air Force will deploy three qualified flying instructors to Royal Air Force (RAF) Valley in the UK - the training base for British fast jet pilots.

The two air chiefs will also travel to Air Force Station in Gwalior to understand IAF's operational procedures and best practices in countering new-age aerial threats.

"It is a privilege to visit India and further strengthen our defence partnership, hosted by my esteemed colleague and good friend, Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh," Smyth said.



"The planned arrival this September of Indian Air Force Qualified Flying Instructors at RAF Valley — joining the IAF instructor already contributing at RAF College Cranwell — illustrates the depth of trust, shared professionalism, and mutual commitment that underpin our relationship," he said.

Smyth said these exchanges, together with expanding training and operational cooperation, demonstrated the enduring bonds between the Royal Air Force and the Indian Air Force.

"Our shared dedication to security, stability, and technological excellence. I look forward to building on this momentum and continuing to deepen the cooperation between our air forces in the years ahead," he said.

Commodore Chris Saunders, a defence adviser at the British High

Commission, said the visit by the UK Chief of the Air Staff emphasises the significance of the UK-India defence relationship.

"Embedding IAF instructors within our instructor cadre at RAF Valley and RAF College Cranwell, as well as those from other Services, alongside increasingly complex air exercising and multi-domain cooperation, represents a tangible and substantive strengthening of defence ties in all domains," he said.

"As the fourth and most senior flag-rank visitor from the UK to India in 2026, this visit clearly signals the strategic importance both nations place on developing a strong defence partnership," Saunders added.

Air Chief Marshal Smyth is also expected to hold discussions with other members of India's civil and military

10,000 AC e-buses for 116 cities by 2027: Govt to Rajya Sabha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government on Monday informed the Rajya Sabha that 10,000 air-conditioned e-buses would be provided to 116 cities across 26 States/UTs by the end of 2027 under the PM-eBus Sewa Scheme, and a new scheme would be launched thereafter to provide another 35,000 e-buses.

Replying to supplementary queries during Question Hour, Minister of Housing and Urban Affairs Manohar Lal said Prime Minister Narendra Modi had on August 16, 2023, announced that the PM e-Bus Sewa scheme would provide mobility in smaller cities and tackle rising pollution.

Since States were unable to



provide adequate finance for e-buses, a target of a total of 10,000 buses was put under the PM e-Bus Sewa scheme for towns with a population between 3 lakh and 40 lakh, he said.

The minister said States were told to give their demands, and a selec-

tion criterion was laid down, and buses were sanctioned on the recommendations of coordination committees.

"Out of 178 cities eligible, 116 cities participated, and they were allotted buses accordingly. Only four cities qualified under the scheme in Bihar, where 400 buses have been sanctioned. While 150 buses have been sanctioned for Patna, 50 buses each have been sanctioned for the cities of Bhagalpur, Darbhanga, Gaya, Muzaffarpur and Purnea," the minister said.

He, however, said that the scheme is being delayed in Bihar as Coordination committees in this regard have not been set up by the State Government.

"The second scheme of 35,000 more buses will come soon, and

cities have to apply under the scheme accordingly. We want to provide the benefit of this scheme to more and more cities and help States, as this also helps reduce pollution," the housing and urban affairs minister told members.

He said a tranche of 225 buses was delivered last month, and tenders have been selected, and agreements for 6,500 buses have been done, and more buses will be delivered to States as soon as they finalise agreements.

"The first tranche of 10,000 buses under the scheme will be completed by the end of 2027, and after that, the next scheme will be started. The impact of this scheme would help in saving money and time for people and improve the environment," Manohar Lal said.

Tamil Nadu polls: AIADMK to contest 178 seats, BJP gets 27 in NDA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) on Monday firmed up a seat-sharing arrangement for the upcoming assembly polls in Tamil Nadu. The BJP will contest on 27 seats out of 234, while All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) will contest on 178 seats. The Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) will battle it out on 18 seats, and the Amma Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam (AMMK) on 11 seats.

The State will go to the polls in a single phase on April 23, with counting scheduled for May 4.

The current tenure of the 234-member State Assembly ends on May 10.

The seat-sharing announcement was made by AIADMK

general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami during a joint press conference at the party's headquarters.

The event was attended by Union Minister Piyush Goyal, BJP Tamil Nadu president Nainar Nagendran, PMK president Anbumani Ramadoss, and AMMK general secretary TTV Dhinakaran.

Reacting to the decision of the BJP contesting on 27 seats in Tamil Nadu elections, BJP's Tamil Nadu election in-charge Goyal said,

"We are all one family, and we will fight the elections to win them...we are very satisfied with the 27 seats, we will sweep the elections as the people of the State are fed up with CM Stalin and DCM Udhayanidhi Stalin...they have hurt the culture of the State...NDA will form the Government in



the State..."

Separately, AC Shanmugam, founder of the Puthiya Needhi Katchi, stated that he has informed Piyush Goyal of his party's willingness to contest nine constituencies under the BJP's lotus symbol. He also referenced his past electoral performances in Vellore, noting

that he secured 3.25 lakh votes in 2014 under the BJP symbol and 4.70 lakh votes when contesting with AIADMK support.

"In 2014, along with PM Modi, the then candidate, we contested under the lotus symbol, and I got 3.25 lakh votes in Vellore. I contested from Vellore under AIADMK

and got 4.70 lakh votes... I already informed Piyush Goyal that we are ready to contest under the lotus symbol and gave a list of 9 constituencies, asking for 4-3," said Shanmugam.

AIADMK general secretary Palaniswami also said the names of constituencies to be contested by alliance parties will be identified soon, adding the seat-sharing talks were cordial.

Palaniswami described the alliance it leads as one marked by "bonding," and called it a "victorious" combine.

He expressed confidence that the alliance would go on to win at least 210 Assembly constituencies out of the total 234. "The alliance will win, and AIADMK will form the Government," he asserted.

Inventory of Puri temple's Ratna Bhandar to begin after 48 years with videography, 3D mapping

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puri

Odisha Law Minister Prithiviraj Harichandan on Monday said elaborate arrangements, including videography, photography and 3D mapping, have been made for the inventory of Puri Jagannath Temple's Ratna Bhandar, scheduled to begin on March 25 after a gap of 48 years.

He said the use of technology is aimed at ensuring transparency and proper documentation of the temple's ornaments and other valuables.

Harichandan said that for the first time, gemologists

and RBI officials will be engaged in the exercise along with expert goldsmiths. However, he clarified that there would be no valuation of the items and the exercise would be limited to documentation and verification.

After reviewing the preparedness for the exercise at the 12th-century shrine, the minister said detailed discussions were held to ensure the inventory process is conducted in a systematic, secure and transparent manner.

He also stressed that daily rituals of the temple should not be disrupted during the exercise and directed officials to strictly follow the standard operating proce-



dures (SOP) prepared by the Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee.

"A decision has been taken

to conduct complete videography, photography and 3D mapping during the inventory process to ensure trans-

parency and secure preservation of records," he said.

Justice Bishwanath Rath, chairman of the Ratna

Bhandar Committee, Shree Jagannath Temple Administration (SJTA) chief administrator Arabinda Padhee and other officials attended the review meeting.

Padhee had earlier said the inventory work would begin between 12.12 pm and 1.45 pm on March 25 and would be carried out in phases, starting with movable ornaments in the outer chamber, followed by those in the inner chamber.

As per the SOP approved by the state Government, only authorised persons will be allowed during the process, and the work will be suspended on festivals, special occasions and days with

heavy footfall of devotees.

Officials said strict security arrangements would be in place and the keys of the Ratna Bhandar would be deposited in the district treasury after each day's work.

Devotees will, however, be allowed to have darshan of the deities from outside barricades.

Harichandan, whose Law Department oversees the functioning of the shrine, said the items documented during the exercise would be matched with records from the last official inventory conducted in 1978.

He said gemologists have been included this time as some precious stones could

not be properly identified during the previous exercise.

The Ratna Bhandar, which has two chambers, the Bhitara Bhandar and Bahara Bhandar, is considered a sacred treasury linked to the religious sentiments of millions of devotees.

The last inventory, conducted between May 13 and July 23, 1978, documented 454 gold-mixed articles weighing 128.38 kg and 293 silver-mixed articles weighing 221.53 kg, besides several precious stones.

Officials said the use of modern technology is expected to help complete the current inventory within about a month.

Nation Focus



PM pays tribute to Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev

PM Narendra Modi on Monday remembered the martyrdom of Independence movement heroes Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev and said their ideals of justice, patriotism and fearless resistance continue to ignite the spirit of countless Indians. Modi also said that at a young age, they displayed extraordinary courage and an unshakable commitment to the cause of India's freedom. On this day, Bhagat Singh, Shivaram Rajguru and Sukhdev Thapar were hanged to death by the British rulers of India in 1931. "Today, we bow in reverence to the brave sons of Bharat Mata, Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev. Their martyrdom for the nation remains etched in our collective memory," the Prime Minister said in a social media post.



UPSC to release answer keys after civil services prelims: Govt

The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) has formulated guidelines to release the provisional answer key on its website after conducting the civil services preliminary examination, the Centre said in the Rajya Sabha. The UPSC conducts the civil services examination annually in three stages — preliminary, main and interview — to select officers for the Indian Administrative Service (IAS), Indian Foreign Service (IFS) and the Indian Police Service (IPS), among others.



States Focus



ODISHA AIMS TO BE MAOIST-FREE BY MARCH 31: CM MAJHI

Around 15 Maoists are active in the areas along the borders of Kandhamal, Kalahandi and Rayagada districts in Odisha, Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi informed the State Assembly on Monday.

As per the Security Related Expenditure (SRE) scheme of the Central Government, at present, only Kandhamal district is considered Left-wing Extremism (LWE) affected in the State, he said, while replying to a question from Congress MLA Taraprasad Bahinipati.

Eight other districts – Boudh, Bolangir, Kalahandi, Koraput, Malkangiri, Nabarangpur, Nuapada and Rayagada – are considered legacy and thrust (L&T) districts, he said.



SIKKIM MUNICIPAL ELECTIONS TO BE HELD ON APRIL 24

Municipal elections in Sikkim will be held on April 24 and the counting of votes will take place the next day, State Election Commissioner (SEC) KC Lepcha said on Monday.

The filing of nominations will begin on March 30 and scrutiny will take place on March 31, he told reporters here. The last date for withdrawal of nominations is April 4. Polling will be held from 8 am to 5 pm on April 24 and the counting of votes will take from 8 am on April 25, he said.

Assam Minister Nandita Garlosa joins Congress

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Minister Nandita Garlosa joined the Congress on Sunday after being denied a BJP ticket, and she will contest the upcoming assembly polls from Haflong constituency in Dima Hasao district, a party statement said.

The Congress had earlier fielded its state unit general secretary Nirmal Langthasa from the seat, but he has agreed to give the party ticket to Garlosa in "greater public interest", it said.

"We are happy to announce that Nandita Garlosa has joined the Congress. She has been the voice of Dima Hasao for the last five years, and she has always stood for her beliefs and principles," the party statement said.

The state sports and youth welfare minister "paid the price for this in the BJP



because Himanta Biswa Sarma is only interested in selling the land of tribals to large corporations", the Congress alleged.

Garlosa had represented the Haflong constituency in the outgoing assembly. The BJP replaced her in the upcoming polls with debutante Rupali Langthasa.

The Assam Congress media team also shared a picture of Garlosa joining the party at Haflong. The state minister was seen in the picture along with Nirmal Langthasa and others. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma visited Garlosa's house at Haflong on Sunday.

Both Sarma and the minister, however, did not comment on the outcome of the meeting.

The elections to the 126-member Assam assembly will be held on April 9. Votes will be counted on May 4.

India, Russia eye \$100B trade target; Jaishankar calls for removing barriers

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India and Russia must tackle regulatory hurdles and non-tariff barriers to significantly boost bilateral trade, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on Monday, reaffirming New Delhi's commitment to deepening its long-standing ties with Moscow.

Speaking via video link at a conference on future bilateral cooperation, Jaishankar highlighted that relations between the two countries continue to strengthen despite shifting global dynamics.

He stressed that a changing multipolar world makes closer coordination between India and Russia increasingly important, particularly through forums such as BRICS, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the G20, and the United Nations.

Jaishankar described the India-Russia relationship as a "special and privileged strategic partnership," built over



Union External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar speaking during his virtual address at a conference titled "India and Russia: Towards a new bilateral agenda" in New Delhi

decades on mutual trust and shared interests. He said both countries are working toward raising annual trade from about \$68.7 billion to \$100 billion by 2030 in a sustainable and balanced manner.

To achieve this goal, he underlined the need to move forward on a proposed free trade agreement between India and the Eurasian Economic Union while addressing existing trade obstacles and making better use of India's skilled workforce.

The minister also referred

to outcomes from Vladimir Putin's visit to New Delhi last December, during which both sides outlined a roadmap to expand economic cooperation over the next five years.

Highlighting sectoral collaboration, Jaishankar called Russia a key partner in India's civil nuclear energy ambitions, noting that New Delhi aims to expand its nuclear power capacity to 100 GW by 2047.

Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov praised India's independent foreign policy and reaffirmed Moscow's respect for its strategic autonomy. He also expressed hope that Prime Minister Narendra Modi would visit Russia later this year.

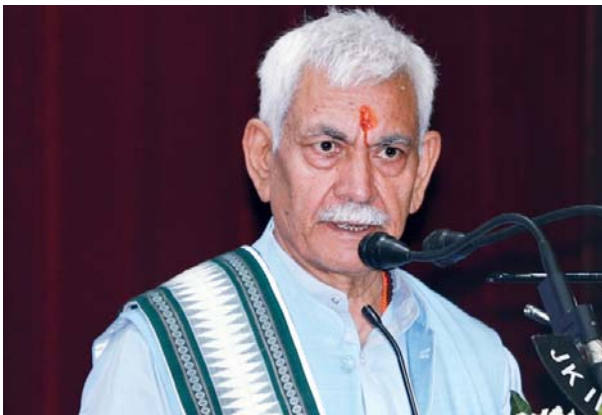
Lavrov described the relationship as a "time-tested" partnership and a model for international cooperation based on equality, trust, and mutual respect, emphasising that both nations continue to prioritise each other's interests amid evolving global challenges.

No safe havens for terrorists in J&K: LG Manoj Sinha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jammu

Following a major crackdown against the existing terror ecosystem in Jammu and Kashmir, Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha, on Monday, issued a fresh warning to the remaining elements of the terror ecosystem and conflict entrepreneurs to recognise that no safe havens exist for terrorism or its supporters in the Union Territory.

The Lieutenant Governor also maintained that those who were part of this terror ecosystem and managed to



Jammu and Kashmir LG Manoj Sinha addressing the handing-over ceremony of appointment orders under SRO 43 (Victims of Terror) and Rehabilitation Assistance Scheme (RAS) in Jammu on Monday

infiltrate Government machinery in the past will face the law, and they will be systematically removed from Government jobs and punished as per the law.

LG Manoj Sinha issued the stern warning after he handed over appointment letters to 37 Next of Kin (NoKs) of victims of terrorism, at the Convention Centre, Jammu. Appointment letters were also handed over to 29 NoKs of Government employees who lost their lives in service, and beneficiaries in Age relaxation cases, under Jammu and Kashmir Rehabilitation Assistance

Scheme-2022 and SRO 43.

"So far, appointment letters have been given to 438 terror-victim families. This is not merely a number - these are 438 shattered worlds," Sinha said while addressing the gathering.

Paying tribute to the victims of terrorism, the Lieutenant Governor vowed the strongest action against the terror ecosystem and its supporters. "I pledge to the families of terror victims that we will work with full commitment to secure their dignified and honourable lives. We will discharge every duty towards them with utmost

seriousness, and we will not rest until justice reaches every family," the Lieutenant Governor said.

"The people of Jammu Kashmir know fully well who shielded such terror elements, but that shield is now crumbling. I warn them that there is no longer any haven in Jammu Kashmir for terrorists or the networks that support them," he said.

The Lieutenant Governor reiterated that it is his commitment to ensure that every terror victim's family receive the justice, jobs, recognition and support they deserve after years of suffering.

186 new archaeological sites identified in Bihar: Government

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has conducted a village-to-village survey to identify sites in Bihar with "archaeological potential", the Government informed Parliament on Monday.

In a written response to a query in the Lok Sabha, Union Culture Minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat also said that during the last

three years, 42 sites in Lakhisarai district and 144 sites in Samastipur district have been "reported". He said Rs 15 crore has been allotted for the conservation of monuments and sites in Bihar, which are listed under the ASI during the current year.

He was asked whether the Government has undertaken any surveys or studies to identify sites in Bihar with the potential to be accorded her-



itage status. "Yes sir, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has conducted a village-to-village survey to

identify sites in Bihar with archaeological potential," Shekhawat said. He added that during the "last three

years (from 2023-24 to 2025-26), 42 sites in district Lakhisarai and 144 sites in district Samastipur are reported". The minister said the ASI takes up conservation of protected monuments and protected areas.

"There are 70 protected monuments and protected areas in Bihar. An amount of Rs 15 crore is allotted for the conservation of these monuments/sites during the current year," he said.

Monuments of sites of national importance located in Bihar include the ruins of the ancient Nalanda University in Nalanda district, Barabar Caves in Jehanabad, Buddha Relic Stupa in Vaishali, the site of the ancient Vikramasila monastery in Bhagalpur and the Tomb of Sher Shah Suri at Sasaram in Rohtas district.

The Patna Circle of the ASI administers these centrally protected sites in Bihar.

Telangana BJP president detained over Assembly protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad

Telangana BJP President N Ramchander Rao, along with several leaders and cadres, was taken into custody after they attempted to lay siege to the Assembly as part of a protest over the alleged failure of the Congress Government to fulfil its poll promises.

The Congress came to power by making tall promises to the people. But in the last two years, the people of Telangana have experienced only cheating, deception, and betrayal. The promises made to farmers, women, youth, employees, pensioners, and other sections of society have remained largely unfulfilled,



the BJP said in a release. "I was arrested for standing up against the betrayal, deception, and cheating that the Congress Government

has inflicted on the people of Telangana by its false promises," Rao said in a social media post.

Congress has once again

exposed its anti-democratic mindset by trying to crush dissent and silence protest, he further said.

Rao's arrest is yet another example of the Congress Government's anti-democratic attitude. Rather than responding to public anger over its failures, the Government has chosen to misuse State machinery against those raising their voices on behalf of the people, the BJP said.

The Telangana BJP launched the "Assembly Siege" protest to reflect the growing anger and frustration of the people of Telangana, who feel cheated by a Government that promised much but delivered nothing, the party added.

CR Patil urges citizen action for India's water security

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil on Monday stressed the urgent need for water conservation and active citizen participation to ensure India's future water security. He was addressing the World Water Day Conclave at Dr Ambedkar International Centre, where key national reports and policy documents on water bodies and irrigation were released.

Patil felicitated officials from the Ministry of Jal Shakti and other related departments at the event for their contributions to water management.

The 7th Minor Irrigation Census, 2nd Census of Water



Bodies, 1st Census of Springs, 1st Census of Major & Medium Irrigation Projects, the National Water Data Policy 2026, and technical publications by the National Mission for Clean Ganga, Central Ground Water Board, and National River Conservation Directorate were released at the conclave.

Addressing the conclave, Patil said, "I urge all citizens to conserve water in every possible way - collecting rainwater from rooftops into pits or trenches, using stones and pipes to direct water into the ground. Even 100 mm of rainfall can store one lakh litres per household. Water is not just a right. It is our responsibility.

If we fail to conserve, future generations will suffer."

"Water is the main foundation of life, agriculture, industry, and development. For achieving the goal of a developed India, the proper utilisation of water is essential. Rainwater harvesting must be increased, and water sources must be protected from pollution. At the community level, water conservation can be strengthened through active participation," he said. The minister outlined the progress of key Central Government initiatives, including the Jal Jeevan Mission and the Namami Gange programme.

"The Jal Jeevan Mission is a vision of the Prime Minister Narendra Modi, aiming to

provide piped, clean water in the right quantity to every household across the country. Under this mission, approximately 15.80 crore households have already received piped water..."

For the remaining 3 crore households, the plan, originally set to end in March 2024, has now been extended to December 2028, with an allocation of ₹1.51 lakh crore, he said.

He said the National Water Data Policy, launched on the occasion, will enable evidence-based decision-making for sustainable water management. "Data is crucial for planning; without it, many projects face mismanagement or fail to meet targets. The prime minister emphasises

the use of data and technology, ensuring that projects and plans are implemented efficiently and on time," the minister said.

Surat, he said, has become a city that has a plan to meet water requirements for the next 50 years. "The Central Government sanctioned ₹600 crore, and the State Government contributed ₹400 crore. Such planning ensures future water security," he said.

Referring to former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee's warning that a third world war could be fought over water, Patil said India is well prepared to meet its water needs under the current Government's leadership.

BJP's Ashoka urges Karnataka Speaker not to curtail Budget session

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bengaluru

Leader of the Opposition in the Karnataka Assembly R Ashoka on Monday urged the Speaker not to allow the ongoing Budget session of the legislature to be curtailed, amid indications of such a move, in the wake of bypolls to two Assembly segments in the State.

Ashoka, a senior BJP leader, said that there are indications the session may be curtailed and urged Speaker UT Khader not to allow it. As the House met for the day, Ashoka said, "We wanted to discuss Bengaluru's issues, but no one is here. Neither the Chief Minister nor the Deputy Chief Minister are present. What should we do?"

Speaker Khader replied, "Let them come; the matter can be taken up after that."

To this, Ashoka asked whether they would come and that he had "doubts" about that. "There are indications the Government may curtail the session. Please don't allow it to happen." The Speaker then said that any such decision would be taken after discussing with the Opposition leader. To this, Ashoka said there was no need for any discussion and that "let the session be held as per schedule."

Meanwhile, speaking to reporters outside the



Assembly, Labour Minister Santosh Lad admitted there were indications the session might be curtailed.

"The legislative session has been on for three weeks. Despite holidays in between, the session has been held for the minimum number of days. I don't have complete information about what the Opposition, the Chief Minister and the Speaker will decide. But such indications are there," he said in response to a question.

The State legislature's Budget session, which began on March 6 with Chief Minister Siddaramaiah presenting the Budget for 2026-27, is scheduled to conclude on March 27.

Two Assembly segments in the State – Bagalkot and Davangere South – will go to bypolls on April 9. Since Monday is the last date for filing nominations for the bypolls, both Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and his deputy DK Shivakumar are visiting those segments to accompany Congress candidates while filing their papers.



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Nothing left: SC disposes of wife’s plea challenging Wangchuk’s detention



The Supreme Court on Monday disposed of a plea filed by Gitanjali J Angmo, wife of climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, against the latter's detention under the National Security Act (NSA).

A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and PB Varale noted that the Centre revoked its order of Wangchuk's detention on March 14. The apex court said there was nothing left in the matter. Earlier, the top court had asked the Centre if there was any possibility for the Government to relook at the detention of Wangchuk, considering his health condition.

The Centre on March 14 said it had revoked with immediate effect the detention of Wangchuk under the NSA, nearly six months after he was arrested following violent protests in Leh that left four dead.

Wangchuk was detained on September 26, 2025, two days after the protests over demands for statehood for Ladakh and its inclusion under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution rocked Leh.

Ex-tehsildar gets one-year jail in 16-year-old graft case in Srinagar

A court here on Monday sentenced a former Government officer to a year's imprisonment in a 16-year-old corruption case. Anti-Corruption Court Srinagar, Special Judge Tasleem Arief Ganie, convicted Mohammad Akram Khan, a retired tehsildar, in a bribery case registered. The case was registered against him by the anti-corruption bureau (ACB) in 2010.

An ACB spokesperson said the accused, then posted as tehsildar, was found guilty under provisions of the Jammu and Kashmir Prevention of Corruption Act and the Ranbir Penal Code (RPC).



No bail for 14 arrested for Iftar party on boat in Ganga

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Varanasi

A court in Varanasi on Monday rejected the bail applications of 14 people who were arrested a week ago after they allegedly held an Iftar party and ate chicken biryani on a boat in the Ganga river.

The 14 were charged with defiling a place of worship, hurting religious sentiments



and causing public nuisance and water pollution. Subsequently, the police had also added a charge regarding the alleged forcible seizure of the boat, according to Shashank Shekhar Tripathi, the counsel for complainant Rajat Jaiswal who is the BJP Yuva Morcha's city unit chief. "Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate Amit Kumar Yadav observed that the charges are grave and non-bailable; therefore, there are no sufficient grounds to grant bail at this juncture," Tripathi said.

The prosecution strongly opposed the bail applica-

tion, arguing that the offence committed by the accused is of a serious nature and carries provisions for severe punishment.

They also contended that granting bail to the accused could potentially interfere with the judicial process, Tripathi said.

The 14 individuals were booked after a video of the incident surfaced online last Monday, and a written complaint was filed on the same day by Jaiswal.

The court had on Thursday sent the 14 people to judicial custody.

According to Tripathi, the accused had "threatened a boatman and forcibly taken him along before holding the party on his boat in the river".

The police also submitted a report to the court, citing the boatman's statement and eyewitness accounts. Consequently, a plea was filed to add several additional charges against the accused, including kidnapping.



Probe ADAG firms diligently, SC asks CGI, ED

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday expressed displeasure over the "reluctance" shown by the CBI and the ED in probing the alleged large-scale banking fraud involving the Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group and its firms, and directed them to conduct a "fair, dispassionate, transparent, and time-bound" investigation into the matter. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi took note of the submissions of Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) and the Enforcement Directorate (ED), and directed all concerned financial institutions to "render full cooperation to the ED".

Hearing a PIL filed by former bureaucrat EAS Sarma seeking a court-monitored investigation into alleged loan frauds exceeding ₹40,000 crore by Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG) firms led by Anil Ambani, the bench permitted the central probe agencies to approach it in case there is any reluctance on the part of other Government bodies in extending cooperation to them.

SG Mehta informed the bench that an SIT, in pursuance of an earlier order, had been constituted comprising senior ED officers and



financial experts from the banking sector. He said the probe agencies, so far, attached assets worth ₹15,000 crore and also arrested four persons, including a few senior officials. On the other hand, lawyer Prashant Bhushan, appearing for Sarma, referred to a SEBI report and said it has been highlighted that there was a scheme devised to siphon off money and yet the CBI has not made any arrests so far.

"Arrests have been made. We cannot make random arrests," the Solicitor General said. "We cannot direct them whom to arrest; but the investigating agencies, the way they have shown reluctance, is not acceptable. They should say in a time-bound manner as to what has been found. Your investigation

should reveal what has been done and must inspire confidence not only in us, but everybody," the CJJ said.

The bench referred to certain facts disclosed in the fresh status reports of the probe agencies and said the CBI and the ED are presently probing seven and eight FIRs, respectively. It also said that a loan amount of more than ₹3,000 crore has been apparently settled by paying ₹26 crore. The bench said it is estimated that the total fraud amount is around ₹73,000 crore.

"The investigating agencies must join hands and find out the issue. We impress upon the CBI and the ED that the probe be completed most dispassionately and independently so that it is taken to a logical conclu-

sion in a time-bound manner." The Solicitor General assured that no stone shall be left unturned to unearth the truth. The solicitor general has pointed to the second status report by the ED, where details have been sought from financial institutions. We allow the prayer in its entirety," the bench ordered.

Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for Anil Ambani, said that due to the pendency of the PIL, the lending banks are not willing to have a dialogue with him to settle the dues. "Due to the pendency of the case, they are hesitant," Rohatgi said. The bench said it has not stopped anyone from having any consultations. The bench sought fresh status reports from the probe agencies and fixed the PIL for further hearing after four weeks.

On February 4, the bench had voiced displeasure over the "unexplained delay" in investigations.

Ambani had assured the top court that he would not leave the country without its prior nod after the petitioner apprehended that he may flee.

The ED has alleged defaults of ₹7,500 crore in Reliance Home Finance and ₹8,200 crore in Reliance Commercial Finance, citing "large-scale diversion of public funds". On Reliance Power, the ED's report, which has been recorded by the bench, said the agency is investigating the submission of forged bank

guarantees to the Solar Energy Corporation of India, which caused a loss of more than Rs 105 crore.

Bhushan pointed out that Reliance Communications, despite having debts of ₹47,000 crore, was sold for a mere ₹430 crore, roughly 1 per cent of its value, to a company belonging to Anil Ambani's brother. "The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code is being misused like anything," the CJJ said. A senior lawyer, appearing for ADAG, said that two group companies, Reliance Power and Reliance Infrastructure, had already repaid ₹20,000 crore.

On January 23, the top court had asked the CBI and the ED to file status reports in a sealed cover within 10 days on their ongoing investigations into alleged massive banking and corporate fraud. The FIR was registered in 2025, though the fraud had been going on since 2007-08. It said the FIR registered by the CBI, along with the connected ED proceedings, addresses merely a small segment of the alleged fraud.

It also sought a direction to the respondents for the constitution of a special investigation team (SIT) comprising officers from the CBI and the ED to conduct a thorough, impartial and time-bound investigation. It said between 2013 and 2017, RCOM, Reliance Infratel and Reliance Telecom borrowed ₹31,580 crore from a consortium of banks led by the State Bank of India.

Madurai court holds 9 policemen guilty in case of custodial torture leading to deaths of father-son

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Madurai

A court in Madurai on Monday held guilty all the nine accused policemen in the case of custodial torture of a man and his son, leading to their deaths at Sathankulam in Thoothukudi district in the year 2020.

The First Additional District and Sessions Court Judge G Muthukumaran declared that the prosecution had proven its case and held the policemen guilty of causing the death of the father-son. The quantum of sentence for the convicted policemen will be pronounced on March 30, the judge said.

On June 19, 2020, mobile phone shop owner P Jayaraj (59) and his son J Benicks (31) were taken to Sathankulam police station in connection with an alleged violation of norms to prevent the spread of a coronavirus pandemic. The father and son died on June 23 at Kovilpatti subjail following alleged brutal custodial torture at the police station.

The case, which includes the charge of murder, against



10 policemen, including Inspector S Sridhar, Sub inspectors K Balakrishnan, P Raghuganesh, Head Constables, S Murugan and A Samidurai, was initially probed by the CB-CID and it was later taken over by the CBI. The incident had caused a major public outrage in the state then.

There were 105 witnesses, including Selvarani (wife of Jayaraj) then Sathankulam police woman head constable R Revathi in the case. As many as 116 documents were marked, which included the

judicial inquiry reports on the deaths of Jayaraj and Benicks. One of the accused, Special SI, A Pauldurai, died during the pendency of the case and 9 others, including Sridhar, continued to be in Madurai Central Prison.

The CBI initially filed a chargesheet and later a supplementary report which together was nearly 2,500 pages. Attempts of the accused to secure bail proved futile during the nearly 6-year-old trial of the case.

Daughter of deceased Jayaraj, Persis, told reporters

that the court has, in the judgment, said that her father and brother died due to the injuries inflicted on them by the 10 policemen.

Quoting the judgment, she said the policemen had beaten up her father and brother "all through the night and till early morning."

Asked on the judgment citing policemen's claim to "get trained by beating the father-son," she said it showed that they were not at all humans. She demanded that the guilty be handed exemplary punishment, which would be a deterrent.

"CBI did a good job," she said. She, further, said: "We were waiting for this day all these days. We think we have got justice. The punishment will be made known on March 30. We have faith in judiciary. No other family must be affected like us."

Jebasingh of Tirunelveli, an advocate on behalf of the victims' family said blood stains of victims from a van, (taken to transport them to jail) lathi and a table in police station helped establish torture and prove the charges.

SC transfers Ilaiyaraaja’s copyright suit against Sony Music

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday transferred a copyright suit filed by music composer Ilaiyaraaja from the Madras High Court to the Bombay High Court. A bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Vinod K Chandran allowed a petition by Sony Music Entertainment India Pvt Ltd for the transfer of the suit filed by Ilaiyaraaja last year in the Madras High Court.

During the hearing, senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for Sony Music, argued that since the suit before the Bombay High Court had been filed earlier, the later proceedings in the Madras High Court should be transferred to avoid the possibility of conflicting decisions by the two high courts on the same dispute.

However, senior advocate Kapil



Sibal, appearing for Ilaiyaraaja, opposed the contention and questioned the jurisdiction of the Bombay High Court. He submitted that the agreements between the parties contained jurisdiction clauses providing that disputes would fall within the

jurisdiction of courts in Madras.

Sibal further contended that the composer was not using the sound recordings in question but only performing his own musical compositions, and alleged that the proceedings initiated by Sony Music were not correct.

During the hearing, Justice Kumar observed that Ilaiyaraaja had not sought any relief against the institution of the suit before the Bombay High Court and suggested that the matter be transferred there.

The bench then allowed the transfer petition of Sony Music as Sibal sought liberty to raise all objections, including those relating to jurisdiction, before the Bombay High Court. The top court recorded that all issues in the dispute, including the question of jurisdiction, would remain open for consideration by the Bombay High Court. Sony Music had earlier filed a

copyright infringement suit before the Bombay High Court on January 13, 2022 for a permanent injunction to restrain the music composer from infringing its alleged copyrights in certain sound recordings and related literary and musical works.

Subsequently, Ilaiyaraaja approached the Madras High Court with a similar suit against Sony Music, Echo Recording Company Pvt Ltd and Oriental Records, seeking to restrain them from exploiting his sound recordings and musical works. He also challenged the claim of Sony Music's ownership and rights over the song recordings.

Last year, Ilaiyaraaja Music N Management Pvt Ltd had approached the top court for transfer of Sony Music's copyright infringement suit from the Bombay High Court to the Madras High Court. However, the apex court had dismissed that plea.

Fraud case: ED starts extradition process against absconding Ukrainian accused

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Monday initiated extradition process against Ukrainian national Olena Stoian, a prime accused in the multi crore Torres fraud case, by approaching the special PMLA court for requisite paper compilation and attestation to prepare a dossier.



These documents will be sent to authorities at Republic of Moldova, where Stoian has reportedly been traced, for her extradition. The court, considering the probe agency's plea, handed over the extradition documents to the ED.

Earlier, the special court had issued non-bailable warrants (NBWs) against four accused, including three absconding Ukrainian nationals, Stoian being one of them, for their alleged role in the case.

Hearing in defamation case against Rahul Gandhi postponed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Hearing in the defamation case involving Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, which was scheduled to take place on Monday at the MP-MLA Court in Uttar Pradesh's Sultanpur district, could not take place due to the non-appearance of the plaintiff Vijay Mishra. The court will now hear this matter on March 27.

Santosh Kumar Pandey, the advocate of the plaintiff, on Monday said that he had submitted a formal application to the court during the previous hearing.

This application requested that the audio and video recordings of the statements made by Rahul Gandhi, which have been presented as evidence, be matched with Rahul Gandhi's authentic voice.



Due to Vijay Mishra's absence, the court has scheduled the next hearing for March 27, when the arguments in the case will be pre-

sented. On February 20, Gandhi, the MP from Raebareilly, had appeared before the court and recorded his statement, claiming the case was

filed against him due to political vendetta. He had also told the court that the audio and video evidence submitted by the complainant was incorrect and said he would present his own evidence.

The case stems from Gandhi's alleged objectionable remarks against then BJP president Amit Shah during the 2018 Karnataka election campaign.

Following the remarks, Mishra, a resident of Hanumanganj under Kotwali Dehat police station area in Sultanpur, filed the defamation complaint.

In December 2023, the court had issued a warrant against Gandhi after he failed to appear before it. He later surrendered before the court in February 2024 and was granted bail on two surety bonds of ₹25,000 each.



Editor's
TAKE

West Asia war tests India's economy

As tensions escalate in West Asia, India finds itself confronting the familiar tremors of surging oil prices and currency pressure

Three weeks on, there is no sign of a let-up, only escalation – this sums up the US-Israel-Iran war that started as a regional conflict but is now impacting the whole world, and India is no exception. With our heavy dependence on imported fossil fuels, most of which passes through the Strait of Hormuz, the oil supply is severely hit, and as the war prolongs, things will get worse. The impact is staggering. The oil markets are in a tizzy, oil prices have already reached \$119 per barrel. Experts feel that oil prices will touch \$150 per barrel within a matter of weeks if the war does not end or some sort of mechanism to supply oil through Hormuz is not reached. The Iran war has once again exposed the fragility of global energy markets-and India's deep vulnerability to them.

Recognising the gravity of the situation, Prime Minister Narendra Modi convened a high-level meeting to review the country's energy preparedness, signalling both urgency and concern. While retail petrol and diesel prices have so far remained stable, this may not hold for long. Industrial diesel prices have already risen by about 25 per cent, reflecting the underlying stress in the system. Such increases inevitably translate into higher transportation and logistics costs, which in turn fuel inflation across sectors. Equally alarming is the falling rupee against the dollar, and it would not be an exaggeration to say that we are now close to breaching the 100 mark in months, if not weeks. The depreciation of the Indian rupee further compounds the crisis by making imports more expensive.

Like every crisis, this too has its own lessons, if we are willing to learn. For long, we have depended upon imported oil for our energy needs without ever caring that this dependency is one of the severest weaknesses any nation can have, especially if it strives to be a regional power. The time to correct this vulnerability is now. It is a structural issue and needs to be tackled with utmost urgency. There cannot be a short-term fix for it, like arranging alternative suppliers or increasing cess to manage demand. It would need investments in exploration and refining facilities. It would need sustainable solutions like biofuels and renewable energy resources – the policy decisions that would alter the energy equation. It is not a unique problem; many countries have successfully become self-sufficient and transitioned from total dependence on oil to a more diversified and self-reliant energy mix. Germany, through its 'Energiewende,' scaled renewables rapidly; Denmark switched to wind energy in a big way; and China dominates solar, wind, and battery supply chains, combining energy security with industrial strategy. Electrification of transport, expansion of public transit, and promotion of energy efficiency can significantly reduce oil dependence. Equally important is macroeconomic resilience. Strengthening the rupee through sound fiscal management and boosting exports can help mitigate the impact of external shocks. The lesson is clear-energy security equals national security, and it should be our national priority. We need a long-term strategy; it will not be fixed with a band-aid!

A new dawn or another illusion?

Nepal's recent election was an eruption of public anger against years of stagnation and corruption. Yet, a pressing question remains: has the country chosen real transformation, or simply been swept up by emotion without a clear path forward?



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

The election in Nepal last week was not merely a political exercise; it was an eruption of pent-up fury, a rejection of the old guard that had throttled any semblance of progress for decades. But what now stares back at the country is a stark question: have the people truly changed their future, or simply traded one set of illusions for another?

For years, Nepalis endured the same trio of power brokers-the Nepali Congress, the CPN-UML, and the so-called Communist Party-as these entities pirouetted through government halls, recycled leadership, and maintained an endless cycle of impressive promises and microscopic delivery. Institutions decayed, corruption metastasised, and unemployment worsened further. Youth unemployment stands north of 20 per cent-more than double the national average. Around 1,500 young Nepalis leave their homeland every single day seeking work abroad, a staggering exodus that undermines any future the country might hope to sculpt for itself.

So, when the uprising erupted, when Gen Z and youth frustration boiled over into the streets, it was not just rage-it was despair. Into this void surged Balendra Shah, the rapper-turned-Kathmandu mayor better known as Balen. He became the face of something many claimed they wanted: a break with the past. The Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP), a party as new as its leader's rise from outside the entrenched political class, swept to an unprecedented majority: 125 of the 165 first-past-the-post seats. A single party holding nearly two-thirds control in Nepal is almost unheard of, a brutal indictment of the old establishment's collapse.

Nepal's new leadership inherited not opportunity but catastrophe. The economic foundation is weak and brittle. Public debt hovers around 40-45 per cent of GDP, but it is the quality of the economy that terrifies: a narrow tax base, enormous dependence on remittances accounting for roughly one-quarter of GDP, and a private sector too fragile to absorb the burgeoning army of young jobseekers. Tourism, once thought a panacea, remains exquisitely sensitive to global disruptions. Agriculture remains archaic and unproductive. Power outages and distribution inefficiencies plague even the most basic enterprises. Crucially, the labour force-the very youth that marched in protests-has no obvious outlet for meaningful employment.

The RSP manifesto, the so-called "2082 Vision", is nothing if not audacious: 1.2 million jobs in five years; GDP expansion to almost \$100 billion; per capita income rising to \$3,000; 15,000 megawatts



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of installed capacity; halving LPG imports; digital services exports of \$30 billion in ten years; and the construction or upgrade of 30,000 kilometres of national highways. These numbers are ambitious-some might say visionary-but independent observers see them as fantasy built on the emotional reservoir of hope, not on deeply rooted economic analysis. Nepal's energy grid cannot reliably distribute current capacity; transportation infrastructure routinely buckles under seasonal rains; foreign direct investment remains underwhelming; and the digital economy is throttled by regulatory unpredictability and an underdeveloped legal regime for international payments.

These are the grim realities. A promise to reduce imports without addressing critical bottlenecks in trade policy or cross-border logistics is a promise destined for frustration. A pledge to build tens of thousands of kilometres of roads without sustained institutional capacity to manage land acquisition, competitive bidding, quality control, and anti-corruption oversight offers little more than ritual ground-breaking and even more ceremonial delays.

This mismatch between aspirational rhetoric and structural capacity points to a far more troubling truth: Nepalis have been deceived not by individuals but by narratives. The uprising was not wrong in its desire for change. But it was driven by visceral emotion-a collective impulse to reject the old, often without a coherent alternative blueprint that could realistically transform the economy and provide stability. Angry protests and street fervour commandeered the engine of politics, and once that engine is running on emotion rather than evidence, it becomes dangerously unpredictable. If Nepal is honest with itself, it must question whether Balen may tread a similar path: overwhelmed by the emotional thunder that elevated him, yet unprepared to deliver the institutional and economic stability the nation desperately needs.

Here is the painful truth: Gen Z politics, fuelled by emotion, creates momentum but not mechanisms. Momentum wins rallies; mecha-

nisms build nations. The current administration's inexperience-not merely in government, but in managing a modern economy under immense pressure-sets the stage for something grim: a crescendo of disappointed expectations.

Worse still, emotional politics is ripe for exploitation by external actors. Nepal is geostrategically hemmed in by its two giant neighbours. India-the largest source of trade, investment, energy supplies, and transit routes-watches with both interest and caution. China, a stakeholder in multiple infrastructure ventures and a central actor in Belt and Road projects, has its own expectations. Both have engaged with the RSP, seeking alignment with their own strategic interests. But emotion is a currency external

powers love to leverage: where national confidence is high and institutional clarity is low, foreign influence finds entry points. A government fuelled by public passion-but lacking robust policy anchors-becomes pliable, attractive, and dangerous. The question is: did the electorate truly choose a path to prosperity, or merely a dream of it? Emotional politics gave the people a mirror-a reflection of their hurt, their labour unrecognised, their aspirations denied. But mirrors do not map roads; they only reveal what is already before us.

Balenomics may become a lesson in hubris-not because the goals are unworthy, but because goals without disciplined implementation, institutional reform, and credible governance remain poetry when the country needs engineering. Nepal needs a systemic recalibration of labour markets, transparent rule-making, competitive commerce, legal certainty for investments, and infrastructural credibility-not just slogans that rouse crowds. When citizens see delays, when promised jobs fail to materialise, when inflation stubbornly erodes incomes, and when foreign capital does not flood in simply because of optimism, the inevitable question will surface: was this all just emotional theatre? If the answer is yes, Nepal risks entering a phase worse than the old guard's mismanagement: disillusionment with revolt itself.

PIC TALK



Students dressed as Lord Hanuman take part in a fancy dress competition ahead of the Ram Navami festival in Patna.

PHOTO: PTI

Peace cannot grow from seeds of violence



RAJYOGI BRAHMA
KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

There has never been a single day in the whole history of the news media when the media reported that peace prevails on the whole planet Earth and that everything is going right in the world. A study of the recorded history of the world gives conclusive evidence that there has constantly been bitter or bloody strife over the last two-and-a-half millennia. This strife may have been social, economic, political, cultural, ethnic, religious, or militaristic, or of any other kind; often, it was bolstered by a claim that it was for a noble goal or a just cause.

Similarly, those who were responsible for the partition of the Indian subcontinent claimed that it was done for the noble goal of seeking justice for one particular community, which was considered the main minority community. Similarly, those who are now waging a struggle for

reservation of government jobs for the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, etc., claim that they are fighting for social and economic justice for the weaker and backward sections of society.

Of late, even extremists claim that their fight is for obtaining political freedom and for the human right of self-determination. Now, even if we suppose that the struggle waged by the above-mentioned groups or individuals, or by others mentioned in history, has been for a noble goal or a good cause, the question arises about the means used to achieve their professed goal. Have the means adopted in each one of the above cases also been worthy?

Looking at the historical facts, one would find that some of these struggles or protests indulged in gory acts of bloodshed of hundreds of thousands of people, and they created a deep feud against the capitalist world, thus leading to large-scale armament build-up. In their struggle for a classless society, they led to the creation of antagonistic groups or countries locked in global conflicts of various sorts.

The means adopted by the leaders for forcing the partition of India resulted in unparalleled communal carnage and genocide on a mass scale. Similarly, the strategies of those who want reservation for backward castes and the approach and means adopted by militants also have led to great strife and the latter, in particular, have led to killings, abduction, and fear.

It is easy to romanticise revolution or justify conflict in the name of ideals, but one should remember that lasting peace can never emerge from paths paved with violence. In the process of pursuing justice, if we lose our sense of humanity, the very purpose of that justice becomes diluted. So, the analysis of events of history leads us to the conclusion that if we wish peace for ourselves and the world, and if we aspire that bloody strife should end, then we must first review our goal and see if it is really correct

and noble, and then we should double-check whether our means are also noble. Let us remember that the means are as important as the goal. The greatest transformations in history have not always come from force, but from the strength of inner conviction and peaceful resistance. Leaders like Mahatma Gandhi and Martin Luther King Jr. taught the world that non-violence, dialogue, and moral clarity have the power to dismantle oppressive systems without bloodshed. In today's fractured world, where lines between activism and aggression are often blurred, we must return to the wisdom of these ideals. True peace is not just the absence of war, but the presence of compassion, understanding, and ethical integrity in both our vision and our methods. So, let our future struggles, if any, be defined not by the wounds they cause, but by the healing they bring.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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WHEN EVERY SIDE NEEDS INDIA, IT MUST ACT WISELY

India's carefully cultivated neutrality has gradually transformed into something far more valuable - strategic indispensability. Years of sustaining working relationships with rival powers, without binding itself exclusively to any, have earned India a position that few nations occupy today. The unfolding West Asia crisis is now putting that hard-won standing to its most demanding test yet.

What makes this moment particularly significant is that all sides – the US, Israel, Iran, and the Gulf states – simultaneously need India's ear. That rarely happens. Historically, non-alignment was principled abstention. Today, under Modi and Jaishankar, it has evolved into active, multi-vector engagement. India is no longer

watching from the sidelines; it is operating as an indispensable node in a network with few other common points.

But diplomatic access, however valuable, has a shelf life. It must be converted into tangible outcomes – ceasefire facilitation, safe passage for stranded vessels, stable energy corridors, and protection of the Indian diaspora across the Gulf.

India's BRICS presidency adds another lever. Using it purposefully, rather than procedurally, could make a meaningful difference. Back-channel diplomacy, quiet mediation, and confidence-building between Tehran and Washington are areas where India's credibility with both sides gives it genuine utility.

A MYILSAMI | Coimbatore

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Lift safety cannot be ignored

Kolkata's RG Kar Medical College is back in the news. A patient's father was killed after he was trapped along with his family inside a lift when it malfunctioned at the hospital's trauma centre. He reportedly was stuck either between the lift doors or between the lift and the wall.

It goes without saying that lifts or elevators should be regularly monitored and their upkeep must be foolproof. Secure electric connections, temperature maintenance, and lubrication of parts cannot be taken for granted. Checking the functionality of doors through periodic check-ups is extremely essential. Door sensors have to be kept in good condition.

Monthly or quarterly servicing must be undertaken. Scrupulous adherence to annual maintenance contracts (AMCs) should be mandatory. Timely audits cannot be bypassed. Traction elevators are more effective in larger buildings.

Old and worn-out elevators should make way for newer ones. Nowadays, lift operators are conspicuous by their absence. Also, the majority of them are untrained. Proper training and supervision are necessary to avoid such tragic incidents in the future. Safety cannot be compromised in public institutions, especially hospitals, where lives already hang in the balance.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

CAPF officers deserve leadership roles

In recent times, both social media and traditional media have witnessed active discussion on the CAPF (General Administration) Bill 2026. The Bill has sparked debate, particularly among Indian Police Service (IPS) and CAPF officers, who have publicly expressed their concerns regarding the provisions related to the proposed role of IPS officers.

Having served in the Armed Forces, I have reasonable insight into the functioning of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs). My experience provides practical insight into their structure and deployment in challenging environments. The backbone of the CAPFs lies in their units and sub-units, led by subordinate and CAPF officers, often deployed far from headquarters for internal security, law and order, elections, and protection of vital installations.

It is the cadre officers who are exposed to complex and challenging situations in the field. They coordinate with local administration and other security forces to fulfil both operational and administrative directives. Considering this, the claim that IPS officers alone possess wider experience is far from reality. CAPF officers possess the necessary qualifications and experience to be promoted to higher positions currently held by IPS officers.

PRAKASH BHATT | NOIDA

Nuclear threat remarks are irrational

The remarks of Abdul Basit, the former Pakistan High Commissioner to India, that "if the US were to ever attack Pakistan's nuclear arsenal, Islamabad would launch retaliatory strikes against New Delhi and Mumbai", are illogical and senseless. His comments are in response to the US National Intelligence Director Tulsi Gabbard's assessment before a Senate committee that "Pakistan's nuclear missiles are a future threat to the US". Basit argues that in the event of a conflict with the US and Israel, since the former is not within Pakistan's immediate nuclear range, India would become the default target.

This reflects a crab mentality, like a man who lost both his eyes finding satisfaction in a neighbour losing one. It is surprising that such remarks come not from a trigger-happy Pakistan general but from a former diplomat. The US has no military base in India, unlike in some West Asian nations targeted in the US-Israel-Iran conflict. Pakistan may partially succeed in its attempt, but if India were to retaliate, it may be wiped out from the face of the earth. Such an eventuality will not be a victory for either, but a colossal failure of diplomacy, statecraft, and human imagination. One hopes Basit is not echoing his government.

V JAYARAMAN | CHENNAI

Degrees but no job: Is a college education still worth it?

India possesses one of the youngest populations in the world, a demographic advantage that could fuel economic transformation. But this potential can only be realised if the country's education system is closely aligned with the shifting demands of the global economy

FIRST
Column



DINESH
SOOD

For decades, millions of Indian students have followed a familiar economic script: study hard, earn a college degree, and a stable job will follow. This belief, shaped by the 1990s era of economic liberalisation, evolved into an unwritten social contract between schooling and work.

Yet recent evidence suggests that this contract is rapidly weakening. A recent report by Azim Premji University reveals a striking reality: “around 67 per cent of India's unemployed youth today are graduates. In 2023 alone, roughly 1.1 crore unemployed young people were degree holders, a dramatic rise from 32 per cent in 2004”. Over the same period, the proportion of graduates in the youth population rose sharply—from about 10 per cent in 2004 to nearly 28 per cent in 2023.

These figures reveal a structural paradox in India's labour market. While access to higher education has expanded, the economy has not created enough high-quality jobs to absorb the growing number of graduates. The result is an emerging crisis: more degrees, but not enough employment.

For earlier generations, the formula worked. A college degree was rare and therefore highly valuable in the labour market. But the India of 2026 presents a different reality. Higher education has expanded rapidly, yet employment opportunities have not kept pace. As a result, the value of a conventional degree is steadily declining while youth unemployment continues to rise.

Degrees are rising faster than jobs

Data from the International Labour Organisation's India Employment Report 2024 paints a troubling picture. According to the report, “young people account for nearly 83 per cent of India's total unemployed population. Even more alarming is that graduate unemployment is nearly nine times higher than that of individuals with little or no formal education.”

These figures raise a difficult but necessary question: does a college degree still guarantee economic mobility in India?

The problem today is not simply a short-



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age of jobs; it is the hyperinflation of degrees. Over the past two decades, the number of universities and colleges in India has expanded. While this expansion has increased access to higher education, it has also created a mismatch between what students learn and what industries need.

The economics of signalling and the declining value of degrees

Economists describe part of this phenomenon via signalling theory. A degree does not simply certify knowledge; it also signals certain qualities to employers—discipline, perseverance, and the ability to complete organised tasks.

When graduates were relatively few, that signal held substantial weight. But when millions of students graduate each year with similar qualifications, the signal becomes diluted.

A Mercer-Mettl India Graduate Skill Index (2024-25) report reveals that only about 55 per cent of Indian graduates are considered employable for modern industry roles. In other words, nearly half of India's degree holders enter the labour market without the skills employers actually require.

One reason for this gap lies in the slow pace of curriculum reform. University syllabi often take years to update, while

the digital economy evolves almost weekly. As a result, students graduate with outdated knowledge that does not match contemporary business demands.

Artificial Intelligence and the end of generic knowledge work

Technological disruption, particularly the rise of Artificial Intelligence (AI), has accelerated this shift. Many knowledge-based tasks, once justified by white-collar employment, are now being automated. If a degree primarily trains students to perform routine analytical tasks, basic coding, or standardised reporting, those skills are rapidly losing economic value. AI systems can perform such tasks in seconds and at minimal cost.

Industry projections show this transformation. According to NASSCOM, India will require over one million specialised AI professionals by 2026 to meet growing technological demand. However, these roles require advanced, applied skills that cannot be acquired solely through outdated classroom lectures.

In other words, the modern economy does not simply reward what individuals know. It rewards what they can build, solve, and create.

Proof of Work in the Digital Economy
The internet-driven economy has intro-

duced a powerful shift in recruitment methods. Increasingly, employers and clients care less about formal credentials and more about demonstrable ability.

An aspiring AI engineer is judged by the projects visible on their GitHub profile. A digital writer or marketer is evaluated by their published articles, audience reach, or portfolio. A college degree may promise potential, but a public portfolio provides undeniable proof of competence. This transformation has created a more meritocratic environment where skill, creativity, and execution matter more than institutional pedigree.

The rise of parallel learning ecosystems

Recognising these realities, a parallel learning ecosystem is emerging across India. Web platforms, coding boot camps, digital learning hubs, and professional communities provide learners with practical skills that traditional institutions often fail to deliver.

These platforms emphasise project-based learning, industry exposure, and practical problem-solving. Many global technology firms are increasingly prioritising skills assessments and portfolio-based hiring instead of purely academic credentials.

Decisive Initiative of BBSSL: Towards self-reliance in the seed sector



RAMANI
KUMAR

India is an agrarian country where a large section of the population depends directly or indirectly on agriculture. With changing times, agriculture is no longer merely a means of livelihood; it has become a central pillar of self-reliance, food security, and rural economic development. In any agricultural system, seed is considered the most critical input because crop productivity, quality, and farmers' income are directly dependent on seed quality. At the global level, the seed industry is undergoing rapid technological transformation. Advanced biotechnology, artificial intelligence-based agriculture, and organised supply chain systems are taking this sector to new heights. Regions such as North America lead the industry, while the Asia-Pacific region, particularly India, has emerged as a rapidly growing and significant market.

In this context, the establishment of Bharatiya Beej Sahakari Samiti Limited (BBSSL) is regarded as a historic initiative. This institution is not merely a commercial organisation but a national cooperative movement rooted in farmers' participation, aiming to make the country self-reliant in seed production and to provide high-quality certified seeds to farmers. BBSSL has been formed in alignment with the vision of “Self-Reliant India” and “Prosperity through Cooperation.”

Global seed market and India's position

In 2024, the global seed market was estimated at approximately Rs 4 lakh crore. North America leads the sector due to precision farming, advanced machinery, and strong supply chain infrastructure. Meanwhile, within the Asia-Pacific region, India is emerging rapidly as a key seed market. India's seed industry was valued at Rs 67,858 crore in 2024 and is projected to reach Rs 1,65,295 crore by 2033. An estimated annual growth rate of around 10.5 per cent highlights the sector's strong potential. Diverse agro-climatic conditions, contributions from research institutions, and government support are accelerating this growth. However, India continues to face challenges such as counterfeit seeds, limited access to quality seeds, and inadequate modern storage facilities. The establishment of BBSSL represents a structured and coordinated effort to address these issues. BBSSL was established with an initial capital of Rs 250 crore, contributed



equally by five major cooperative institutions—Indian Farmers Fertiliser Cooperative Limited (IFFCO), Krishak Bharati Cooperative Limited (KRIBHCO), National Agricultural Cooperative Marketing Federation of India (NAFED), National Cooperative Development Corporation (NCDC), and National Dairy Development Board (NDDB). Its authorised share capital has been fixed at Rs 500 crore. Operating under the brand name “Bharat Beej,” the organisation promotes indigenous seed production to reduce dependence on imports.

It is a national-level multi-state cooperative seed society, with its registered office located at WTC Tower, New Delhi. Its membership extends from Primary Agricultural Credit Societies (PACS) to state and national-level cooperative institutions. Breeder seeds for production are sourced from the Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR), state agricultural universities, and other national and international institutions.

Objectives and operational framework

The primary objective of BBSSL is to provide farmers with high-quality certified seeds, promote domestic seed production, and reduce import dependence. The organisation places special emphasis on developing climate-resilient and disease-resistant seed varieties. Strengthening farmers economically by integrating cooperative institutions into the value chain is also a key priority. Additionally, increasing the Seed Replacement Rate (SRR) and Variety Replacement Rate (VRR), along with ensuring transparency through a QR code-based traceability system, are among BBSSL's core strategic initiatives.

Strategic operations and achievements

BBSSL procures breeder seeds from reputed research institutions, produces foundation and certified seeds, and supplies them to farmers. The organisation invests in research

and development to develop drought-tolerant, pest-resistant, and high-yielding varieties capable of addressing climate change challenges. Through the expansion of its distribution network, BBSSL is ensuring the availability of certified seeds even in remote regions of the country. From a statistical perspective, the organisation has made notable progress. So far, it has received more than 35,524 membership applications and issued 34,078 share certificates. In the financial year 2025-26, it distributed 2,70,167 quintals of seeds, generating an operational revenue of Rs 177 crore. During Kharif 2025-26, seed production was carried out over 11,125.68 hectares, resulting in 1,99,501 quintals of output, while for Rabi 2025-26, production of 7,04,388 quintals is estimated. The organisation has set an ambitious target of achieving a turnover of Rs 25,000 crore by 2035.

Vision 2035: A Self-Reliant Seed Powerhouse
BBSSL aims to become one of the world's top five seed-producing organisations by 2035. To achieve this, it is expanding research based on artificial intelligence and genomics, strengthening local production systems, reducing import dependence, organising farmer training and demonstration plots, and adopting environmentally sustainable production practices.

Conclusion

Bharatiya Beej Sahakari Samiti Limited (BBSSL) represents a historic and transformative initiative in India's seed industry. Through its cooperative-based model, the organisation is providing a new direction to agricultural productivity, food security, and rural prosperity. By integrating quality, transparency, technology, and cooperation, BBSSL is emerging as a strong pillar in realising the vision of a self-reliant India.

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From AI to legal Intelligence: Strengthening governance



NIRMAL
SINGH

India's technological rise has entered a decisive phase. For decades, the world viewed India largely as an IT services powerhouse—efficient, reliable, and cost-effective. Today, that perception is changing fundamentally. India is no longer merely supporting global digital systems; it is building and exporting them.

The next frontier in this evolution is not just Artificial Intelligence (AI), but Legal Intelligence (LI). As India's economy expands and regulatory frameworks grow more complex, governance systems must evolve accordingly. A nation aspiring to be a \$5 trillion economy cannot depend solely on manual compliance systems, prolonged arbitration processes, and procedural bottlenecks. Speed, transparency, and institutional efficiency are now central to economic competitiveness and investor confidence. Artificial Intelligence, when applied responsibly, can serve as a powerful enabler of governance reform.

However, generic AI models are insufficient for India's layered legal and constitutional architecture. Our federal structure, sector-specific regulations, evolving taxation frameworks, labour codes, and judicial precedents require systems that are context-aware and rooted in Indian realities. Legal Intelligence must be designed with a deep understanding of constitutional values, due process, and regulatory nuance.

Equally important is the question of sovereignty. Legal and regulatory data is strategically sensitive. As India builds digital public infrastructure across sectors — from payments to identity management — it must ensure that AI systems supporting governance are aligned with national priorities and data security imperatives. Dependence on external technological frameworks in such critical domains may create long-term vulnerabilities.

In this context, recent developments signal a promising shift. CognexiaAI recently launched an AI-native Legal Intelligence platform—India's first-in Mumbai, aimed at supporting arbitration, compliance, and institutional processes. The effort reflects an emerging confidence among Indian technologists to address governance challenges through domain-specific innovation rather than generic automation.

This initiative is part of a larger transformation underway in India's technology ecosys-

tem. CognexiaAI has also secured ₹540 crore in enterprise contracts across Australia and New Zealand for its AI-driven ERP and CRM platforms.

While commercial in nature, these global wins highlight a deeper shift: Indian companies are no longer competing only on cost efficiency, but on performance, scalability, and intellectual property ownership.

High-value AI exports contribute directly to foreign exchange inflows, strengthen India's digital trade position, and expand global demand for Indian engineering and domain expertise. Increasingly, Indian talent is travelling abroad not as outsourced support, but as architects of intelligent systems.

Yet technology must serve a higher institutional purpose. Legal Intelligence should augment, not replace, human judgment. Judges, policymakers, compliance officers, and legal professionals bring interpretative wisdom rooted in constitutional balance. AI can assist by accelerating research, identifying regulatory overlaps, streamlining documentation, and reducing procedural delays—while remaining transparent and auditable.

Accountability must remain central. In governance systems, algorithms cannot function as opaque black boxes. Ethical guardrails, explainable AI, and regulatory oversight are essential to preserve public trust.

India has already demonstrated how digital infrastructure can scale securely and inclusively. The next logical extension of that success lies in modernising legal and regulatory systems with equal ambition.

At this juncture, the evolution from Artificial Intelligence to Legal Intelligence aligns closely with the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat. Technological self-reliance is not confined to manufacturing or strategic sectors; it extends to digital architecture, governance platforms, and institutional frameworks. Building sovereign AI capabilities for legal and regulatory processes strengthens national resilience and reduces strategic dependency. The transition to Legal Intelligence is therefore not merely technological progress. It is an affirmation that India can design systems rooted in its constitutional ethos while competing globally on innovation and excellence. If harnessed responsibly, Legal Intelligence can help India build governance mechanisms that are faster, fairer, and globally respected. In doing so, it will not only enhance institutional efficiency but also reinforce the foundations of a confident and self-reliant Republic.

The Pioneer
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STEADY, SET, **STOP**

The figures are as stark as they can be. The education ministry states that the number of Indian students going abroad dropped from more than 9,00,000 in 2023 to just over 6,00,000 in 2025, or a massive drop of 30 per cent. Monthly outward remittances to fund overseas education has declined from more than \$400 million in August 2024 to \$165 million in December 2025, or a steep drop nearing 60 per cent. The drop is universal across the major education destinations such as the US, the UK, and Canada. The figures reveal several trends that have gone unnoticed, or were overlooked by experts and policy-makers. First, this indicates that the decline in students' interest, or inability to go, is not quite related to the India-US issues related to visas over the past 12 months, or the new norms that were introduced in the recent past. The decline began in 2024, and accelerated in 2025.

One of the prime reasons is finances. Over the years, and especially in the recent past, mainstream, and renowned global colleges and universities have hiked fees. In addition, the cost-of-living expenses have zoomed across major cities, including campus towns, in the post-Covid period. The double impact on prices has scaled down expectations. For instance, earlier there were families that were ready to encourage children to get graduate degrees from abroad. Now, there is an insistence to pursue post-graduation since it involves lower expenditure because of the shorter-duration courses. Monthly EMIs on education loans can stretch up to ₹1,00,000 for Ivy League colleges, and require huge salaries to pay them off in 3-5 years. In some cases, if the salaries are not high, the repayment can take 10-15 years. Given the geopolitical situation since 2022, when Russia attacked Ukraine, and going on till the Iran war, students are not confident of bagging financially-lucrative jobs abroad, and that too for longer periods.

Jobs are, as we know, difficult to get. In the US, as we know, things have become tough after Donald Trump took over as the president for the second time. Due to the restraints on H-1B visas, two headaches have cropped up for the students. Their ability to transition to H-1Bs is limited as Indian firms rely less on the visas due to high fees, and the new salary-linked system that will operate from this month. This acts as a negative for the students, who wish to graduate to H-1B, and possibly a green card within a few years. Across states, firms are cagey to hire younger, lower-level foreigners, including Indians, especially those who are fresh out of colleges. Even a bulk of graduate Americans fail to find entry-level or first jobs, and remain unemployed. For the Indian students, who need to pay the loans, the situation is sticky, as they need well-paid jobs to pay EMIs, and lead decent lives in the US.

In the UK, according to a media report, youngsters need higher finances to stay in cities. London is exorbitant and expensive. Even the smaller cities are expensive. Recently, the UK changed the laws for dependents. Now, restrictions are imposed on dependents of care workers, some medium-skilled workers, and students, with the "latter now limited largely to post-graduate-level or government-sponsored studies." Although the dependent criteria may not apply to students, many individuals who pursue higher studies are married, and others wish to bring their aged parents abroad for several reasons. In the UK, the dependents are generally spouses, partners, or children, and their visas last until the main applicant's. Dependents need to show that they can support themselves without public funds and, for skilled workers, this may entail showing their own funds. Dependents cannot travel outside the UK "until a decision is made on their application."

Even those, who are studying abroad, are assessing their options based on financial statuses, jobs availability, and living expenses. Obviously, there are a set of students, who are forced to come back despite the burden of EMIs and loans. But there are those who deliberately choose not to extend their stay after course completion, or come back sooner than they intended to. A growing section, unlike the past mindset, does not wish to stay abroad, or gain citizenships. Their intention is to work abroad only till the loan is repaid. Hence, their ideal period to remain overseas after education is 3-4 years. There are others who never intended to work abroad. They go abroad to study, and come back to handle family businesses, launch start-ups, or become consultants in India. Global education is no longer linked mainly to migration. Many make a conscious decision to come back, and work in India.

Even among the youngsters, as is evident among the mid-managers, and senior executives, working abroad has emerged as a solution to acquire multiple skills through short-term stints abroad, including short-period courses that range from a few months to a year. The idea is to reset skills to prepare for a new emerging world, where tech and AI may change the nature of jobs and workplaces. Hence, the newcomers and old-timers wish to prepare themselves for such changes through acquisition of multiple skills in short bursts over a few years.

The Pioneer

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BUSINESS

10

Crude confusions confound crisis

Worst energy crisis since the 1970s looms ahead, says IEA

The current situation is "very severe," states the International Energy Agency (IEA). The scale of the shock, and the crisis may exceed the twin 'crude' shocks of the 1970s (1973 and 1979), and the rude one after the Russia-Ukraine war in 2022. "This crisis... is now two oil crises, and one gas (Russia) crisis put together," warned Fatih Birol, the head of the IEA. This is the gravest warning that has emanated from a global expert agency, whose understanding of the energy markets is immense. Yesterday, the Indian Sensex was down by more than 1,800 points, albeit a 100 points over the intra-day low.

Decisions by the world leaders, especially the Americans, hint at a similar analysis. In the past few days, the US allowed Russia to sell oil, and even urged Iran to sell its oil despite the western sanctions against both nations. The US president, Donald Trump, then gave a 48-hour ultimatum to Iran to open the Strait of Hormuz, or the US would "hit and obliterate" the latter's power plants. Just before the end of the ultimatum, Trump declared "peace through strength," and described it as being put "mildly." Iran responded with a similar paradox.

First, Teheran said that it would allow tankers to pass through the Strait, except for the enemy vessels that included the American ones. Later, after the 48-hour ultimatum, Teheran mocked Trump. "Hey, Trump, you are fired. You are familiar with this sentence. Thank you for your attention to this matter." The first line echoed the language the US president used when he hosted the show, The Apprentice. The last one is the typical Trump sign off in his social media posts. After the "hit" warning, Teheran stated that it would retaliate.

"If Iran's fuel and energy infrastructure is attacked by the enemy, all energy infrastructure, as well as information technology, and water desalination facilities, belonging to the US and the regime in the region will be targeted pursuant to previous warnings," screamed Teheran. This was days after Iran unleashed a long-distance missile to attack ships in the distant ocean, a move that stunned and shocked several military observers. Not many realised that it had this capability. Teheran's missiles seem to have a longer range than expected.

Of course, the IEA is concerned about the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz, which is the oil lifeline, and main transport artery for global energy flows. It triggered the largest-ever supply shock, much larger than those of the 1970s, which disrupted economies. Hence, the flames in the Middle East can easily engulf and envelope the economies in Asia, Americas, Europe, and Africa. In fact, no nation is safe. As Birol said, it is no longer about oil and gas, as "some of the vital arteries of the global economy, their trade, is interrupted."

Social media is full of insights, pieces, articles, and blogs by experts and amateurs on how this crisis has expanded beyond crude. In fact, crude is an extremely 'crude' explanation of it. Now, there are talks about how fertiliser supplies will be derailed, how the lack of sulfur will affect mining in sensitive metals and minerals, and how the manufacturing related to artificial intelligence, smartphones, and tech gadgets will be hit. Lower refinery production of petrochemicals will impact the textile sectors, and manufacture of plastics. The list goes on.

Large consumers like India and China are scouring for new sources, any sources, to acquire crude oil, and other products like liquefied petroleum gas (LPG). This is despite the IEA stating that it will release 400 million barrels from the emergency strategic reserves. Iran apparently allowed two Indian ships carrying LPG. New Delhi plans to purchase double the quantity from Washington, which has pushed the former to buy energy from it for more than 12 months. China is relying on Russia, as is India, as also smuggled and legal oil supplies from Iran.

In media interviews, IEA's Birol explained that even if the war ends soon, the destruction in the Middle East will require months before the energy assets come back to normal operations and supplies. "It will take six months for some (sites) to be operational, others much longer," he said in one of the interviews. According to him, the world leaders and policy-makers were underestimating the scale of the disruptions, and nearly a fifth of the oil and gas supplies were stranded. The leaders possibly do not want to scare away their citizens, and potential voters, by airing extreme negative views. They wish to convey things are under control, even if they are not, and the keys are with the others.

Different consumer nations have reacted differently over the past three weeks. China has enhanced illegal sourcing from Russia and Iran, apart from paying huge premiums to divert oil and gas. India did the same, and a ship bound for China took a U-Turn mid-ocean, and sailed to India. Prices of some of the products, including LPG, have gone up, either marginally or steeply. India has asked refiners to hike LPG production, and curtail others. Bangladesh and Thailand have begun to ration fuel, and draw on internal emergency reserves.

For a country like India, there was a lucky respite, as temperatures came down dramatically and suddenly in North India over the past several days. This reduced the demand for power, as before the cold wave, households had begun to use ACs and coolers. But with the hot season around the corner, if the war continues, power demand will peak. The annual coal production of over a billion tonnes for the second year in row has provided some confidence. Officials are in talks with the coal miners, including the state-owned near-monopolist, to gauge whether there is enough fuel, or can production be ramped up further.

According to a media report, "The country has enough generation during daytime to meet the surge in demand.... The evening, when nearly 140 GW of solar capacity is idle, can be trickier. That could be compounded by disrupted supplies of liquefied natural gas, putting more pressure on coal-powered plants. India's summer starts in April, but in recent years the nation has seen temperatures rising from March (though there was a respite this year). There is an increased likelihood of more heatwave days across many parts of the country in the three months to May 31, the Indian Met Department said earlier."

OUR TAKE

Asansol (West Bengal):

Mamata's love-hate with industry

TMC and BJP grapple with industrial paradoxes in West Bengal

In the runup to the assembly elections in April 2026, both the ruling and opposition parties seem to be arm-twisting with economic contradictions. The BJP has doled out the promise of "bringing jobs back." Its leaders, including the central ones, rebuke Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee of giving doles to assuage the feelings of the people afflicted with massive industrial decline in the state. Yet, Niti Aayog's analysis, "Macro and Fiscal Landscape of the State of West Bengal (2025)," shows that the state's annual unemployment decelerated to 2.2 per cent in 2022-23, and remained below the national average (3.2 per cent) since 2017-18.

Mamata Banerjee, whose rise to power was based on her opposition to large industrial projects, Tata and Salim Group, and related massive land acquisitions plans, is known for welfare policies, and sops for the poor, women, and other sections. Her vision is that of welfare-led growth. Yet, she claims that the business houses promised to invest a huge Rs 1.33 lakh crore in 2025, with projects in steel, petrochemicals, and logistics. The state's industrial growth in 2024-25 was 7.3 per cent, or above the national average (6.2 per cent).

Ground realities may seem positive or negative depending on whose supporter one is. "I agree that MSMEs have come to the region, but it will not provide as many jobs as we need today. We need at least one large industry in the Paschim Bardhaman district," says Sambhunath Jha, Hon. Secretary, Asansol Chamber of Commerce. His pleas are based on how a large factory has spillover and multiplier effects due to indirect jobs, and chain of logistic ventures. Moreover, there was a time when Asansol was a part of an industrial hub; today, most of the private factories, which were nationalised, are closed.

Jha cites several political, social, and economic reasons for the so-called industrial decline in the region. Since the 1970s, when the Left Front regime took over, and ruled for 34 years, followed by Mamata's reign since 2011, the state governments were opposed to the central regimes. Hence, "there was a lack of coordination," he adds. Towards the fag end of its tenure, the Left Front wooed private investments, with promises from leading business houses, but the plans did not

Honorary Secretary of the Asansol Chamber of Commerce, Sambhunath Jha

fructify. Mamata's political ascendance was based on a rhetoric, or logic that was anti-industry, or rather anti-prime land acquisitions for private factories.

At the economic policy level, Jha is angered by a policy reversal in March last year. Decades ago, the former Left chief minister, Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee, introduced an industry-specific incentive scheme to encourage investments. This was withdrawn by Mamata Banerjee's government. "While other states invite industries, and offer subsidies, in West Bengal, not only was the incentive stopped but the industrialists were told to return what they received since 1993. This is not feasible," contends Jha. Many experts feel that these are regressive measures that will further distance the business community.

"We made representations, and urged the local MP (Shatrughan Sinha of Trinamool Congress) to highlight the problems in Parliament, and before the central government. We have not heard anything," he laments. "Unlike other states, where the regimes acquire land for industries, West Bengal offers land to only SMEs, and not the larger industries. The latter are expected to acquire land themselves.

There is land available, some of it belonging to the erstwhile closed-down central units, which can be handed over for the larger factories," suggests Jha.

What has happened to the industries is reflected in the state of employment. Despite the low unemployment rates, jobs are difficult to get. Hence, complains a local restaurant manager, a state that attracted workforce from the other states like Assam, Bihar, and Bangladesh, exports labour. "Residents prefer to leave the state for better options," he adds. "The only way to stop this exodus, and even contain (reduce) regional violence is to industrialise, and create jobs. Once there is scope for income, other things will cease," feels Jha.

Most experts are unanimous that except for the presence of the IISCO steel plant, there are no major industries in the region.

Even the size and influence of the Eastern Coalfields is down over the years. "The mainstay for the Asansol region is the Indian Railways," says Jha. But there was a time, not too long ago, when steel, engineering, and allied industries grew around the major coal and rail links. Large plants and ancillary units created dense industrial townships. But

most of them were nationalised, and went out of business, leaving barren land.

Technological obsolescence, and ownership changes undermined their competitiveness. Many of the older mills and factories could not modernise, and aggressive trade unions, and policy issues led to several strikes and lockouts. Nationalisation and restructuring altered the industrial map. With the state takeovers of non-coking coal, and major steel firms, and their mergers with larger public sector units, there was a complete change in the local employment patterns. Mining patterns shifted, mainly from underground to open-cast operations, and the abandonment of less-viable mines reduced local employment.

Hence, the entire industrial ecosystem ruptured, and decimated. As the bigger units fell by the wayside, the smaller ancillary units, and engineering units that depended on the larger supply and value chains closed shop, or downsized. There was urban decay, loss of jobs, difficult social lives, as societal structures broke down. Since land is an emotive, politically-sensitive issue, especially farmlands and productive ones, as Mamata Banerjee's rise shows, industry took a back seat. Even the vacant land either lay vacant, or was occupied by outsiders, who turned voters. Legal disputes over the ownership between state-owned entities ensured that they were neither used for new units nor reused.

So, when the BJP talks about bringing growth back, rising on double-engine (Centre-State) growth, it insists that there will be no acquisitions of farmlands to blunt Mamata's barbs. When Trinamool Congress talks about welfare-led growth, and its positive efforts to woo private money, there is little talk of land. In effect, the revival of industry depends on the ability to do so with either minimal purchase of land from the farmers, or use of existing barren land. But even in those cases, corruption-related controversies will be inevitable.

In West Bengal, land is a political-economic landmine. No politician can confidently tread the dangerous path. If one does it, it will be at their own peril, and can lead to dangerous outcomes. While industry is an election issue, it needs to be handled with a lot of care.

(The author has more than three decades of experience across print, TV, and digital media)

India is building data centres. The economics of AI is pointing beyond earth

As power, land and cooling limits tighten on Earth, the most energy-intensive AI workloads may shift to space — challenging India's infrastructure bet



At the very moment India is inviting the world's data centres onto its soil, the logic of where computation belongs is beginning to shift — away from the ground altogether.

Over the past two years, India has moved decisively to position itself as a global hub for digital infrastructure. States are competing to attract data centres with land allocations, power assurances, and expedited approvals. Industrial groups are committing billions to expand capacity. The argument is straightforward: in an AI-driven economy, hosting compute is a source of long-term economic and strategic advantage.

That argument still holds. But it rests on an assumption that is becoming less certain — that the future of large-scale computation will remain anchored to Earth.

The constraint behind AI infrastructure today is not demand. It is the cost of sustaining that demand within physical systems that were never designed for it.

Electricity consumption is the most visible symptom, but it is not the most important one. According to the



International Energy Agency, data centres already consume roughly 415 terawatt-hours annually — about 1.5–2 per cent of global electricity demand — and that share is rising. Yet the real pressure is not global — it is local. AI workloads are clustering in specific regions, pushing grids, cooling systems, and land availability to their limits.

What appears as growth at the global level behaves as saturation at the regional level. In major hubs, data centres are no longer just large consumers of electricity; they are becoming dominant ones. In Northern Virginia, now the world's largest data centre cluster, utilities are already warning of grid strain, while cities like Amsterdam and Singapore have imposed restrictions on new capacity. Governments are beginning to slow approvals — not because capital is unavailable, but because infrastructure cannot keep pace.

AI demand compounds annually. Infrastructure expands in steps. Power grids take years to build. Transmission equipment faces multi-year supply constraints. Cooling depends on water resources that are increasingly scarce. Land near high-capacity transmission corridors is finite and contested.

The result is a simple but underappreciated change: the cost of adding the next unit of compute is no longer determined primarily by chips or capital. It is determined by everything around them. For a time, this pressure can be managed geographically. Workloads move to regions with cheaper power.

Data centres are colocated with energy generation. Hyperscale firms negotiate directly with utilities.

This isn't a long-term fix. It rearranges the problem within the same limits. Even with advances in efficiency and alternative energy, the rate of AI demand growth

continues to outpace the speed at which terrestrial infrastructure can adapt. And when a problem cannot be solved inside a system, the system itself stops being sufficient. This is where the conversation begins to change.

For decades, the idea of putting large-scale computing in space was dismissed. The costs made it impractical, and launch expenses kept computation firmly on Earth. That assumption is now starting to crack.

Launch costs have fallen from over \$20,000 per kilogram in the Shuttle era to roughly \$2,000 — \$3,000 today on reusable systems, with further reductions anticipated. Companies like SpaceX are pushing this curve downward, while firms such as Axiom Space, alongside initiatives within NASA and the European Space Agency, are already exploring the architecture of orbital computing.

This does not make space inexpensive. But it brings it into a range where it can be compared — not to ideal conditions on Earth, but to increasingly constrained ones. And that comparison is where things become interesting. Because space changes the constraint equation in ways that align directly with the pressures now facing AI. Energy in orbit is not tied to terrestri-

al grids. Solar generation operates with near-continuity, largely unaffected by weather and far less constrained by day-night cycles. For compute systems that require sustained, high-density power, this is not a marginal advantage. It is a structural one.

Cooling, one of the most resource-intensive aspects of data centres, can be handled through radiative heat dissipation into space. On Earth, cooling consumes both energy and water, often becoming a limiting factor in where infrastructure can be deployed. And perhaps most importantly, space removes the constraint of land. There are no zoning restrictions, no local opposition, no competition for high-capacity transmission corridors.

The constraints do not disappear. They change — from geography to engineering. This distinction matters because not all computing workloads are equally sensitive to location. The most energy-intensive layers of the AI stack — training large models, running simulations, processing massive datasets — are already geographically flexible. They are not latency-sensitive. They are driven by throughput.

These are also the workloads placing the greatest strain on terrestrial systems. To be clear, this does not imply that AI is about to "move to space" in any complete sense. Real-time applications, inference systems, and user-facing services will remain Earth-bound. Bandwidth limitations and latency make that unavoidable.

But the transition does not need to be complete to be consequential.

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Cybersecurity trends and the expanding impact of AI: 2025-2026



MURALIDHARAN RAMACHANDRAN

Cybersecurity is undergoing its most profound transformation in decades. The convergence of accelerated digital adoption, expanding attack surfaces, and the explosive rise of artificial intelligence—both as a defensive tool and an offensive weapon—is reshaping the threat landscape. Recent industry research reveals a world where AI is no longer a future concern but a present force redefining risk, resilience, and response.

AI — The New Battleground: AI has become a double edged sword. On one side, organisations are using AI to detect threats faster, automate responses, and reduce breach costs. Extensive use of AI and automation has been shown to shorten breach lifecycles by 80 days and reduce breach costs by nearly \$1.9 million. On the other side, attackers are weaponising AI at scale. Studies show that 1 in 6 breaches now involve attackers using AI, most commonly through AI generated phishing (37 per cent) and deepfake impersonation (35 per cent). One notable case in 2025 involved an AI driven cyber espionage campaign where an autonomous AI tool executed 90 per cent of malicious actions without human intervention.

This marks a turning point in that AI is no longer an experimental tool for attackers and is an operational enabler.

Shadow AI — The Silent Risk Multiplier: One of the most alarming trends is the rise of shadow AI—unsanctioned AI tools used by employees without oversight. Around 20 per cent of organisations experienced breaches involving shadow AI, and these incidents added an average of \$670,000 to breach costs. Shadow AI incidents were also more likely to compromise sensitive data, especially customer PII (65 per cent). Ungoverned AI introduces new vectors for data leakage, model manipulation, and supply chain compromise.

The governance gap is stark with:

- 63 per cent of organisations lacking AI governance policies.
- only 34 per cent conducting regular audits for unsanctioned AI.
- 61 per cent lacking AI governance technologies.

Without governance, AI becomes a systemic risk rather than a strategic advantage.

Attack Surface Expansion — IoT, Edge, and Autonomous Systems: The attack surface is expanding faster than organisations can control. The proliferation of IoT devices, edge computing, and autonomous AI agents is creating a sprawling, interconnected environment where traditional perimeter security is obsolete. By 2026, an estimated 21-24 million connected devices will be in use



across homes, enterprises, and critical sectors. Many of these devices suffer from weak passwords, outdated firmware, and insecure APIs—conditions ripe for exploitation.

Industrial environments are particularly vulnerable. Nearly 22 per cent of OT systems recorded malicious activity in early 2025, with attacks affecting dams, water systems, and manufacturing plants.

The convergence of IT and OT means that a breach in a seemingly non critical system can cascade into physical disruption.

Zero trust becomes the operational baseline: Across the cybersecurity landscape,

one theme is consistent: identity is the new perimeter. With hybrid work, SaaS adoption, and distributed systems, Zero Trust is no longer optional—it is foundational. By 2026, Zero Trust is expected to shift from an innovative strategy to a survival standard, driven by regulatory pressure, cloud adoption, and the need to secure AI agents as digital identities.

Identity-human and machine-must be governed dynamically. Attackers are increasingly "logging in rather than hacking in," making identity governance and phishing resistant authentication essential.

Semiconductor technology: Turning India's dream to reality

India's landmark journey in semiconductor technologies: Sand-to-Silica to system on chips



T SENTHIL SIVA SUBRAMANIAN

India, a remarkable country in this planet due to rich natural source of raw materials such as chemicals, rare earth minerals, and gases, which is the need of the hour for the semiconductor supply chain.

India is the powerhouse of semiconductor transformation from Indian soil to silica and finally finished System on Chip [SoC]: VIKRAM 3201, SHAKTI Processors which are "Vocal for Local Indian Swadeshi semiconductor chips."

Global surge in advanced technologies urge India to become self-reliant in advanced semiconductor technologies. India established itself as a strong service nation for centuries. Although India has strong IT foundation, but our nation swiftly and safely makes an equivalent shift to a promising future by building a focused hardware base. It has pushed and crossed several boundaries of valley of death curve to build Swadeshi and Vocal for Local products in semiconductor technologies.

India's Karma Bhoomi is a land of fertile semiconductor valleys. Semiconductor valleys spread across each corner of our nation. The growing demand of chips in potential applications like power/energy (smart energy meters), automotive industry, critical healthcare applications, smart and precision farming, smart cities, aerospace, and telecommunication industry pushes India to the verge of establishing niche technologies in homeland thereby to meet the demand supply ecosystems of semiconductor chips across the globe.

India is making a big breakthrough to advance world's famous Moore's law through working on next generation iconic 2D materials like Graphene with 3D integration-architecture thereby achieving More than Moore philosophy. To realise this dream to reality, Indian industry leader, Larsen & Toubro Semiconductor Technologies is



establishing India's first 2D innovation hub in collaboration with Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bangalore to develop deep-scale wafer fabrication, prototype, and capacity building program. India has established first Centre of Excellence and innovation hub for 2D material — Graphene in Kerala which will boost the semiconductor research and innovation in 2D materials leading to achieve the Make in India Mantra through optimising Man, Machine, Material, and Money.

Global partners like Micron, Foxconn, Qualcomm, IBM, Intel, Google, Microsoft, Applied Materials, Texas Instruments and NVIDIA see a huge and rapid market growth for semiconductor chips in India and across the entire world. The best example for our nation is Texas Instruments which has strong link in Indian market for more than decades in electronic design systems.

The advent of Government of India's revolutionary schemes like production linked incentives and design linked incentives give a 'good push' for employment linked incentives. India establishes a strong connect between the design of chips from classroom to clean room. Semiconductor technology

has travelled a spectacular journey from Indian classroom to clean room chip fabrication.

Hon'ble Prime Minister of India Shri Narendra Modi vision towards the Viksit Bharat@2047 has paved the way for global partners like



Micron to launch the semiconductor assembly, testing, marking, and packaging of semiconductor devices in Sanand, Gujarat. Hon'ble Union Minister of Railways, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, and Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology, Government of India Shri Ashwini Vaishnaw had mentioned that "just imagine, writing the entire Ramcharitmanas on the nail of this thumb and entire book is like making a semiconductor."

This example reflects the significance of high precision, resolution, accuracy, sensitivity, and meticulous committed preparations by utilising advanced emerging nanoimprint lithography technologies deployed in Indian institutions and industries

which is required for semiconductor fabrication, manufacturing, and advanced characterisation tools and techniques.

India has the clean room facilities and fabrication laboratories at Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bangalore, Indian Institute of Technology, IIT Bombay and Nanoscale Research Facility at Indian Institute of Technology, IIT Delhi. India's collaboration and partnership with Micron have established the pioneering world's largest superpower Cleanroom facility aligning with global standards at the industrial set up in Gujarat, India.

Additionally, the India's IT major HCL joined hands with Foxconn to lay the foundation stone of semiconductor chip manufacturing plant in Uttar Pradesh.

This proves the foreign investments and innovation ecosystems to build a strong digital transformation public infrastructure in India. India has stepped into the sparkling journey of establishing a large-scale scalable semiconductor unit to manufacture the DRAM and NAND chips in India.

And India has successfully designed the pioneering 2nm chip in collaboration with Qualcomm addressing the gap of design and deployment.

Platformisation — Simplifying Complexity: Security complexity has become a threat in itself. Organisations often operate dozens of disconnected tools, creating blind spots and alert fatigue. There is a strong shift toward platformisation-unified cybersecurity ecosystems that consolidate telemetry, analytics, and response.

Security system complexity is one of the top factors that increase breach costs, while integrated SIEM and AI driven insights significantly reduce them. Platformisation enables.

- End to end visibility.
- Faster correlation of signals.
- Unified policy enforcement.
- Reduced operational overhead.

AI Governance — The Missing Pillar: The rapid adoption of AI has outpaced governance. Key gaps include:

- 87 per cent of organisations lack governance processes to mitigate AI risk.
- 61 per cent lack AI governance technologies.
- Most do not perform adversarial testing or model audits.

AI introduces risks such as prompt injection, data poisoning, insecure plugins, excessive agency, and model theft. These risks span the entire AI lifecycle—from data to deployment. Without governance, AI becomes unpredictable, opaque, and potentially dangerous.

The Road Ahead — Resilience Through Integration: The cybersecurity landscape of 2025-2026 is defined by acceleration of threats, technologies, and interdependencies. AI is amplifying both risk and defense.

Attack surfaces are expanding across devices, clouds, and autonomous systems. Governance gaps are widening. And geopolitical tensions are reshaping technology choices.

- The path forward requires:
- Integrated AI driven security platforms.
 - Robust AI governance frameworks.
 - Zero Trust as an operating principle.
 - Identity centric protection for humans and machines.
 - Continuous monitoring and rapid response capabilities.
 - Cross functional collaboration between security, IT, compliance, and business leaders.

Cybersecurity is no longer a technical function—it is a strategic imperative tied to trust, resilience, and competitiveness.

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Writer is a seasoned technology and governance professional with over 37 years of leadership experience across digital transformation, cybersecurity, and business strategy. As a writer, he brings a practitioner's perspective to complex technology and risk issues, translating them into insightful, boardroom-relevant commentary for business leaders and policymakers

Indian education ecosystems boost the semiconductor technology

Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, Government of India strengthened higher education institutions across India with world-class Electronic Design and Automation tools world-class Electronic Design Automation (EDA) being supported by global semiconductor simulation tool giants like Synopsys, Cadence, Siemens, Renesas, Ansys and AMD.

Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship, Govt. of India pushes National Educational Policy 2020 which has enabled different On-the-Job Training (OJT) demand programs across higher educational institutions like apprenticeship enabled degree/diploma programs, research based AICTE internships, community-based learning like MY Bharat, virtual labs, to build a strong talent pool in India thereby meet the growing demands for semiconductor job market.

Government of India under the flagship initiative of The Ministry of Tribal Affairs (MoTA) in collaboration with CeNSE Indian Institute of Science, IISc, Bangalore is building a nationwide capacity building training program specially crafted for tribal students.

It is a National Skill Qualification Framework (NSQF) certified semiconductor training program which has interesting features of both theory and first-hand courses of 60-hour and 90-hour foundation and advanced online and offline courses, respectively. These courses will train and empower the tribal students. Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bangalore in collaboration with Synopsys and Samsung is offering Cohort training/fellowship program under India Semiconductor Workforce Development Program for undergraduate engineering and science students.

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Please read the complete article online at [dailypioneer.com](#)

FROM THE WORLD

SLOVENIA

Liberals lead tight race

Slovenia's governing liberals and opposition right-wing populists were neck and neck after a highly contested parliamentary election on Sunday, near-complete preliminary results showed, heralding a period of political uncertainty in the small European Union country.

Prime Minister Robert Golob's centre-left Freedom Movement won 28.5 per cent of the votes while the right-wing Slovenian Democratic Party, or SDS, led by ex-premier Janez Jansa – an admirer of US President Donald Trump – had 28.1 per cent, the State Election Commission said after counting some 99 per cent of the ballots.

The practically equal result means that none of the main parties will have a majority in the 90-member parliament and that whoever will form a future Government will depend on smaller parties that will act as kingmakers.

FRANCE

Ex-PM Lionel dies at 88

French former Prime Minister Lionel Jospin, who gave France its 35-hour work week and then withdrew from politics after leading France's Socialist Party to an earth-shaking presidential election defeat against far-right firebrand Jean-Marie Le Pen, has died. He was 88.

His death was confirmed by the current prime minister, Sebastian Lecornu. Lecornu said in a post on X that Jospin "served France with constancy, rigour and a sense of responsibility" and that "his actions, guided by a certain vision of social progress and republican values, leave a lasting mark and a model of commitment." A touse of white curls and thick-rimmed glasses gave Jospin the trappings of the economics professor he was before being unexpectedly named as head of the Socialist Party in 1981 by newly elected President Francois Mitterrand.

Israel launched new attacks on Tehran and Lebanon

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai

Israel launched new attacks on Monday on the Iranian Capital, saying it had "begun a wide-scale wave of strikes" on infrastructure targets in Tehran without immediately elaborating. Explosions were heard in multiple locations in the afternoon. It wasn't immediately clear what had been hit.

The United Arab Emirates reported its air defence was attempting to intercept new incoming Iranian fire on Monday afternoon.

Israel has also targeted the Iran-linked Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon, while the group has fired hundreds of rockets into



Iranian Red Crescent emergency workers using a bulldozer to clear rubble from a residential building that was hit in an earlier US-Israeli strike in Tehran, Iran on Monday

Israel. In recent days, Israel has hit many apartment buildings in Beirut and bombed bridges over the Litani River in southern

Lebanon. Lebanese President Joseph Aoun called the targeting of bridges "a prelude to a ground invasion," while Egypt denounced the strikes as the

"collective punishment" of civilians for the actions of Hezbollah. Authorities say Israeli strikes have killed more than 1,000 people in

Lebanon and displaced more than 1 million.

Iran's death toll has surpassed 1,500, its Health Ministry has said. In Israel, 15 people have been killed by Iranian strikes. At least 13 US military members have been killed, along with more than a dozen civilians, in the occupied West Bank and Gulf Arab states.

Turkey silent on possible US-Iran mediation

Turkey's Foreign Ministry declined to comment Monday on whether the country had relayed messages between Iran and the United States.

On Sunday, however, Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan held telephone calls with

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi as well as his counterparts from Qatar, Saudi Arabia, Pakistan, Egypt, and the European Union.

Turkish officials also said he spoke with US officials as part of efforts to end the war, without providing further details. Fidan pressed ahead with his telephone diplomacy on Monday, making separate calls with his Pakistani, Norwegian and Egyptian counterparts.

Oman working to secure transit

Oman's top diplomat says his country, which has long mediated between the U.S. and Iran, was working to secure safe transit through the Strait of Hormuz. He did

not elaborate. Foreign Minister Bad Albusaidi also wrote in a social media post that Iran is not to be blamed for the war. "Whatever your view of Iran, this war is not of their making. This is already causing widespread economic problems," he wrote.

Egypt denounces Israel's strikes

"The deliberate destruction of infrastructure in Lebanon represents a blatant Israeli policy of collective punishment," the Egyptian Foreign Ministry said in a Monday statement. It criticized Israel's "systemic and deliberate" strikes, including on bridges on the Litani River in south Lebanon.

Hormuz open to friendly nations: Iran's envoy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Colombo

The Strait of Hormuz remains open to friendly countries, the Iranian envoy to Sri Lanka said on Monday, stressing that Tehran is ready to supply oil or other essential goods to the island nation if the need arises.

The conflict in West Asia, involving the US, Israel, and Iran, has led to the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, a key shipping route through which 20 per cent of the world's energy is transported. Iran, which controls the Strait of Hormuz, has allowed very few ships to cross it since the conflict started on February 28.

Addressing a press confer-



Alireza Delkhosh

ence, Iran's Ambassador to Sri Lanka Alireza Delkhosh said that the key strait remains open to friendly country vessels to pass. "Sri Lanka is our friendly country and as I told you, Hormuz is not closed to our friends

like Sri Lanka," he said. "If Sri Lanka demands oil or any other necessary goods, Iran will supply," he added. The conflict, which has roiled global oil markets, entered its fourth week, coinciding with which, the Sri Lankan Government hiked fuel prices by 25 per cent on Sunday.

It was the third fuel price hike by the Government since March 1. Speaking about an Iranian vessel which was torpedoed and sunk in international waters off Sri Lanka's coast by a US submarine earlier this month, the envoy said it was "not here for war".

"Dena was not ready for war. It was not here for con-

flict. It was participating in a peaceful exercise in India," he said, calling the targeting a violation of humanitarian law.

The Iranian warship IRIS Dena was returning after participating in the Milan naval exercise, a multilateral wargame hosted by India, when it was struck. At least 87 Iranian sailors were killed in the attack.

Delkhosh said that the Sri Lankan Government had invited the three Iranian vessels involved in the Milan exercise to visit the island nation. "This vessel, with the two other vessels, was invited by the Sri Lankan side to come here. And they came here upon their invitation," he said.

Global economy faces major threat because of Iran war, says IEA head

CHARLOTTE GRAHAM-MCLAY
Wellington

The head of the International Energy Agency said Monday that the global economy faces a "major, major threat" because of the Iran war.

"No country will be immune to the effects of this crisis if it continues to go in this direction," Fatih Birol told *Australia's National Press Club* in Canberra on Monday. He said the crisis in the Middle East has had a worse combined impact than the two oil shocks of the 1970s and the effect on gas markets of the Russia-Ukraine war.

His comments came as Israel launched a new wave



of attacks early on Monday against Tehran.

A top American commander also told Iranians to remain in shelters for the foreseeable future, while Iran renewed strikes on its Gulf neighbours and threatened to start hitting their power plants.

Birol said 40 energy assets in nine countries across the region were "severely or very severely damaged." (AP)

China braces for fuel shortage; hikes gasoline, diesel prices

KJM VARMA
Beijing

China has increased retail fuel prices as part of preparations for a fuel crisis amid apprehensions that the US-Israel-Iran war may prolong, leading to shortages of gasoline and diesel.

China's top planner the National Development and Reform Commission (NDRC) has announced temporary measures starting from Tuesday amid increases in international oil prices.

The measures have been adopted to mitigate the impact of the abnormal rise in international oil prices, reduce the burden on downstream



users, and ensure stable economic operation and social livelihood, the NDRC said.

Accordingly, gasoline and diesel prices will increase by 1,160 yuan and 1,115 yuan per tonne, respectively, according to the statement by NDRC.

China reportedly has about four months of emergency reserves. Following the announcement of the fuel price hike, vehicle owners rushed to gas stations all over China to fill their vehicles' tanks. (AP)

North Korea says summit with Japan is off unless Tokyo drops its anachronistic ways

HYUNG-JIN KIM
Seoul

The powerful sister of North Korean leader Kim Jong Un said on Monday a summit between her brother and Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi won't happen if Japan sticks to "its anachronistic" approach.

Kim Yo Jong's statement came after Takaichi told reporters last week that she had informed US President Donald Trump during a summit in Washington that she had "a very strong desire" to meet Kim Jong Un. "But this is not the one that comes true, as wanted or decided by Japan," Kim Yo



Jong said. "In order for the top leaders of the two countries to meet each other, Japan should first be determined to break with its anachronistic practice and

habit." Kim Yo Jong, who is also a senior official, didn't explicitly say what Japan's "anachronistic practice and habit" are. However, in 2024,

she said in a statement that North Korea's acceptance of a reported offer for a meeting by one of Takaichi's predecessors would depend on Japan tolerating the North's nuclear weapons program and ignoring its past abductions of Japanese nationals. The meeting eventually didn't occur. In her latest statement carried by state media on Monday, Kim Yo Jong said, "I don't want to see the prime minister of Japan coming to Pyongyang." But she still described her rejection as "just my personal position," suggesting she was pressuring Japan to make concessions. (AP)

Historic Hawaii floods leave 2,000 people without power

JESSICA HILL
Honolulu

More than 2,000 people remained without power afternoon after Hawaii suffered its worst flooding in more than 20 years when heavy rains fell across the islands.

Heavy rains fell on soil already saturated by downpours from a winter storm a week ago. Raging waters lifted homes and cars, causing an expected \$1 billion in damages. The storm prompted evaluation orders for 5,500 people north of Honolulu – though they were later lifted – and more than 200 people were rescued from the rising



waters. No deaths have been reported as of yet, Molly Pierce, spokesperson for Oahu's Department of Emergency Management, said Sunday afternoon.

By Sunday afternoon, Hawaiian Electric restored

power to about 1,200 people in Waialua on the North Shore of O'ahu, according to the company. Customers' power was proactively turned off Friday because of the flooding.

Crews continue to assess

the damage and make repairs, and Hawaiian Electric expects to return power to 2,000 more people later on Sunday.

On Maui County about 100 people were without power Sunday afternoon, and all major outages were addressed on Hawai'i Island, according to the company. The worst of the storms appear to be over, Hawaii meteorologist Matthew Foster said.

By Sunday afternoon, the weather shifted from widespread showers to scattered rain from Oahu, Maui County to Big Island, Foster said. Less than 5 inches of rain is expected for the Big Island,

Nepal eases rules for solo foreign trekkers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kathmandu

Nepal has revised its trekking permit policy for restricted areas, allowing individual foreign tourists to obtain permits for trekking that were previously only issued to groups of two or more.

The restricted areas mainly lie in the remote mountain region near the China border such as Lomanthang and Upper Mustang. The Department of Immigration (DoI) on Sunday issued the notice following grievances from the Trekking Agencies' Association of Nepal (TAAN) and other related organisa-



tions. Previously, foreigners were facing inconvenience as they needed to find a trekking partner before a permit could be issued.

According to a spokesperson, this decision was made on March 21. To make the process for foreign groups travelling through agencies more efficient, the department has arranged an online system for granting trekking permits.

with between 1 to 2 inches in other areas. Winds will pick up out of the northeast sides of the islands, which have more vegetation and can handle more rain, Foster said. It will take a couple days for the moisture to push past the islands, and drier and more typical March weather can be expected by Wednesday. Additional flooding could still occur, but more on an isolated scale rather than widespread, Foster said.

A boil water notice remained in place Sunday for North Shore areas from Mokuleia to Turtle Bay, and residents were encouraged to report damages to the city.

Gov. Josh Green said the cost of the storm could top USD 1 billion, including damage to airports, schools, roads, homes and a Maui hospital in Kula. Officials were concerned that the 120-year-old Wahiawa dam could fail, though that worry has primarily passed since water levels have dropped, Pierce said. The dam continues to be monitored.

Winter storm systems known as "Kona lows," which feature southerly or south-westerly winds that bring in moisture-laden air, have been responsible for the deluges in the past two weeks. The intensity and frequency of heavy rains in Hawaii. (AP)

Explosion in Nigeria kills 1, says Police

PELUMI SALAKO
Ilorin

An explosion killed at least one person and injured an unspecified number of people Monday in Nigeria's north-central Kwara state, police said, in the latest attack in an area where Muslim militants have been increasingly active.

The explosion, believed to have been from an improvised explosive device, went off in the early morning in a village near Woro in the Kaïama district, in an area where an armed group slaughtered more than 160 people in February.

Police spokesperson Toun Ejire-Adeyemi in Kwara state told The Associated Press an investigation into the explosion has been launched.

The blast struck a commercial vehicle that was heading to neighbouring Niger state, she said. No group has claimed responsi-

bility for the attack. However, the state has become a new frontier of expansion by various Islamist groups who are pushing southward in the country's escalating security crisis. Nigerian President Bola Tinubu deployed the military to the area following the attack in February.

"This is another trauma again because people are afraid. Likely, some people will leave the community again," village head Umar Bio Salihu said. Islamist groups have recently launched a wave of attacks on communities and military installations in the northern region, often overrunning military camps in what experts say is a campaign to weaken the military's response to attacks by the groups.

Earlier in the year, the United States sent troops to help train the Nigerian military in its fight against the armed groups. (AP)



Air Canada plane hits fire truck, 2 pilots dead

JAKE OFFENHARTZ AND
JENNIFER PELTZ
■ New York

Two pilots were killed after an Air Canada regional jet collided with a fire truck on a runway during landing at New York's LaGuardia Airport late Sunday night, officials said. The collision crushed the nose of the aircraft, while 39 passengers and crew members were taken to area hospitals, some with serious injuries. Most have since been released from treatment, authorities said on Monday.

Two Port Authority employees who were travelling in the fire truck also suffered injuries that were not believed to be life-threatening,

said Kathryn Garcia, executive director of the Port Authority of New York and New Jersey, which operates the airport.

The two deceased individuals were the pilot and copilot of the aircraft. Both were based out of Canada, Garcia said during a news conference early Monday.

The airport will remain closed until at least 2 pm Monday to facilitate the investigation, which is being led by the National Transportation Safety Board (NTSB).

The fire truck was travelling across the runway to respond to a separate incident aboard a United Airlines flight, whose pilot had reported "an issue with



Port Authority aircraft rescue and firefighting vehicle lays on its side off runway 4 after colliding with an Air Canada Jet at LaGuardia Airport

odour," said Garcia, who deferred additional questions about the sequence of events leading up to the crash to the NTSB. There

were 72 passengers and four crew members aboard the aircraft, a Jazz Aviation flight operating on behalf of Air Canada, according to a state-

ment from the airline. The flight originated at Montreal-Pierre Elliott Trudeau International Airport, the major airport serving Montreal.

Photos and videos from the scene showed severe damage to the front of the aircraft, with cables and debris hanging from a mangled cockpit. Nearby, a damaged emergency vehicle lay on its side.

Stairways used to evacuate passengers from the aircraft were pushed up to the emergency exits on the jet, a Bombardier CRJ. The impact left the jet with its crumpled nose tilted upward.

In the moments before the crash, an air traffic controller could be heard on a

radio transmission giving clearance to a vehicle to cross part of the tarmac, then trying to stop it.

"Stop, Truck 1. Stop," the transmission says. The controller can then be heard frantically diverting an incoming aircraft from landing. Air traffic controllers are not impacted by the partial Government shutdown that has caused long delays at airport security checkpoints in recent days. They have been affected by past shutdowns.

As passengers straggled out of the airport into the dark early Monday, some described having arrived at LaGuardia hours before their flight, hoping to beat the lines. (AP)

Imran Khan accuses judges for selling their souls



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

Pakistan's jailed former prime minister Imran Khan on Monday accused the judges in the country of "selling their souls for personal privileges", saying he and his wife are not getting justice from courts.

Khan, 73, has been incarcerated since August 2023 and is currently lodged in the high-security Adiala Jail, Rawalpindi, in multiple cases against him. The Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) founder leader made the accusations in a telephonic conversation with his sons on Eid, which they posted on his X account on Monday. His son Kasim Khan said the former cricketer-turned-politician wanted his message to be conveyed to the public. "The

judges in this country should be ashamed of themselves. Time and time again, we have gone to the judiciary. But they have sold their souls for their paid personal privileges. They have sold their integrity," the post quoted him as saying.

Making an indirect reference to the country's powerful military establishment, Khan said, "They know they cannot break me, so they turn to my wife. How can they allow this inhumane treatment of Bushra Bibi (his third wife), simply to blackmail me? She spends 24 hours a day in isolation, except for 30 minutes with me per week - and even that is often ignored. Khan said that it was "un-Islamic" to harm women, children and the elderly, and their motives are plain.

India, China bear brunt of US visa policy: Report

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

India and China bore the maximum brunt of tougher immigration policy unveiled by the Trump administration which issued 2.5 lakh fewer visas in the first eight months of 2025 compared with the same period in 2024, according to a media report.

From January to August 2025, the State Department approved 11 per cent fewer permanent resident and temporary visas compared with the same period a year before, according to State Department data released in early March.

These visas are generally issued for students, workers, and family members of citi-



zens and legal residents.

The 11 per cent drop doesn't include tourist visas, which also fell during the same period, the Washington Post reported on Sunday.

According to the report, visas for Chinese and Indian nationals fell by about 84,000 compared with the same period in 2024, largely reflecting a drop-off in international students and workers from

those countries. Business and tourism visas declined by about 3.4 per cent in the first eight months of 2025 compared with that period a year earlier, a drop of nearly two lakh visas.

Between January and August 2024, the US had issued more than 3.44 lakh student visas, the number declined to a little over 2.38 lakh during the same period in 2025.

The family preference visa, which includes adult children and siblings of US citizens fell by more than 27 per cent or by over 44,000.

The visas issued to sea and airline workers also reduced by 30,876, while those issued for culture exchange visitors declined by 29,594. The visas

issued to fiance/spouse declined from 37,229 in the first eight months of 2024 to 18,894 for the period under review in 2025. White House spokeswoman Abigail Jackson said in a statement that "President Trump was elected with a resounding mandate to put American citizens first and every policy decision he's made has reflected that priority." In a statement to The Washington Post, State Department spokesman Tommy Pigott said: "A visa is a privilege, not a right.

Unlike the Biden administration, President Trump is not willing to compromise the safety of American citizens to allow mass migration of unvetted foreign nationals into our country." (PTI)

Socialist Emmanuel wins Paris mayoral race

SYLVIE CORBET
■ Paris

Emmanuel Gregoire, a Socialist little known to the French public, was elected mayor of Paris in a runoff vote Sunday, succeeding fellow party member Anne Hidalgo. Soon after claiming victory, Gregoire, 48, took a city bike through the streets of Paris toward City Hall, echoing his promise to make the French Capital greener.

Gregoire beat out prominent conservative contender Rachida Dati, who acknowledged her defeat after partial results were made public.

The race for Paris mayor was part of France's second round of municipal elec-



Emmanuel Gregoire

leading the city through the 2015 extremist attacks and the 2024 Paris Olympics. Here are five things to know about Paris' new face.

A local political career Gregoire was well-placed to step into the limelight when Hidalgo decided not to seek a third term.

He had joined the Socialist party at 24 in 2002, got involved in Paris politics and eight years later became the chief of staff of Paris' then-mayor, Bertrand Delanoë. Gregoire subsequently worked in the prime minister's office under Socialist President Francois Hollande. He was first elected to the Paris City Council in 2014. (AP)

Marco Rubio to testify secretly about lobbying for Venezuela

JOSHUA GOODMAN
■ Miami

The federal trial of a former Miami congressman accused of secretly lobbying for Venezuela's Government during the first Trump administration begins Monday with Secretary of State Marco Rubio set to testify over his interactions with his old friend.

Prosecutors allege David Rivera was a hired gun for former President Nicolas Maduro, leveraging Republican connections from his time in Congress to push the White House to abandon its hard line on Venezuela's socialist Government.

Rivera, who at one time had been Rubio's roommate in Florida, allegedly persuad-

ed then Foreign Minister Delcy Rodriguez — now Venezuela's acting president - to award him a \$50 million lobbying contract to be paid by state oil company PDVSA.

As part of the alleged foreign influence campaign, prosecutors say Rivera was aided by Texas Republican Rep. Pete Sessions and a convicted Cali cartel associate as he sought meetings with the White House and Exxon Mobil on Maduro's behalf.

The trial offers a rare glimpse into the often unseemly role Miami - long a haven for exiles, corruption and anti-communist crusaders — plays in shaping US policy in Latin America. As such, it is perhaps fitting that Rubio, Miami's most promi-



Secretary of State Marco Rubio

nent politician, is set to take the stand on Tuesday about his meetings with Rivera while the former congressman was allegedly helping Maduro mount a charm offensive in Washington.

Also likely to face scrutiny is Rodriguez, who relied on

lowing Maduro's ouster and the ascent of his more pragmatic aide.

Indictment details alleged covert lobbying and money-laundering scheme An 11-count indictment, unsealed in 2022, charges Rivera and an associate with money laundering and failing to register as a foreign agent.

Prosecutors allege that to hide their work, Rivera set up an encrypted chat group called MIA - for Miami - with his main conduit to the Maduro Government: Venezuelan media tycoon Raul Gorrin, who was subsequently charged in the US with bribing top Venezuelan officials.

Members of the group used playful code words to discuss their activities:

Maduro was the "bus driver," Sessions

"Sombbrero," and millions of dollars "melons," according to prosecutors.

Rivera, 60, denies wrongdoing. His attorneys counter that his one-man firm, Interamerican Consulting, was hired by an American subsidiary of Venezuela's state-owned oil company - not PDVSA itself - and therefore did not need to register as a foreign agent.

His consulting work, they say, was focused on positioning Venezuelan-owned Citgo in the US energy industry and was wholly distinct from his peacemaking efforts, which involved working with Maduro's opponents to usher in leadership less hostile to the US. (AP)

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A low priority for the US Government, an increase from about one-third just after Trump took office. About one-third of AAPI adults now say these deportations should be a moderate priority, and only about 2 in 10 say they should be a high priority.

Fran Peace, 75, of Oroville, California, still sees deporting immigrants here illegally as a high priority. But the Japanese American retiree disagrees with stopping people based on "stereotypes" like their looks or if they have an accent. She also is open to a citizenship path for those who've lived here for years and haven't committed a crime. (AP)

AAPI adults mostly think Trump has done more harm than good on immigration: Survey

TERRY TANG/LINLEY SANDERS
■ Washington

Most Asian Americans, Native Hawaiians and Pacific Islanders believe President Donald Trump has done more harm than good on the issue of immigration and border security in his second term so far, according to a new AAPI Data/AP-NORC poll.

About 6 in 10 AAPI adults say Trump has hurt immigration and border security "a lot" or "a little," according to the survey from AAPI Data and The Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research, compared with about 4 in 10 US adults in a January AP-NORC survey. About two-thirds of AAPI

adults — who are generally more likely to be Democrats than US adults overall - also say Trump has "gone too far" when it comes to deporting immigrants living in the US illegally, compared with about half of Americans in general.

Trump's administration has instituted sweeping immigration measures since he took office, but the past two months have been especially tumultuous. This past January, Trump suspended processing immigrant visas for citizens of 75 countries. Arrests at the US-Mexico border have fallen dramatically, but the number of Immigration and Customs Enforcement arrests and



detentions have soared. In December 2024, daily detentions averaged just under 40,000. Last month, they numbered about 70,000.

The survey was conducted on the heels of the January fatal shootings by ICE agents of two US citizens and their detainment of a

Hmong American man — clad only in his underwear — in freezing temperatures.

These immigration crackdowns hit close to home for Jeff Ugai, who lives in Hawaii. On his island, Kauai, nearly four dozen people were arrested in November in immigration raids.

"It seems like the current administration's efforts have been more about about cruelty than they have about actually establishing an immigration system that makes sense to this country," said Ugai, 39, who is a Democrat.

AAPI adults, one of the fastest-growing demographics in the US, broadly don't support Trump's tough

tactics on immigration, the poll found. A separate AAPI Data/AP-NORC survey last fall found that unhappiness about Trump's immigration approach had risen from earlier in the year.

"We're also seeing opposition to policies that may not involve violence or violations of due process, but still involve things like banning immigrants from entire countries where there is a history of visa overstays or deporting immigrants who are married to US citizens," said Karthick Ramakrishnan, founder and executive director of AAPI Data. In this poll, around 4 in 10 AAPI adults say deporting immigrants living in the US illegally should be

A low priority for the US Government, an increase from about one-third just after Trump took office. About one-third of AAPI adults now say these deportations should be a moderate priority, and only about 2 in 10 say they should be a high priority.

Fran Peace, 75, of Oroville, California, still sees deporting immigrants here illegally as a high priority. But the Japanese American retiree disagrees with stopping people based on "stereotypes" like their looks or if they have an accent. She also is open to a citizenship path for those who've lived here for years and haven't committed a crime. (AP)



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

British police are investigating an apparent arson attack on four vehicles belonging to a Jewish ambulance service in London early Monday morning.

Four ambulances belonging to Hatzola Northwest, a volunteer organization that provides emergency medical response, were damaged, according to the London fire brigade. Multiple cylinders on the

vehicles exploded, causing windows to break in an adjacent block of flats, it said in a statement, adding that no injuries have been reported.

Officers were called to Golders Green, a London neighborhood with a large Jewish population, after receiving reports of a fire. The police said the incident is being treated as an antisemitic hate crime.

The cause of the fire is under investigation, authorities said.

Trump places statue of Christopher Columbus near White House



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Annapolis

A statue of Christopher Columbus has been placed on the grounds of the Eisenhower Executive Office Building adjacent to the White House, the latest effort by President Donald Trump's administration to recognise the controversial explorer.

The statue is a replica of one that was tossed into Baltimore's harbor in 2020 during Trump's first term at a time of nationwide protests against institutional racism.

Trump endorses a traditional view of Columbus as a leader of the 1492 mission seen as the unofficial beginning of European colonisation in the Americas and the development of the modern economic and political order. But in recent years, Columbus also has been recognised as a primary example of Western Europe's conquest of the New World, its resources and its native people.

"In this White House, Christopher Columbus is a hero, and President Trump will ensure he's honoured as such for generations to come," the White House posted on X.

▼PROSPECT

HDFC Bank shares down nearly 12% in 3 days

Shares of HDFC Bank are on a downtrend, falling nearly 12 per cent in three days, after its non-executive chairman Atanu Chakraborty abruptly resigned. On Monday, the heavyweight stock tanked 4.70 per cent to settle at ₹743.75 on the BSE. During the day, it tumbled 5 per cent to ₹740.95 – the 52-week low. At the NSE, the stock declined ₹744.15. The market valuation of the firm has dropped 11,44,778.71 crore. HDFC Bank's non-executive chairman, Atanu Chakraborty, abruptly resigned, citing differences over "values and ethics" – a ground that the management of the country's second-largest lender said was baffling, as the former bureaucrat offered no specific instance despite repeated requests. Keki Mistry, a veteran of the HDFC Bank Group, who was appointed the interim chairman following the resignation, said there may have been "relationship issues" between Chakraborty and the executive leadership, but found no "substantive" concerns behind the departure.

Rubrik Data Protection to enhance Google Workspace

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As adoption for Google Workspace continues to grow, Rubrik (NYSE: RBRK), the Security and AI Operations Company has announced the launch of Rubrik Data Protection for Google Workspace. More than 11 million enterprises using Google Drive and Gmail can now use Rubrik features to help them achieve end-to-end cyber resilience. Google Workspace is a suite of AI productivity tools that empowers teams to collaborate from anywhere. It holds mission-critical data for millions in organisations worldwide who cannot lose access to these tools or their data. Rubrik Data Protection can now help Google Workspace customers reduce the risk of significant data and business losses, or suspended operations, according to a Press release.

Anneka Gupta, Chief Product Officer at Rubrik,

said, "Organisations can't protect data in isolation. Modern resilience requires us to see the entire estate at once. Rubrik is built on three pillars of resilience – data, identity, and AI – because an attack or error in one is a direct threat to the entire ecosystem. With our deep collaboration with Google Cloud, our core mission is to empower today's organisations with a unified platform that offers trust and complete cyber resilience."

"As Google workspace adoption accelerates, building protection and resilience is no longer optional for Indian organisations; it is essential for maintaining control over data, identity, and AI," he added. Now, Google Workspace customers can benefit from these Rubrik features with Logical Air-Gap Protection, High-Fidelity, Rapid Recovery, Automated, Policy-Driven SLAs and Seamless Continuity.

11 airlines exited in 10 years due to financial stress: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As many as 11 airlines exited the market in the last 10 years due to financial stress, non-availability of aircraft and other internal issues, according to the Government.

Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol told the Rajya Sabha on Monday that the aviation sector is deregulated, and airlines operate based on commercial considerations while the Government is committed to ensuring a balanced and resilient sector.

"Since 2016, a total of 11 airlines have exited the market due to reasons such as financial stress, non-availability of aircraft and other internal issues. Further, AirAsia (India) Pvt. Ltd. (now



AIX Connect Pvt. Ltd.) has merged with Air India Express Ltd., and Tata SIA Airlines Ltd. (Vistara) has merged into Air India Ltd," he said in a written reply.

Specific details were not disclosed.

To a query on the total outstanding dues of failed airlines to airports, employees, and creditors, Mohol said Kingfisher Airlines had ₹380.51 crore dues towards the Airports Authority of India (AAI) and the claim has been

lodged before the official Liquidator at Bengaluru.

Kingfisher Airlines had stopped operations in 2012.

The dues of Trujet towards AAI is ₹0.03 crore while there are no dues of Jet Airways and Go First.

Indian Army swiftly neutralises UXOs following standoff attack in Assam



TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

In the early hours of March 22, 2026, a standoff attack by ULFA(I) was reported at approximately 2 am near an Assam Police Commando camp at Jagun, Tinsukia district, Assam. The incident left behind unexploded ordnance, including RPG and

UBGL rounds, posing a serious threat to the local population. Responding promptly, Red Shield Sappers, in coordination with Assam Rifles, mobilised a Bomb Disposal team to the site.

The area was swiftly cordoned off and all safety protocols were meticulously enforced to ensure full



control of the situation.

The unexploded ordnance was subsequently neutralised in a controlled manner at a secure location away from civilian habitation, eliminating any risk to life and property. The operation was carried out with a high degree of professionalism, precision and adherence to

established procedures.

The swift and coordinated response ensured the safety of the local populace and prevented any collateral damage. The Indian Army remains committed to maintaining peace, security and stability in the region and continues to remain vigilant against emerging threats.

SEBI board approves conflict of interest, disclosure framework for top officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The board of capital markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on Monday approved several recommendations of a high-level committee on "conflict of interest" requiring the chairman and senior officers to publicly disclose their assets and liabilities to increase transparency and accountability.

Additionally, the Chairman and Whole Time Members (WTMs) are to be brought within the definition of "insider," SEBI said in its statement after the conclusion of



the board meeting.

The committee, chaired by former Chief Vigilance Commissioner Pratyush Sinha, also suggested that all SEBI board members and employees should make

initial, annual, event-based and exit disclosures of assets, liabilities, trading activities and family relationships as well as other professional and relational interests.

"The immovable property

details of the Chairman, WTMs, Executive Directors and Chief General Managers may be publicly disclosed in line with the requirements already applicable to Government of India All India Service (AIS) and Central Civil Services (CCS) officers. However, details of assets and liabilities in the format to be prescribed would have to be internally disclosed to SEBI," the regulator said.

However, the restrictions would not apply to part-time members, given their limited role and sphere of influence compared to WTMs. Also, the board approved setting up of a digital system for manage-

ment of conflict of interest, whistleblower system for reporting actual, potential, or perceived conflicts of interest and training and development programmes to foster a culture of ethical conduct.

The board also accepted recommendations in case of recusals relating to material financial interest and other circumstances that may require recusal as given in the HLC report. Also, it approved a digital system and recusal framework may be put in place to record disclosure of conflicted relationships as well as to process recusals, including grant of approvals.. The SEBI board approved a

recommendation of the high-level committee (HLC) for a uniform application of restrictions on investments and trading (in equity and equity-related instruments, other than permitted investments in mutual funds) for the Chairman and WTMs as currently applicable to employees.

The report, which was submitted to SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey on November 10, recommended that new investments in any pooled vehicle may be permitted, provided the scheme is professionally managed by a regulated market intermediary.

India's Next Great Export: Medical Tourism



GOVIND BHATTACHARJEE

RAVI GARG

Across advanced and developing economies alike, rising costs, aging populations, workforce shortages, and long waiting times are today creating ever-widening gaps between healthcare demand and supply. Millions of patients worldwide are seeking high-quality medical care that is affordable, timely, and reliable.

India stands uniquely positioned to respond to this global demand and become the world's leading destination for medical tourism, while also transforming its healthcare system into one of our most potent export earners and employment creators. It can offer the most advanced surgical, diagnostic, and wellness services at a fraction of the costs charged in developed countries, while also providing traditional healing through Ayurveda and Yoga. It is an opportunity grounded in India's comparative advantages, backed by proven capabilities and a support system.

A Global Market in Search of Solutions

Healthcare costs are rising dramatically across the world. In the USA, per capita healthcare spending exceeds \$12,000 annually, nearly five times the global average. In many OECD countries, complex surgeries such as joint replacements, cardiac procedures, and cancer treatments involve waiting periods ranging from

six months to over two years. As these countries age faster, the global healthcare workforce shortages are projected to reach 11 million professionals by 2030, according to the WHO. These pressures are already driving cross-border healthcare.

The global medical tourism market is estimated to surpass \$100 billion by 2030. Patients are no longer traveling only for cosmetic or elective procedures; they are increasingly seeking complex surgeries, oncology care, fertility treatment, organ transplants, and long-term rehabilitation. India has emerged as one of the most trusted destinations in this space, attracting patients from 75 developing and developed countries for advanced treatments and wellness therapies. Its medical tourism market is projected to grow from \$18 billion in 2025 to \$58 billion by 2035, according a KPMG estimate.

India's Current Position: Strong but Underleveraged

India's medical tourism sector has displayed robust growth over the post-COVID years, with the arrival of foreign tourists for medical purposes soaring from under 200,000 in 2020 to over 640,000 in 2024, 75% from Bangladesh alone. The sector is poised for 15% growth, following the simplified e-Visa process announced in the Union Budget 2025-26, which will further enhance India's appeal, with medical tourism expanding beyond metro cities.

The Government's e-medical visa and e-medical attendant visa facilities today extend to citizens of over 171 countries, reducing the earlier barriers to access.

However, India's growth in medical has occurred largely without a unified national strategy, driven instead by private sector excellence, clinical outcomes, and India's compelling cost advantages, with complex surgeries and procedures costing between 10 and 20%, and cancer therapies and organ transplants at one-third the cost seen in advanced economies at compara-

ble and sometimes superior quality and patient care.

With over 700 internationally accredited hospitals, and in addition over 90,000 doctors and 150,000 nurses annually, which constitutes the largest English-speaking medical workforce in the world, India matches and often transcends global benchmarks on patient satisfaction, while its public healthcare system remains dismal. But there are many strong contenders in this area: Thailand, Mexico, Türkiye, Malaysia, UAE, and Singapore. We must calibrate our policies carefully to benefit from realising their full potential or watch them unfold elsewhere.

Today metros like Chennai, Delhi, Mumbai, and Bengaluru serve as medical tourism hubs, with 25% medical tourists choosing Tamil Nadu alone, while Kerala is positioning itself in wellness tourism destination, combining surgical care with holistic and Ayurvedic treatments.

But other states are lagging hopelessly behind in the healthcare value chains, and rural and semi-urban areas remain way behind in foundational healthcare infrastructure. Bridging this urban-rural divide remains a crucial agenda for Governments - not only for equitable domestic health outcomes but also for broadening the domestic supply base that supports the medical tourism sector.

Healthcare Exports and India's Trade Imbalance

India's current account deficit (CAD) in FY 2025 stood at \$23 billion, with services exports playing a critical role in offsetting our trade imbalance. Other than IT and IT-enabled services - the backbone of our service exports - healthcare services can emerge as the next major pillar.

Unlike manufacturing exports, healthcare services have low-import dependence and generate high value, with 85% domestic components - comprising local doctors, nurses, technicians,

pharmaceuticals, diagnostics, hospital infrastructure, hospitality, and transport services. Every international patient contributes not only to hospital revenues but also to airlines, hotels, translators, wellness centres, and local businesses.

Estimates indicate that every 1,000 inbound medical tourists can create 80-100 jobs in associated services in these areas. Few export sectors offer this combination of scale, resilience, employment intensity, and domestic value creation. If the sector indeed contributes over \$50 billion by 2035 as estimated, it will be able to balance our CAD and even generate a surplus. An Opportunity That Strengthens, Not Competes with, Domestic Healthcare

It is important to address a legitimate concern: Does medical tourism divert resources away from domestic patients? International experience suggests the opposite when managed well. Revenue from foreign patients enables hospitals to invest in advanced technology, expand capacity, cross-subsidize care for underserved populations, and retain top clinical talent within the country.

Countries such as Thailand and Turkey have demonstrated that medical tourism can coexist with-and even strengthen-universal healthcare systems. In India, medical value travel can support the development of centres of excellence across cardiology, oncology, orthopaedics, fertility care, transplants, Ayurveda, and rehabilitative medicine. With targeted investment, tier-2 and tier-3 cities can emerge as regional healthcare hubs, driving employment and economic development across states.

What a National Strategy Must Focus On

To fully realize this opportunity, India must move from organic growth to coordinated execution. Apart from simplification of e-Visa procedures, the Government's "Heal in India"

Delhi marks Bihar Day with cultural showcase

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government organised a grand cultural programme at the Delhi Secretariat to mark Bihar Foundation Day. On the occasion, Minister of Art, Culture, and Languages Kapil Mishra extended greetings and highlighted efforts to promote cultural unity.

The event, held to commemorate the formation of Bihar on March 22, 1912, was organised by the Sahitya Kala Parishad under the Department of Art, Culture, and Languages. The event also featured traditional performances of Bihar. Addressing the gathering, Mishra said the celebrations align with the Centre's "Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat" vision and aim to bring India's diverse cultural traditions onto a common platform. He said the Delhi Government has been organising foundation day events of different states to strengthen national unity.

The programme showcased Bihar's cultural heritage through Jhijhiya folk dance and musical performances in Bhojpuri and Maithili. Around 20 artists participated in the event. Mishra described Bihar as a land known for knowledge, spirituality, and historical significance. He stated that the State has contributed significantly to India's cultural and intellectual legacy and continues to hold an important place in the country's identity.

He referred to Bihar as the land associated with Lord Buddha and Lord Mahavira, and said it has historically conveyed messages of peace and good governance. He added that languages such as Bhojpuri, Maithili, and Magahi form an integral part of India's cultural heritage.

The minister also highlighted the significance of festivals like Chhath Puja, calling them a reflection of

discipline, devotion, and respect for nature. He said the Delhi Government has taken steps to expand and support such cultural practices in the Capital.

Mishra said large-scale Chhath Puja celebrations were organised in Delhi last year, including the development of model ghats. He also said that cases registered against devotees for performing Chhath Puja at the Yamuna ghats during the previous Government were withdrawn. He added that the scale of Chhath celebrations in Delhi will continue to increase in the coming years.

The cultural programme remained the highlight of the event. The Jhijhiya dance performance drew attention for its traditional style and devotional theme. The dance form is usually performed during Navratri and is associated with the worship of Goddess Durga.

Performances in Bhojpuri and Maithili music and dance added to the festive atmosphere. Artists depicted themes of rural life, nature, social relationships, and everyday experiences through their acts. Officials said such events aim to preserve and promote regional traditions while encouraging cultural exchange among communities living in Delhi.

The audience response remained positive, with attendees appreciating the efforts to showcase Bihar's heritage in the national Capital. The event is part of a broader push by the Delhi Government to promote cultural programmes and celebrate the diversity of different states.

Officials said similar initiatives will continue in the future to strengthen cultural engagement and awareness among citizens. The programme concluded with performances highlighting the simplicity and richness of Mithila's traditions, reinforcing the role of cultural events in fostering unity and shared identity.



Govind Bhattacharjee, a former Director General, CAG of India, is currently a Professor at Arun Jaitley National Institute of Financial Management.

Ravi Garg is a public policy analyst and the Founding Director of India Senior Living Platform. Opinions expressed are personal

BRIEFLY

Devyne Charlton matches her own world record



Bahamas sprinter Devynne Charlton matched her own world record by clocking 7.65 seconds to win the 60-metre hurdles at the World Indoors for the third straight year on Sunday. Charlton also ran 7.65 at the 2024 World Indoors. Nadine Visser of the Netherlands took silver in 7.73 and Pia Skrzyszowska took bronze before her home fans with the same time. Charlton finished sixth in the 100 hurdles at the Tokyo and Paris Olympics.

Youngest winner: The 17-year-old American Cooper Lutkenhaus won the 800 in 1:44.24 to become the youngest man to win an individual gold medal at a worlds – seven months after turning pro.

The U.S. swept golds in the men's and women's 4x400s. Justin Robinson, Chris Robinson, Demarius Smith and Khaleb McRae clocked a championship record 3:01.52 and Bailey Lear, Rosey Effiong, Paris Peoples and Shamier Little set a season's best 3:25.81.

Big night for Britain: Also, Keely Hodgkinson won the 800 in a championship record 1:55.30 for the first world title of her career.

New era of Indian indoor athletics begins on Tuesday



India will formally begin its tryst with narrower tracks and consistent conditions of indoor athletics by hosting the format's maiden national championship starting here on Tuesday, taking the first preparatory step towards conducting the world championship at the same venue in two years' time.

The state-of-the-art facility here was last week named as the venue for the World Indoor Athletics Championships to be held from March 3-5, 2028. It would be the first time that the country will be hosting a global track and field showpiece. The national championship would be a two-day affair at the facility that was inaugurated in 2024.

Indoor athletics has been a lesser known aspect of the sport in the country though some Indians have been competing at the international stage. This has to do, in large part, with the lack of top-class indoor facilities in the country. In indoor events, athletes run on tracks which are narrower and have banked turns. The outdoor 400m tracks are wider and have flat turns.

Indoor events are not affected by wind and the weather conditions are consistent throughout the duration of the competition. Familiar faces like star javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra and 3000m steeplechaser Avinash Sable will not compete here as their events are not in the roster.

With the completion of the world-class facility inside the Kalinga Stadium complex here, India was able to convince World Athletics to allocate the 2028 global showpiece.

Germany forward Deniz Undav extends Bundesliga scoring streak to 6 games

CIARAN FAHEYAP
■ Berlin

Deniz Undav celebrated his return to the Germany squad by scoring for the sixth consecutive Bundesliga game in Stuttgart's 5-2 rout of Augsburg on Sunday.

This time Undav scored twice to take his tally to 18 for the season and deliver Germany coach Julian Nagelsmann a timely reminder – if he needs one – of his prowess before World Cup warmup games against Switzerland and Ghana. The

visitors' dominance. Anton Kade scored in the 71st for Augsburg and Undav set up Ermedin Demirovic to complete the scoring with a tap-in against his former club in the 83rd.

Stuttgart moved three points clear of Leipzig and Hoffenheim, with Bayer Leverkusen four points further back in sixth.

Where's Gotze? Eintracht Frankfurt dropped World Cup hero Mario Gotze and lost 2-1 at local rival Mainz in their derby earlier Sunday.

Paul Nebel scored both



win lifted Stuttgart to third with seven rounds remaining, well placed to finish among the top four for Champions League qualification.

Undav opened the scoring in the 12th minute. Nikolas Nartey set up Tiago Tomas in the 29th, two minutes before scoring himself to put Stuttgart 3-0 ahead.

Fabian Rieder pulled one back for Augsburg after the break, but Undav replied a minute later to reassure the

goals for Mainz, grabbing the winner in the 89th minute to set off wild celebrations and deal Frankfurt its second defeat under new coach Albert Riera.

Nebel opened the scoring in the sixth minute before Nathaniel Brown responded for Frankfurt in the 20th, then Nebel fired home the rebound after Frankfurt 'keeper Michael Zetterer saved Nelson Weiper's header. (AP)

Messi, Santos push Inter Miami to come-from-behind victory

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ New York

Lionel Messi scored the equaliser off a free kick in the second half before helping to set up Micael dos Santos' winner and Inter Miami came from behind to beat New York City FC 3-2 at Yankee Stadium on Sunday.

Inter Miami (3-1-1) pulls into a second-place tie in the Eastern Conference by handing NYCFC (3-1-1) its first loss.

Gonzalo Lujan scored his first career goal – unassisted off a rebound in the 4th minute to give Inter Miami an early lead. The 21-year-old defender has started in 23 of his 30 career appearances.

Nicolas Fernandez continued his red-hot start with



his fifth goal, scoring off a free kick in the 17th minute to pull NYCFC even. Fernandez has eight goals in 16 career appearances since last season.

Agustin Ojeda scored - with assists from Maxi Moralez and Kevin O'Toole -

to give NYCFC a 2-1 lead in the 59th minute. It was Ojeda's second goal this season and his fifth in 61 career matches. Moralez already has four assists this season.

The advantage lasted for two minutes until Messi drilled a left-footed free kick

that ricocheted its way past Matt Freese for his fourth goal this season. It was Messi's 54th goal in his 58th MLS appearance. The Argentine legend has scored 901 goals in his illustrious international and club career.

Messi's corner kick in the 74th minute helped set up a header by Micael and Inter Miami took a 3-2 lead. Noah Allen and David Ayala assisted on Micael's first goal with his new team.

Dayne St. Claire turned away three shots on goal for Inter Miami in his first season with the defending MLS Cup champions. He has surrendered eight goals in his four starts.

Matt Freese had five saves for NYCFC.

Hardik, Sukhjeet, Sanjay, Abhishek in fray for Hockey India Player of the Year award

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Star Indian midfielder Hardik Singh, forwards Sukhjeet Singh and Sanjay, and defender Abhishek are in contention for the Hockey India Balbir Singh Sr Player-of-the-Year award for 2025.

In the women's category, Salima Tete, Navneet Kaur, Lalremsiami and Savita have been nominated for the top honour.

The HI awards ceremony, scheduled to be held here on Friday, will also throw spotlight on emerging talent through the Jugraj Singh Award for Upcoming Player-of-the-Year (U-21 men) and Asunta Lakra Award for Upcoming Player-of-the-Year (Under-21 women).

A total of 32 nominees across eight



categories have made the final short-list. In addition, special recognitions such as the President's Award for Outstanding Achievement and Jaman Lal Sharma Award for Invaluable Contribution will be presented.

Officials will also be honoured

through awards for Umpire/Umpire Manager of the Year, Technical Official of the Year, and Best Member Unit.

The ceremony will also felicitate the gold medal-winning Indian men's team from the Asia Cup and the junior men's side who secured a bronze medal at the World Cup.

"As we enter a crucial year for Indian hockey, it is important to recognise the standout performers and contributions made over the past year," Hockey India president Dilip Tirkey said.

"The Hockey India Annual Awards celebrate the dedication and achievements of players and officials who continue to elevate the standard of Indian hockey. We look forward to acknowledging their efforts and the progress made," he added.

Carlos Alcaraz loses to Sebastian Korda in third round of Miami Open

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Miami Gardens (USA)

Carlos Alcaraz was eliminated in the third round of the Miami Open on Sunday, losing to Sebastian Korda in three sets. The 22-year-old Alcaraz, who completed the career Grand Slam when he won the Australian Open in January, dropped to 17-2 this season. The No. 1 player in the men's rankings also lost to Daniil Medvedev in the semifinals at Indian Wells last weekend.

Korda served for the match at 5-4 in the second, but Alcaraz rallied by winning five consecutive games. The 25-year-old Korda then regrouped and closed out a 6-3, 5-7, 6-4 victory in two hours, 19



minutes. "It was a tough match, obviously," Alcaraz said. "I think (Korda) was incredible today. Played such a great game. A lot of tied moments that I just didn't make the most of it, and I think he was better on (those) points and (those) moments." At No. 36, Korda became the lowest-ranked man to beat Alcaraz since No. 55 David Goffin accomplished the feat in the second round in Miami last year, according to the ATP Tour.

"A lot of tense moments, for sure," Korda said. "But you know I think today, the ultimate thing was belief. Going back to just believing, committing into every shot, and luckily I got it done at the end." Next up for Korda is qualifier

Martin Landaluce, who advanced with a 6-3, 7-6 (2) win against 14th-seeded Karen Khachanov.

Americans Taylor Fritz and Tommy Paul joined Korda in the fourth round. The sixth-seeded Fritz beat Reilly Opelka 6-3, 6-4, and No. 22 seed Paul eliminated Raphael Collignon with a 6-2, 3-6, 7-6 (5) victory.

No. 21 Jiri Lehecka, No. 24 Valentin Vacherot and No. 29 Tomas Martin Etcheverry also were among the winners. On the women's side, top-seeded Aryna Sabalenka cruised to a 6-4, 6-2 win against Catherine McNally. No. 3 Elena Rybakina beat No. 27 Marta Kostyuk 6-3, 6-4, and No. 5 Jessica Pegula posted a 6-2, 6-2 win over No. 26 Leylah Fernandez.

Fitzpatrick goes from disappointment to winning at Valspar Championship

DOUG FERGUSONAP
■ Palm Harbor (USA)

Matt Fitzpatrick took longer than usual to get over his loss last week at The Players Championship, mainly because he played so well and did so little wrong until Cameron Young won on the difference of one tee shot at final hole.

"To lose it right at the death is always difficult to take," Fitzpatrick said.

Seven days later, he found the best antidote. Fitzpatrick was locked in a duel with David Lipsky in the final hour at the Valspar Championship and this time delivered the goods, a birdie putt from just inside 15 feet on the final hole for a 3-



under 68 and a one-shot victory. "I knew that I was playing well," Fitzpatrick said. "And it was like, Let's just keep pushing and give ourselves the best chance we can." That's all he could asked on a tough Copperhead course at

Innisbrook that doomed 54-hole leader Sungjae Im and crushed the hopes of 45-year-old Presidents Cup captain Brandt Snedeker. They were among five players who had a share of the lead at some point, all jostling for position. (AP)

Vinicius scores twice to lead Real Madrid to a pulsating 3-2 win over Atletico in La Liga

JOSEPH WILSON
■ Barcelona

The cheers were back for Vinicius Junior at the Santiago Bernabeu after the Real Madrid forward scored twice in a 3-2 win over Atletico Madrid on Sunday, keeping his team in the thick of the La Liga title race.

Vinicius had to endure jeers from Madrid's fans earlier this season following the firing of coach Xabi Alonso and some embarrassing losses.

But as the results have improved, so has Vinicius' reception from Madrid's supporters. Madrid has reached a high mark under new

coach Alvaro Arbeloa with the win over Atletico – after a humiliating 5-2 loss in September – and the elimination of Pep Guardiola's Manchester City in the Champions League.

And Vinicius has rightfully gotten some credit for the team's recent improvement in form as he had helped to lead Madrid along with midfielder Federico Valverde, with stars Kylian Mbappe and Jude Bellingham out injured.

Vinicius converted a penalty in the 52nd minute to cancel out Ademola Lookman's first-half opener for Atletico before the speedy Madrid forward grabbed the



winner with a curling strike in the 72nd. "Another great game by Vini, it was an example of his character, his talent. It was a great goal that gave us a win in a difficult moment. I am lucky to

Hyo Joo Kim holds off Nelly Korda for wire-to-wire win in Founders Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Menlo Park (USA)

Hyo Joo Kim held off Nelly Korda at Sharon Heights to complete a wire-to-wire victory in the Fortinet Founders Cup.

Her opening five-stroke advantage gone after 10 holes, Kim regained the lead on the next hole and ended up with a one-shot margin after a closing bogey.

"I don't think I was necessarily shaken up or my emotions were all over the place," Kim said through a translator. "I was just trying to keep my focus on my shots and what I was doing."

Kim shot a 1-over 73 for a 16-under 272 total. The 30-year-old South Korean player also won the 2015



event in Phoenix. She has eight LPGA Tour titles to go along with 14 KLPGA Tour victories. Korda closed with a 69. The American won the season opener in Florida, then skipped the Asia swing. "Obviously, something like 17 stings, so it is what it

is," Korda said. "It's golf. It's a quick turnaround. There is next week. So, just going to take all the positives."

Earlier Sunday, brother Sebastian Korda beat top-ranked Carlos Alcaraz in the third round of the Miami Open tennis tournament.

Manchester City dominate Arsenal to win English League Cup



JAMES ROBSONAP
■ London

The first major domestic trophy of the season is Manchester City's. And after a dominant 2-0 win against Arsenal in the English League Cup final on Sunday, it may not be the last.

Manchester-born Nico O'Reilly sealed victory with both goals in the second half at Wembley Stadium. The win could also have delivered a psychological blow in the race for the Premier League title as Pep Guardiola aims to chase down Arsenal's nine-point lead at the top of the standings.

"(It's an) unbelievable feeling to win a final and to beat this team. We know how good they are," O'Reilly told Sky Sports. "We need to build on it now, it'll give us momentum."

This was serial trophy-winner Guardiola flexing his muscles. It was his 16th major trophy as City manager and a record fifth League Cup. He has won 34 career titles as a manager including his time at Barcelona and Bayern Munich. And, once again, he was stamping out Arsenal manager Mikel Arteta's own

ambitions, having twice beaten his former assistant to the league title in recent years.

"I'm really pleased because I know the opponent we played. Mikel created a team that is almost unbeatable," Guardiola said. "Every time you win a title it looks more difficult than in the past. It is really difficult for many reasons."

Arsenal remains favorite to be crowned league champion this season for the first time since 2004, given its big lead. But with second-place City having a game in hand and the teams still to play each other in Manchester at the Etihad Stadium, the picture could look very different in the coming weeks.

City's win also ended Arsenal's bid this season for an unprecedented quadruple of major trophies by an English team – including the Premier League, Champions League and FA Cup.

"I'm very sad. It is a very hard one to take, especially for our players and our supporters because we know how much it means to them and how much we want that," Arteta said. (AP)

DC hopeful as Starc awaits CA’s NOC for IPL opener

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Cricket Australia (CA) is yet to grant a No Objection Certificate (NOC) to Mitchell Starc for his IPL stint with Delhi Capitals, the franchise said on Monday, but remains hopeful the lead pacer will join the squad before their tournament opener on April 1.

In a media interaction, Delhi Capitals Axar Patel, cricket director Venugopal Rao and head coach Hemang Badani fielded multiple questions on the availability of their pace spearhead. Starc had taken 14 wickets in 11 games last season.

“We are waiting to get

the NOC from Cricket Australia. Once we get that, we will know when he will join us,” said Badani.

“We are in constant touch with CA. He has been bowling, he had a bowled few days back.

Unless Cricket Australia signs off on him that he is fit to play, there is little a franchise can do,” said the coach when asked if the delay in issuing NOC was due to fitness or workload management.

Sitting next to him, Rao added: “He is coming, it is just a question of getting the NOC from Cricket Australia. They are monitoring, we are monitoring (his fitness and workload).”

Flanked by Rao and



Badani, Axar was asked if he was ready to play T Natarajan in Starc’s place if the latter doesn’t arrive in the time for team’s first game against LSG in Lucknow on April 1.

“It is tough to answer that at this stage. If Starc gets NOC, he can come before the first match also. We are waiting for that update. If he doesn’t come there is no temptation to replace a left arm pacer with a left arm pacer.

“It is about team combination. Having said that, Natarajan is doing really well and is 100 percent fit,” said Axar.

Natarajan had played just two games last season due to a shoulder injury.



It’s inconceivable: CA refuses to take more control over Test pitch

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Melbourne

Cricket Australia has ruled out taking greater control over Test pitch preparation, insisting that local curators are best placed to deliver good, unique surfaces despite criticism following the costly Ashes series earlier this year.

Following the two-day finishes in the Perth and MCG Tests, which cost CA nearly AUD 15 million in revenue, the quality of the state pitches came under intense scrutiny. CA CEO Todd Green had also admitted that short Tests are “bad for business”.

But despite the losses, CA is reluctant to opt for a centralised model.

“It’s inconceivable that we could ever control much more than we do now,” CA’s head of operations Peter Roach was quoted as saying by Australian Associated Press. “In England, you could put in a central curator to go around or New Zealand, or South Africa, because the

wickets and the clays and the climates are so similar.

“In Australia, because they’re so different, you could put the best curator in Australia to a different venue and all of a sudden they’re an also-ran for a while.

“Because they wouldn’t know the characteristics and the climate and how those pitches respond to that,” Roach added. CA currently employs consultant Les Burdett to assist curators, but does not dictate what kind of pitches to be prepared. They, however, encourage curators to prepare pitches that last at least four days and offer a balanced contest between bat and ball, without resulting in dull draws, Roach said CA wants states to embrace their venues’ unique characteristics rather than produce uniform pitches.

“The difference of our pitches across from west to east to north to south is so pronounced and it’s something that we don’t want to change,” Roach said.

ICC CEO hails cricket’s global growth

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India remains the “anchor market” but cricket is becoming “incontrovertibly” globalised, said ICC CEO Sanjog Gupta as he applauded the “fearless” performance of Associate countries during the recent T20 World Cup, describing their growth as the “signal of a maturing” global sport.

India won the tournament, that featured 20 teams and was dotted with some gutsy show by lesser-fancied sides like tournament debutant Italy, USA, Nepal and Zimbabwe.



“India is indeed the anchor market of world cricket. Its enormous fan base, financial strength, and time-tested affinity for the sport provide a platform that benefits the entire ecosystem. What is incontrovertibly evident at ICC events, however, is that the ship is sailing far beyond any single location,” he wrote in a column for ‘WPP Media Sporting Nation XIII Edition’.

“The ICC Men’s T20 World Cup 2026 saw spirited performances from Associate Nations...Countries such as Nepal, Italy and the USA captured global attention by playing fearless cricket.

“At the same time, traditional competitors like Sri Lanka and Zimbabwe demonstrated their too often-overlooked pedigree by storming into the Super 8s. Such moments are more than just upsets on the field; they are signals of a maturing

Arundhati Reddy, Sahibzada Farhan win player of the month for February

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

India medium pacer Arundhati Reddy was on Monday named the ICC Player of the Month for February for her fine performances in a T20I series in Australia.

Pakistan opener Sahibzada Farhan was named the ICC Player of the Month for his extra-ordinary performances in the men’s T20 World Cup.

Reddy shone with her fine seam bowling Down Under, helping India win their three-match T20I



series against Australia 2-1.

She was the leading wicket-taker in the series with hauls of 4/22, 2/30 and 2/35, finishing with an average of 10.87 and an economy rate of 7.25.

“It’s a real honour to be

named ICC Player of the Month, and even more special knowing I was able to contribute to a T20I series win in Australia. Beating Australia on their home turf is never easy, which makes this award even more meaningful,” Reddy said.

“This series win has given our team a huge boost of confidence as we build towards the ICC Women’s T20 World Cup in England and Wales this summer. We’ve got a well-balanced squad, and I believe we’ll be a team to watch,” she added.

Akliouche shines as Monaco beats Lyon and Lille wins at Marseille

JEROME PUGMIRE ■ Paris

Maghnes Akliouche scored a brilliant individual goal and American forward Folarin Balogun netted a penalty as Monaco rallied to win 2-1 at Lyon on Sunday for a sixth straight league victory.

Coach Paulo Fonseca’s slumping Lyon side is seven games without a win overall having equaled a club record with 13 straight victories.

Sixth-place Monaco is only one point behind fourth-place Lyon and fifth-place Lille in the race for a Champions League spot next season and faces third-place Marseille after the international break.

The top three qualify directly for the Champions League and the team finishing fourth

goes through qualifying.

Marseille opens the doorMarseille lost 2-1 at home to Lille, which scored a late winner through Olivier Giroud. Monaco can move level on points with Marseille if it wins their match on April 5. Marseille forward Mason Greenwood went off early on after being barged over at full speed by Calvin Verdonk. He was replaced by Ethan Nwaneri, who scored with a neat half-volley from Igor Paixao’s left-wing cross. The 19-year-old Nwaneri is on loan from Premier League leader Arsenal.

Lille goalkeeper Berke Ozer went off in first-half stoppage time after taking an accidental blow to the face from Marseille striker Pierre-Emerick Aubameyang



as they challenged for the ball. Ozer was replaced by Arnaud Bodart.

Another high-profile error from Marseille defender Leonardo Balerdi gifted Lille a 49th-minute equalizer.

typical downward header.

Lyon’s slump continues Things looked good for Lyon when Brazil forward Endrick set up midfielder Pavel Sulc in the 42nd minute, skipping past two defenders down the right before cutting the ball back to the Czech midfielder near the penalty spot.

But Endrick went for goal himself in the 57th and saw his shot cleared near the line with teammate Corentin Tolisso unmarked.

Akliouche equalised five minutes later when he controlled a long pass with one touch to cut inside Clinton Mata and curled a shot into the top-right corner.

Akliouche then won a penalty after drawing a foul from Tolisso and Balogun sent the goalkeeper the wrong way.

The penalty was awarded despite a video review showing Endrick had his jersey pulled by Monaco captain Denis Zakaria in the buildup to the penalty.

It was a second error from the officials, who failed to spot a headbutt from Lyon left back Nicolas Tagliafico to the side of Akliouche’s head. Tagliafico raised his right arm as he was running alongside Akliouche as if to disguise the intent.

Tagliafico was sent off in the 89th for a violent lunge on Lamine Camara, whose left foot buckled under him.

Immobile gets going Veteran Italian striker Ciro Immobile finally got off the mark for new club Paris FC in a 3-2 home win over Le Havre. (AP)

Candidates: Ukraine’s Anna Muzychuk steps in for Humpy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Ukraine’s Anna Muzychuk has replaced Koneru Humpy in the upcoming Candidates Tournament in Cyprus after the Indian Grandmaster withdrew citing safety concerns due to the host country’s proximity to the ongoing West Asia conflict.

The tournament, which will determine the challengers for the world championship crowns currently held by D Gukesh (Open) and Ju Wenjun (women), is scheduled to begin in Paphos on Saturday.

Humpy, a two-time Women’s World Rapid Champion, pulled out of the event despite assurances from organisers, citing concerns over personal safety.

Earlier this month, a British air base in Cyprus was targeted in a drone attack, heightening security fears in the region. In a statement, FIDE confirmed that Muzychuk had been invited as Humpy’s replacement.

“In accordance with the tournament regulations, her (Humpy’s) place was offered to the next highest finisher in the Women’s Events Series 2024-25 who has not yet secured qualification. As a result, Anna Muzychuk (Ukraine) will join the tournament,” FIDE said. Muzychuk is a former Women’s World Rapid champion (2016) and a two-time Women’s World Blitz champion (2014, 2016).

She is also a former World Championship finalist and among the few women to have crossed the 2600 rating



mark. Earlier, explaining her decision, Humpy said personal safety remained her top priority.

“After deep reflection, I have taken the difficult decision to withdraw from the FIDE Women’s Candidates Tournament,” Humpy said in a statement on ‘X’.

“No event, no matter how important, can come before personal safety and well-being. Despite the assurances provided, I do not feel fully secure under the current circumstances. This is a painful but necessary decision, and I stand by it,” she added.

Humpy risks a 10,000 Euro

fine for her decision but FIDE is yet to decide on it.

Nakamura also expresses concerns: The 38-year-old Indian is not alone in voicing safety concerns despite FIDE’s assurances that there is nothing even “remotely dangerous” to warrant a change of venue.

American Grandmaster Hikaru Nakamura, who is understood to have been in the island nation for the past two months in the run up to the tournament, also flagged issues, pointing to recent power outages in parts of Cyprus.

“It’s not a good sign when power goes out completely in parts of Cyprus and doesn’t come back for an extended period of time,” the world No. 2 wrote on Sunday.

Alker wins Cologuard Classic with playoff birdie for 2nd straight year

STEVE BITTENBENDER
■ Tucson (USA)

Steve Alker won the Cologuard Classic with a birdie on the first hole of a playoff for the second straight year, beating Padraig Harrington with a 4-footer Sunday in mid-90 degree heat.

Last year at La Paloma, Alker beat Long Island club pro Jason Caron with a 12-foot putt on the first extra hole. Alker won for the 11th time in 100 career starts on the PGA Tour Champions.

The 54-year-old New Zealander was nine strokes back after opening with an even-par 71, then shot a



62 on Saturday to pull within two.

“I just made some simple mistakes the first round,” Alker said. “A couple three-putts and missed the odd green here and there, and that was kind of silly stuff. I tidied that up. I knew my game

was in good shape.”

Alker closed with a 65 to post at 15-under 198. Harrington, playing behind Alker in the final group, hit his approach long and bogeyed the par-4 18th — missing a 10-foot come-backer. (PTI)

New-look India aim to set tone for season at Asia Cup in Bangkok

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bangkok

India will kick-start the new international archery season with a fresh-faced squad at the Asia Cup Stage 1, banking on a blend of exciting teenagers and returning veterans instead of established stars in the tournament beginning here on Tuesday.

The team will be without Deepika Kumari, Ankita Bhakat, Dhiraj Bommadevara,

Tarundeep Rai, Jyothi Surekha Vennam and Abhishek Verma as the Indian think-tank wants to use the continental opener to test bench strength ahead of a packed season culminating in the Asian Games in Japan come September-October.

The top Indian archers, however, will be back in action with the World Cup’s first two legs in Puebla (Mexico) and Shanghai April onwards.

Despite the absence of its

marquee archers, the overall champions would be firm favourites. In the last year’s opening leg, India topped the tally with eight medals, including five gold. The team will look to maintain its dominance on the Asia Cup circuit which has been given a miss by the world heavyweights South Korea.

In Korea’s, India’s main rivals would be China and Bangladesh. In recurve men’s section Australia’s Ryan Tyack



is the top-ranked archer with a ranking of world No.27, while the women’s section has Russian-born neutral athlete Nurinisso Makhmudova (No. 45) as the highest ranked archer.

The spotlight will firmly be on the formidable Indian men’s compound unit, spearheaded by world No.4 Rishabh Yadav alongside Asian Games gold medallist Prathamesh Jawkar and the seasoned Rajat Chauhan.

They will look to defend the title. Last year, Kushal Dalal was the individual champion. He, along with Manav Jadhao and Ganesh Thirumuru, had won the team gold.

Yadav, one of India’s most consistent performers, will be keen to build on his historic World Championships gold in the team event last year.

The women’s compound side will enter a rebuilding phase in the absence of Jyothi, with 20-year-old Chikitha

Taniparthi leading the charge

Ranked 37th in the world, she returns to a venue where she won a team bronze last year and will be supported by comeback archers Tejal Salve and Swati Dudhwal, along with the experienced Raj Kaur.

None from the women’s compound side managed to win a medal in individual event in 2025 and Chikitha and Co. will look to make it count this time.